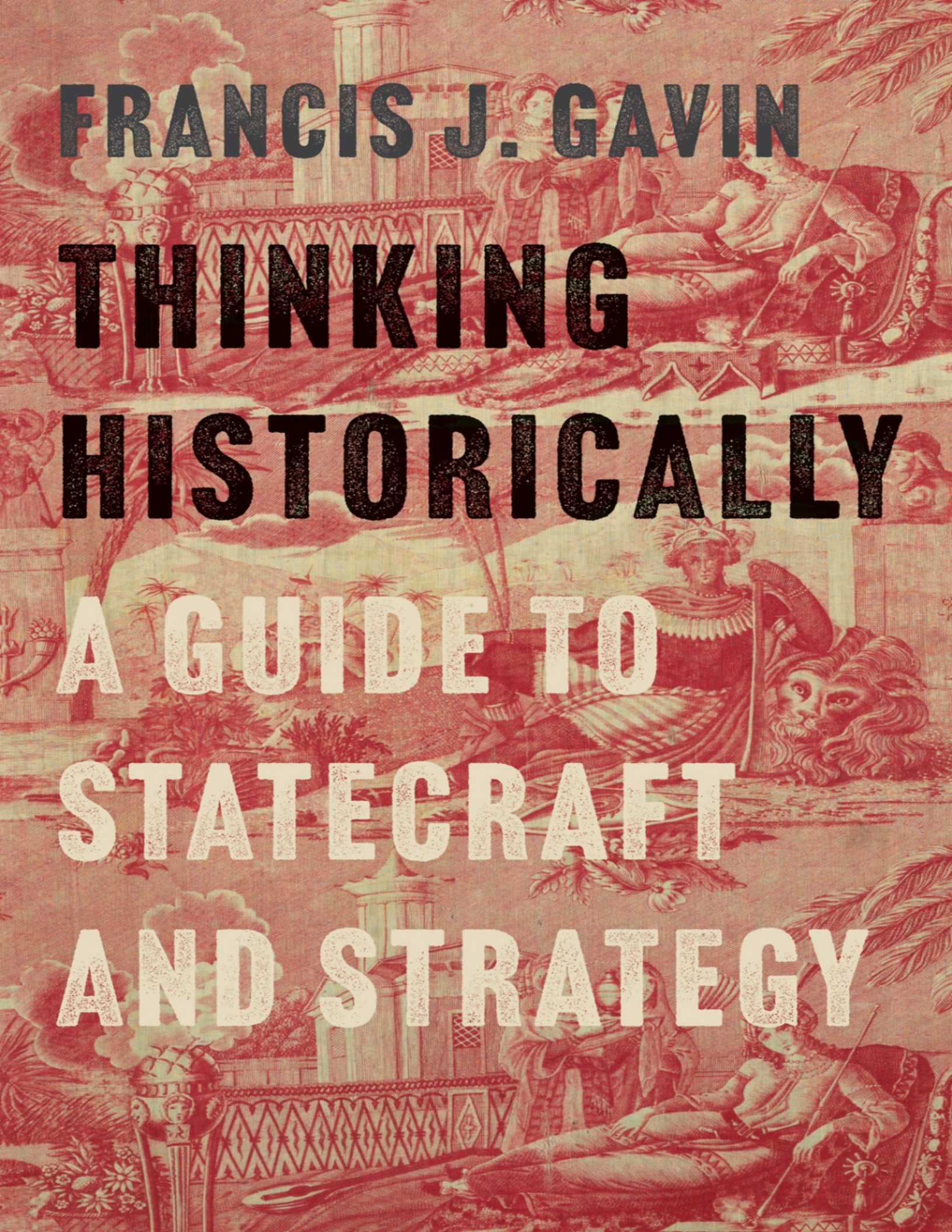




**FRANCIS J. GAVIN**

**THINKING**

**HISTORICALLY**

**A GUIDE TO**

**STATECRAFT**

**AND STRATEGY**



# Thinking Historically

## *A Guide to Statecraft and Strategy*

FRANCIS J. GAVIN

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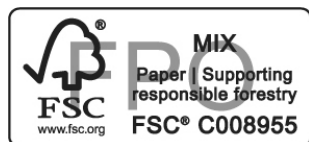
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*To Marc, who taught me history  
To Phil, who taught me policy  
And to Jim, who taught me both*

# Contents

*Preface*

*Acknowledgments*

ONE. Thinking Historically

TWO. History for Policy

THREE. Questioning the Cold War

FOUR. Insights and Tools

FIVE. The History Checklist

*Postscript: What Is to Be Done?*

*Notes*

*Index*

# Preface

A rigorous understanding of the past provides insights and tools that enable better choices in the present. This is especially true in the extraordinarily consequential worlds of statecraft and strategy. This book proposes ways to apply historical knowledge to understand and navigate the complex, often confusing world around us.

It may seem obvious that we should employ history to improve decision-making, but it is rarely done. History is more often misused, deployed ineffectively, or exploited for problematic and even nefarious purposes. Our times favor other ways of knowing the world over historical thinking. And the academic discipline of history has not helped: in recent years it has de-emphasized the history of statecraft and policy in favor of other subjects.

The lack of historical thought devoted to statecraft is puzzling. Making difficult, consequential choices about an unknowable future is so challenging that decision-makers should be eager for whatever insight or knowledge they can get that will make the process easier or more successful. History offers an almost endless reservoir of how such critical choices were made in the past, which ones went well, and which went poorly. One might also think that academic historians would be thrilled if people making such choices relied on their scholarship and pedagogy to improve their processes and outcomes. For reasons I will discuss, however, historians rarely engage decision-makers, and decision-makers seldom consult historians. This is unfortunate, as good historical work captures, perhaps better than any other discipline, the challenges and complexities that decision-makers face.

There are many extraordinary histories that chronicle and evaluate key episodes related to decision-making. A handful of outstanding books explore and illuminate the craft of history. Few works, however, deal explicitly with how to employ historical thinking for policy. One classic in the field remains valuable: Richard E. Neustadt and Ernest R. May's *Thinking in Time*, published almost forty years ago. In this book, I build upon Neustadt and May's insights to make broader and more ambitious claims than they did about the value of a historical sensibility and thinking historically.

Each of us mines the past for our own purposes. How can it be done better? I begin by defining two key interconnected concepts that shape the argument: first, a historical sensibility, which is the foundation for the second, the act of thinking

historically. Critical to both is an understanding of how outstanding historians pursue their craft.

This is not as easy as it sounds. History is not like most other scholarly disciplines. Beyond a concern for the past, the field lacks a shared and transparent sense of itself—its methods, values, and how it evaluates what its practitioners do—that can be conveyed simply and coherently to the larger world. Unlike, say, neurosurgery or mechanical engineering, there is no accepted path to excellence in historical thinking or clear way to evaluate it. Despite this vagueness at the discipline's core, one can deepen one's historical sensibility by better understanding how historians do their work and make important choices about their subjects, the research strategies they employ, and how they wrestle with questions of perspective, time horizons, agency, and causality.

[Chapter 2](#) takes up the benefits and drawbacks of using history for policy. Compared to other epistemologies, such as international relations theory, law, or economics, history provides a different and, I contend, more powerful view into issues of statecraft and strategy. A historical sensibility can also help identify and guard against the misuse of history, a practice as bad if not worse than ignoring history altogether. And despite some skepticism and occasional discomfort with each other, historians and policymakers share clear and deep commonalities in what they encounter and try to understand.

In [chapter 3](#) I deploy a historical sensibility to evaluate the core assumptions behind a widely shared, stylized narrative about a historical episode even experts believe is widely understood: the Cold War. By exploring the different ways of answering simple queries—when the Cold War began and ended, for example, or how and why it ended, who or what drove it, how it interacted with other forces in world politics after the Second World War, and what role policy played, as opposed to other factors—we begin to see how a historical sensibility challenges our beliefs about agency, causality, perspectives, and time horizons.

The exercise of reexamining and rethinking our basic understanding of international politics in the second half of the twentieth century shows how certain historical tools and insights—or ways to think historically—give us a better understanding of how statecraft and strategy can shape the world. This is the focus of the fourth chapter. The practice of thinking historically forces the decision-maker to think deeply and rigorously about causality and agency. It reveals competing spatial and temporal horizons, and it demands precision and guards against “paralysis by analysis” while providing the means to effectively integrate divergent historical streams and narratives.

One of the most powerful tools this style of thinking gives us is the ability to ask better, more probing questions. The fifth chapter offers a “historian's checklist”—similar to the lists developed by pilots and surgeons to avoid common but potentially fatal mistakes. This checklist consists of twelve questions that all analysts,

policymakers, and historians should ask themselves when confronting consequential decisions of statecraft and strategy. Asking and answering these questions will not tell policymakers precisely what they should do or what will happen. But the checklist will better prepare them to navigate the radical uncertainty and complexity presented by the future and allow them to adapt and change course more adeptly when circumstances warrant.

In a postscript, I acknowledge the enormous challenges of persuading and training practitioners to embrace historical thinking in matters of statecraft and strategy. Some challenges are on the demand side: the larger culture often rejects a historical sensibility, and many decision-makers fail to recognize and embrace the merits of thinking historically. But the biggest obstruction remains on the supply side, where the deep pathologies of the academic discipline of history and the perverse incentive system within universities prevent a more mutually beneficial relationship devoted to historically informed statecraft and strategy. I conclude the book with suggestions for how this situation might be changed.

Broadly speaking, this book is written for anyone interested in understanding history, world politics, grand strategy, and national security policy. It might especially interest those who want to bring these worlds closer together. I focus on statecraft and strategy because mistakes in this area can affect millions of people and the future of nations. But I also hope that the book is useful to decision-makers in all areas of life, from domestic policymakers to heads of nonprofits to business leaders evaluating how best to invest capital for future growth. Using the past to make better choices will appeal to anyone who makes consequential but difficult choices while facing radical uncertainty about the future. A focus on the uses of history, and especially what can and cannot be known, should help anyone as they navigate the “foreign,” meaning anything they don’t fully understand. Acquiring a historical sensibility and learning how to think historically should be a core part of every citizen’s education.

In other words, there is something here for anyone. When I think of the true target audience for this book, however, I reflect upon my far younger self as a college graduate, curious about and trying to make sense of a complicated, rapidly changing, sometimes dangerous, often wondrous time. It is for those younger persons—and all people curious about the world—that this book is written.



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Jim Steinberg, in addition to being a renowned statesman, a visionary academic leader, and great friend, knows more about the intersection between history and policy than anyone I've ever met. It is to Marc, Phil, and Jim, who exemplify thinking historically, that this book is dedicated.

# 1

## Thinking Historically

On November 22, 2011, the *New York Times* published a short Op-Doc, “The Umbrella Man,” directed by famed documentary filmmaker Errol Morris, to mark the forty-eighth anniversary of the assassination of President John F. Kennedy in Dallas, Texas.<sup>1</sup> In the six-and-a-half-minute video, Morris employs his Interrotron camera to create his trademark intimacy while interviewing Josiah “Tink” Thompson, the author of a book titled *Six Seconds in Dallas*, on the famous Zapruder film that accidentally captured the assassination.<sup>2</sup> Backed by a haunting score by minimalist composer Arvo Pärt and spliced with snippets of film from the fateful day, the video tells the story of a shadowy figure called the “umbrella man.”

Who was the umbrella man? In the Zapruder film and other films and photographs from that day, an upright figure can be seen standing on the so-called grassy knoll, holding an open black umbrella, moments before bullets are fired into the president’s motorcade. The image is arresting; the weather in Dallas was sunny and warm, and the sight of a lone man under an umbrella would have been disconcerting even if an assassination had not taken place right in front of him seconds later. As Thompson says, “In all of Dallas, there appears to be exactly one person standing under an open black umbrella.... Can anyone come up with a non-sinister explanation for this?”

Writing in the *New Yorker*’s “Talk of the Town” column in December 1967, writer John Updike suggested that the mystery surrounding who the umbrella man was and why he was on the grassy knoll “dangles around history’s neck like a fetish.”<sup>3</sup> None of the authorities—the Dallas police, the Secret Service, the Federal Bureau of Investigation, or the Warren Commission—ever located or identified him or could explain his baffling appearance. Given all the mystery surrounding the assassination, it was only natural to suspect ominous motives. Who was the umbrella man, and what was he doing? Clearly, he must have been part of the conspiracy to kill the president. Perhaps the umbrella was a gun device of some sort, firing a flechette into the president’s throat. Or maybe it was a signal to the actual shooter? In the vacuum of uncertainty, it did not seem unreasonable to make a causal link between the shadowy figure, his umbrella, and the day’s fateful events.

Or not. In 1978, Louie Steven Witt reluctantly came forward to the House Select Committee on Assassinations to admit he was the umbrella man. In 1963, Witt explained, he worked near Dealey Plaza and took a walk every day during his lunch hour. “I was going to use this umbrella to heckle the President’s motorcade.... Being a conservative-type fellow, I sort of placed him in the liberal camp and I was just going to kind of do a little heckling.” The umbrella was a symbolic protest.

MR. WITT: ... It had something to do with the—when the senior Mr. Kennedy was Ambassador to England, and the Prime Minister, some activity they had had in appeasing Hitler. The umbrella that the Prime Minister of England came back with got to be a symbol in some manner with the British people. By association, it got transferred to the Kennedy family, and, as I understood, it was a sore spot with the Kennedy family, like I said, in coffee break conversations someone had mentioned, I think it is one of the towns in Arizona, it is Tucson or Phoenix, that someone had been out at the airport or some place where some members of the Kennedy family came through and they were rather irritated by the fact that they were brandishing the umbrellas. This is how the idea sort of got stuck in my mind.

MR. FAUNTROY. Is it true that what you felt was that Mr. Kennedy would be sensitive because of the appeasement image of the umbrella as related to his father?

MR. WITT. Not the appeasement thing. It was just—excuse me—I just understood that it was sort of a sore spot with them and this was just one thing. I personally never thought too much of liberal politics in general. In this case the Kennedy family just happened to be in office.

MR. FAUNTROY. I see. And it had no relationship in your own thinking between Mr. Kennedy’s posture with; say, the Russians?

MR. WITT. No. No. No. That was not it at all.<sup>4</sup>

Thompson calls this explanation “just wacky enough to be true.” It is a stark reminder to anyone studying the past that “if you have any fact which you think is really sinister, is really obviously a fact that can point to some sinister underpinning, hey, forget it, man. Because you can never on your own think up all the non-sinister, perfectly valid explanations for that fact. A cautionary tale.”

Talking about his film, Morris says that his interest in the assassination emerged from his curiosity about the nature of historical investigation and how to assess evidence. “Why, after 48 years, are people still quarreling and quibbling about this case? What is it about this case that has led not to *a* solution, but to the endless proliferation of *possible* solutions?”<sup>5</sup> Thompson, summarizing Updike, says that historical research may have two parts: the macro level “where things obey natural laws and usual things happen and unusual things don’t happen”; and the world “under a



microscope” where you will find “a whole dimension of weird, incredible things going on.”<sup>6</sup>

The mystery of the umbrella man is both extraordinary and not. Sometimes events reveal themselves clearly, and motives and causes are fully understood. At other times, despite our best efforts, certainty about what happened and why remains frustratingly elusive. No economic model, regression analysis, physicist’s theorem, legal theory, or law of chemistry can fully make sense of the umbrella man or provide the clarity we seek.

More than most fields of inquiry and explanation, history is comfortable operating under the shadow of uncertainty, divergent perspectives, and disputed explanations. Historians recognize that motives can be ambiguous and unclear, evidence inconclusive, direct causal connections frustratingly elusive, and the meaning and long-term significance of events ever-changing. Memories fade, and people make records that are inaccurate or misleading, both intentionally and not. Events appear both unique and similar to those in the past. Stories that make sense on one level are confounding on others.

Historians understand the natural human desire to make sense of a complex universe through narrative, airtight explanations, and tidy if sometimes hasty conclusions. The longing for certainty about causality, agency, fact, and meaning makes it hard for us to live with stories that are incomplete and contradictory. How people, as decision-makers and citizens, navigate uncertainty, complexity, competing perspectives, incomplete or contradictory evidence, macro and micro lenses, and dueling beliefs is extraordinarily important yet rarely discussed. This is the universe that historians regularly inhabit. In the face of such a world, where others accept and even embrace incomplete stories or consensus, historians remains dogged in their unending search to uncover new evidence, other causes and actors, divergent perspectives, different and more complete narratives, and more robust if complex explanations, in an effort to find and convey greater meaning in our past.

### Why Do We Remember the Past?

Almost everything that has ever happened, and almost everyone who has ever lived, is forgotten. We recall and record only the tiniest fraction of the past, amounting to only a sliver of the time humans have been on the planet and barely a whisper of the life of the Earth. This act of remembering, chronicling, assessing, and trying to make sense of that past is, perhaps more than anything else, what makes us human.

Why do we choose to remember what we do, in the ways that we do? There are many reasons: to commemorate and celebrate, to generate identity and bond a community, to better understand the world around us, to create meaning and purpose, to seek justice and improve our world, and to mark and evaluate how and why things change—and don’t change—over time. There are irresolvable debates about what kinds

of marking of the past count as history as opposed to tradition, mythmaking, theology, propaganda, or nostalgia. There has long been a belief, however, that the close study of the past holds vital clues to navigating the dangers and opportunities in our present and future worlds and that excavating, evaluating, and effectively making use of those clues depends on the quality and vigor of our historical efforts.

One long-standing purpose of examining the past is for a self-contained political and socioeconomic group—which may be anything from a tribe to a nation to an empire—to chronicle, understand, and succeed in its relations with other collective entities. Despite the power of globalization throughout history, no all-encompassing world political organization or unified culture has ever developed, and different polities and societies have struggled to manage their interactions with other groups. Sometimes these “international” relations were constructive, peaceful, and even mutually beneficial, shaped by what we today might think of as statecraft. At other times, these relations were deadly and violent, driven by what we might think of today as strategy. More often than not, statecraft and strategy have been inextricably interconnected. The stakes in understanding why war did or did not emerge, and how to prevail if it did, were enormous. Equally important was generating insights on how to best navigate relations with other groups to ensure survival, stability, and success.

This was certainly the goal of arguably the first, foundational work of modern history, Thucydides’s *History of the Peloponnesian War*. This classic has at least three notable, even revolutionary aspects. First, Thucydides set out to understand the cause and course of a decades-long war that ultimately brought ruin to his polity, the great city-state of Athens. In the process, he examined the statecraft and strategy of all of the major participants. Second, he strove to make his account as objective as he could, at least as he understood the term. Whether he achieved this goal—or whether any historian can—is of course debatable. But he did not set out to selectively present the facts so as to glorify or demonize particular leaders, polities, divinities, or systems of governance. His aim, as difficult then as now, was to uncover the elusive truth, with the idea that such a history might prove instructive for others. Third, *The History of the Peloponnesian War* crafts a historical narrative where the end result is not predetermined. No gods, destiny, or historical fate produced an inevitable outcome. The choices made by leaders and polities mattered. But events were also determined by forces that no leader or populace could have foreseen, let alone controlled. Athens’s fall was dictated as much by an unexpected public health crisis—a plague—that its citizens could do little to combat as it was by ineffective strategy or statecraft. For Thucydides, history was shaped by a mixture of choice and structure, linear developments and the mysterious, unexpected, and explosive, between steadfast laws and principles and uncertain, unpredictable outcomes.

*The History of the Peloponnesian War* began a long, extraordinary tradition, among both enlightened publics and individuals tasked with making collective political decisions, of trying to understand history so as to construct effective statecraft and

strategies to navigate a dangerous and uncertain world. The consequences of war and peace are profound: they are perhaps the most important variable shaping outcomes from the personal to the global. Over the past century-plus, as the ferocity and lethality of conflict have grown and the benefits of peace become even more salient, this desire to comprehend and, if possible, minimize the effects of war has understandably increased enormously. The development and spread of thermonuclear devices, a weapon whose mass use could cripple if not end human civilization, makes this historical mission more pressing than ever.

Given this legacy, one might think that scholarly histories of statecraft and strategy would be prized and influential. There are few contemporary issues that do not have a deep connection to conflict and diplomacy. The world we inhabit, from technological developments to our systems of governance to our individual and collective identities, has been shaped by the consequences of war and our efforts to avoid it. Subjects ranging from modern medicine to art to civil rights to food and energy consumption to the sources of innovation cannot be fully understood independently of the history of war and peace. The consequences of statecraft and strategy go far beyond battlefields, the deliberations inside foreign offices, and treaties signed at international conferences. They cast an enormous shadow over every society, every nation, every individual on the planet. Yet we understand far less about these subjects than we should.

These are powerful and compelling reasons to examine the past for insights about statecraft and strategy. Unfortunately, this use of history has fallen out of fashion, both on the demand side—the decision-making world—and on the supply side—the world of university history departments. Political leaders and strategists in both the public and private sectors are today more likely to be trained in economics and political science, or in professional fields such as business or law, than in history. Many have had only a fleeting interaction with the discipline. Among academic historians, meanwhile, few see the scholarly study of statecraft and strategy as a worthwhile pursuit. Peruse the (rapidly declining) roster of tenured historians within the history departments in major research universities, and you will be struck by the paucity, even absence, of scholars engaged in questions of war and peace, diplomacy, and international relations. When historians do turn their attention to international relations, they often define it to exclude what most people understand as statecraft and strategy and write in a way that offers little that is useful or interesting to decision-makers or the wider public.

The decline of historical thinking is deeply unfortunate for the academic field of history and, more important, for the practice of grand strategy and foreign policy. This is especially tragic within the United States, where decision-makers with enormous power face extraordinarily complex and consequential choices about an uncertain future and are often desperate for the guidance and wisdom history can provide.

This book makes the case for the benefits of a greater historical awareness and to provide a sense of what historians do, how they think and make sense of the world, and why it matters. While these lessons can be applied more broadly, to any issue or subject

where the past is engaged to understand the present and the future, my argument focuses on how a deeper engagement with history can improve how we understand, evaluate, and even practice statecraft and strategy. The claim is simple but powerful: a deep and rigorous engagement with the practice of history provides a better way to see, know, and act in a world where decision-makers confront complexity and radical uncertainty about the future.

There are, of course, spirited and important theoretical and ideological debates about how international relations work or should work, the causes of war and peace, and how various countries, including the United States, should behave in the world. While I hold views on these questions, in this book I do not argue on behalf of any particular perspective or school of thought on why wars happen or are avoided, what factors shape outcomes we care about in international relations, or what are the best strategic and diplomatic pursuits and outcomes. Nor do I offer a particular philosophy of history, of which there are many. As I will emphasize throughout, a great and underappreciated characteristic of historical thinking is its tolerance for and even encouragement of multiple approaches to any given question.

### A Historical Sensibility, Then Thinking Historically

How can this claim that history can improve statecraft and strategy be redeemed? I offer a two-step process. First, I will show the power of a historical sensibility. Acquiring this expansive awareness and responsiveness, this conceptual lens, allows one to obtain and internalize critical virtues, including modesty, curiosity, sensitivity to context and circumstance, and a recognition of spatial and temporal perspective, allowing us to better see and know things about the world. Second, and building on this sensibility, I describe a set of skills, tools, and questions that are central to the act of thinking historically and that provide insights to generate better judgments and strategies to navigate a complex, often dangerous world.

*Historical sensibility* and *thinking historically* are closely related if not synonymous terms, and they are sometimes even interchangeable. Still, it is useful to distinguish between them. Historical sensibility may be thought of more as a temperament, a way of understanding. Thinking historically means applying that temperament to develop insights to aid decision-making. One can possess a historical sensibility yet not develop and deploy the tools that allow one to think historically about statecraft and strategy. On the other hand, it is impossible to think historically without acquiring a historical sensibility.

A historical sensibility might best be described as a deep familiarity with the past and its powerful and often unpredictable rhythms. It is less a narrowly defined field of study or a school of thought than a practice, a mental awareness, a discernment, a responsiveness to the past and how it unfolded into our present world, a *discipline* in the broadest sense. When looking at a question or a problem, a historical sensibility conditions the observer to focus on context and complexity while being sensitive to the

unexpected. This sensibility does not believe that the past always unfolded according to any identifiable algorithm but instead recognizes the unforeseen and surprises. That said, this sensibility should train the mind to recognize, identify, and analyze patterns and processes. Rarely does a historical sensibility suggest that the world is shaped by an all-encompassing “master idea” or driven by a unitary historical motor; it instead allows for many different causes for different things. Exploring what came before us should remind us how little we know and understand, both about the past and about ourselves and our own world, and this awareness should induce humility and prudence. As Sir Llewellyn Woodward explained, history reminds us that “our ignorance is very deep. We know just a little about a very small fraction of the human past.”<sup>7</sup>

We might think of a historical sensibility as a mode of thinking, a way of framing the past that tries to make sense of the present and future, a recognition that history shapes all parts of our world, including how we understand and make sense of it. It reminds us that we are a part of the same history we study and cannot escape it. This is true for historians as well; the very practice of history has its own history, as do all the other modes of understanding the world. A historical sensibility also expands our notions of what we think professional historians do: it goes beyond simply collecting evidence from archives or other primary sources to reconstruct and weave narratives about what came before. A historical sensibility, in other words, is about more than simply accumulating facts and telling stories. As Gordon S. Wood eloquently stated, “To possess a historical sense does not mean simply to possess information about the past. It means to have a different consciousness, a historical consciousness, to have incorporated into our minds a mode of understanding that profoundly influences the way we look at the world.”<sup>8</sup>

A historical sensibility is not attached to any particular historical school of thought or method. Historians possess wonderfully dissimilar and often conflicting sets of interpretations and tools for making sense of the past. This diversity of approaches often frustrates professional historians and confuses those outside the profession. I believe that this diversity can be a great strength. Furthermore, the historical sensibility takes one well beyond mining the past for situations that resemble one’s current dilemma or simply importing and applying the “lessons of history” to the present. A historical sensibility should actually guard against crude efforts to cut and paste past events onto our understanding of the present and future. A truer understanding of the past allows us to recognize when events and phenomena are novel and unique and when analogies from the past are more likely to confuse or deceive us than to provide insight.

What are the qualities of this orientation? A historical sensibility includes several characteristics.

First, individuals who possess a historical sensibility tolerate and even appreciate uncertainty, surprise, and unintended consequences and are comfortable with indeterminacy and multicausal explanations. This is hard to do: we do not always like



the unknown, and we often go to great lengths to generate hard and fast conclusions about how the world works and why. Certainty and predictability are very appealing. The desire for certainty, while often exemplary when examining the natural and physical world (although certainty is notoriously elusive at the edges of the sciences, too), can be less helpful and even misleading when one is trying to understand the social, cultural, and political realms, where easily embracing certainty can blind us to the unexpected. Understandably, we expect the future to look like the past, and it often does. A historical sensibility complicates those assumptions and forces us to live with and appreciate complexity and ambiguity. The past matters, not always because it repeats itself but sometimes because it does not.

History makes the unfamiliar familiar while revealing the unfamiliar in what we thought was well understood. As Hannah Arendt said about thinking more broadly, this sensibility should force us to “unfreeze” concepts that have been hardened into familiarity.<sup>9</sup> It leads us to seek the origins and explanations for events, phenomena, and practices that we believed we understood or would otherwise take for granted and to do the same for things that seem unprecedented or out of the norm. It provides an empathy (though not necessarily a sympathy) for the past, a willingness to understand historical subjects as products of a particular time and place. We try to imagine ourselves in the position of those who came before us, to understand their circumstances and dilemmas and the conditions that marked their worlds.

A historical sensibility recognizes and wrestles with the ethical dilemmas of historical judgment. History demands that we take our historical subjects seriously, on their own terms and in their own worlds, less with the aim of praising or casting blame but to better understand why and how they made the decisions they did and to generate insights for our own time. Doing so can be uncomfortable. It does not mean that we suspend moral judgment, about either the past or the present. Fixing a historical lens on past norms and practices, however, should make us far less confident that we in the present have acquired universal, timeless insight into right and wrong. If people in the past could be mistaken, what makes us think that our contemporary attitudes, beliefs, and practices won't be similarly scrutinized and criticized in the future? A historical sensibility suggests that imagining future historical judgments might force us to work harder to understand and improve our behavior today.

A historical sensibility also makes us conscious of the powerful hold history exerts—both on ourselves and on those who come from different nations, cultures, and backgrounds. In the same way that historians sharply disagree about the past and what it means, different nations, cultures, and identity groupings may have fundamentally different understandings of their own past and of history generally. Familiarity with competing histories allows the observer to note and recognize these differences and to better understand the sources of disagreement among different social, cultural, and

political entities. A historical sensibility acknowledges the fundamental importance of the observer's perspective, both in time and in place.

To be clear, this sensibility is not synonymous with the idea that there is no truth or that reality is simply constructed, although there are postmodern historical methods that do take such an approach. Historians possess a deep reverence for facts and evidence, and they recognize that many of the processes that shape human life apply at all times and in all places. But though historians strive for an elusive objectivity, they admit that the who, what, and when of observers—even and perhaps especially if the observers are historians—matter greatly in reconstructing and explaining the past. Finally, a historical sensibility recognizes and appreciates complexity and, though willing to be proven wrong, casts a skeptical eye on parsimonious models that claim to explain, generalize, and accurately predict complex social, cultural, and political behavior. It pushes against the human mind's propensity to seek simple explanations of how the world works.

Individuals and institutions that develop and deploy a historical sensibility make themselves more sensitive to context, chance, circumstance, and contingency and have a better sense of the role perspective plays in the outcomes we care about. The world would be a far better place if this temperament, this way of understanding the world, were widely taught, rewarded, and incorporated into personal, cultural, and institutional practices.

Successful statecraft and strategy, however, demand more than a sensibility. They require tools and insights to navigate a complex, interconnected world while making difficult, consequential choices in the face of radical uncertainty. There is a danger that a historical sensibility—with its focus on context, multicausal explanation, and perspective—can leave decision-makers dizzy and unmoored, paralyzed, unable to choose. Decision-makers must do more than admire a problem and see it from all sides. They must make difficult trade-offs and resolve dilemmas. In their understandable desire to get as much help as possible in making these choices, they might gravitate toward more muscular, parsimonious, and confident epistemologies to guide their decisions.

To think historically is to employ a distinct epistemology that offers powerful tools to assess causality and agency, evaluate difficult choices, weigh competing parallel histories and diverging perspectives, and generate more informed decision-making. Importantly, it dissolves the inertia that can plague anyone confronted by an overwhelming, confusing, often contradictory past by reminding decision-makers that to abstain from choosing is often as consequential as deciding to act decisively. Later chapters will offer the concrete tools, insights, and questions that allow for thinking historically, but overall, thinking historically may be thought of as a way of assessing, evaluating, and trying to make sense of the causal agents and forces shaping the world while exploiting a critical examination of the past to generate a better understanding of contemporary and future circumstances. Employing historical tools can help observers

assess and evaluate the arguments made about the world—both by practitioners and other academic fields, disciplines, and schools of thought—while weighing and evaluating consequential tradeoffs and difficult choices. If successful, thinking historically should help decision-makers, swamped by complexity and radical uncertainty, make better, more informed choices about an unknowable future.

## How People Engage the Past

There persists a widespread misunderstanding of what history is and what historians do, which undermines the appeal of a historical sensibility. Many of these misperceptions come down to one issue: most people and institutions believe that they already think historically and therefore require no additional expertise, training, insight, reflection, or special skills to do it well. Why listen to historians or think rigorously about the past if anyone can do it? This is not only wrong but puzzling: few people would offer their opinions about neurosurgery, aircraft design, or theoretical physics without recognizing the advanced training needed before one can credibly comment on these fields. History demands similar and at times greater levels of knowledge, training, and expertise. People should be as wary of accepting historical advice from a layperson as they would of allowing a random person to attempt heart surgery, but for a variety of reasons, they are not.

To a certain extent, this is understandable. Most human beings and societies possess two powerful, interwoven, and seemingly universal impulses: to be remembered and celebrated by those who come after them and to mark, commemorate, and assess their past. These acts—both remembering and being remembered—are accomplished in a number of ways, including song, dance, and poetry, art and ritual, structures and monuments, and oral traditions and customs passed between generations. The idea of creating a distinct profession of skilled thinkers—trained and tasked to study and write about the past in a rigorous, serious way, with at least the goal of some form of “objectivity”—is far rarer and has emerged as a distinct, credentialed profession only in recent times. In the United States, the notion of a professional historian as a scholar possessing advanced training and observing shared norms and practices emerged in leading research universities in the decades following the Civil War, borrowing practices and training from European, particularly German, universities.<sup>10</sup> In other words, while people have always been interested in recording and celebrating the past, the emergence of a historical scholarly “discipline” as we know it today, distinct and independent from the organs of rulers or religious institutions, is largely a modern phenomenon. While the discipline of history emerged alongside others in the social sciences—economics, political science, anthropology, sociology—the innate human interest in making sense of the past makes the relationship between academic historians and the larger public far more complicated than with other disciplines.

The complicated relationship emerges, in part, because most people do not regularly encounter “history” through scholarly history, nor do they have any sense of how this kind of history might influence the world they live in. Instead, they experience history in a variety of ways, three of which are worth noting.

First, most people have taken a history course or two—perhaps in primary school, secondary school, or college—or a hybrid social studies or government class that aspires to history. The pedagogy often focuses on dates, events, and facts. Rarely is this historical past connected in a meaningful, organic way to students’ current lives or presented as a tool to help them think about their contemporary world. For too many, history is either a dry chronology or else a set of heavy-handed moral lessons or themes, with little connection to students’ present-day or future lives. There is little effort to highlight the virtues of history as a methodology, temperament, or way to understand, navigate, and improve outcomes in the world.

Second, people often encounter the past by visiting historic sites or museums. They interact with tour guides, see exhibits, and visit original or replica sites where significant events took place or consequential figures lived or worked. Museums, memorials, and historical sites can generate curiosity or even excitement about the past, but they themselves are products of history and cannot be viewed uncritically. Consider someone wanting to visit the Betsy Ross House in Philadelphia after having picked up somewhere that Ross, at the behest of George Washington and other leading founders, sewed the first American flag. The visitor might be surprised, and likely disappointed, to learn that historians have discovered no evidence that Ross made the flag or even lived in the house and that her legend is largely the product of a speech given by her grandson after the Civil War, made popular by the flag mania that arose after the conflict and has never quite subsided.<sup>11</sup> Or especially alert visitors on a tour of Colonial Williamsburg might find that the place reveals more about attitudes and perspectives of 1930s Virginia, when the site was restored with funds from John D. Rockefeller Jr., than it does about the eighteenth-century British colony it purports to represent. Museums and public history sites can inspire a visitor to reimagine the past and encourage further inquiry. It can go unmentioned, however, that these sites have their own history and purpose and provide problematic or disputed interpretations of the past, leaving viewers mystified, disappointed, or even misinformed.

Third, the larger public often encounters the ideas of popular historians through their books. Many of these writers offer their thoughts on television programs or podcasts, often commenting on important anniversaries or political events. These authors tell vivid, engaging stories, and many do try to connect the present with the past. At times, however, their analysis can feel more anecdotal than rigorous. They often focus on wars, political leaders, or other important individuals and are often hagiographic, patriotic, redemptive, and oriented toward simple lessons. They rarely compel readers or viewers to challenge their own assumptions or query what questions

or issues are being left unasked. Their narratives are often offered more to celebrate, commemorate, or condemn than to complicate the past or offer some new understanding of it.

These common ways of interacting with the past demonstrate the challenges for history both as a scholarly discipline and as a way of thinking. Learning history in primary and secondary school, going to museums and historical sites, and reading popular history books and watching documentaries are good ways to generate an interest in the past. These activities are not, however, the same as developing a historical sensibility or thinking historically. A historical sensibility has less to do with memorizing dates and facts than with understanding change and agency in the world. Public history is crucial to creating civic identity and connecting with collective tradition. It does not necessarily lead to deep historical reflection. Nor is it the main purpose of scholarly history to generate patriotic feelings, veneration, or blame. The work of popular historians, while a potential gateway drug for the love of history, offers just a small and sometimes misleading slice of the purpose and insights provided by historical thinking. At best, a historical sensibility involves far more than collecting evidence and telling good stories. It should provide a powerful conceptual lens and counterintuitive insights with which to better understand a complex, often murky world.

How do historians engage larger audiences that may have little interest in the past and may believe that they already have easy, accessible, and comfortable ways to scratch any historical itch that arises? In other words, how do you lead people beyond the easily digestible forms of the past that the larger culture often presents as “history” to the more challenging and ultimately rewarding histories that may lead them toward a historical sensibility—without losing their attention or alienating them? Providing the larger world with a view into how historians work might help.

## What Historians Do

A better understanding of the motivations and practices of the people who devote their lives to chronicling and evaluating the past should provide greater insight into the benefits of a historical sensibility and of thinking historically. But no instruction manual exists for how to become a historian—someone who engages with the past in a serious way. How might this help you evaluate and make sense of the world? And how might the qualities of a historical sensibility and thinking historically be adopted and integrated into the world beyond the historian, especially into the world of consequential decision-making?

There is a stereotypical image of academic historians. They spend much of their time seeking historical evidence, often in archives, where they unearth previously unfound or misunderstood documents and make sense of them. They then deploy that evidence to tell new stories about the past. In this view, historians are assessed by how novel their evidentiary base is and how compelling their stories are.

This portrait has a certain truth. Research in primary materials is indeed the lifeblood of the historians' craft. Given enough funding, historians will travel the world in search of one missing document. As the practice of history has broadened and become more sophisticated, historians have expanded their search for evidence as they seek to reconstruct and understand issues beyond affairs of state. Social and cultural historians trying to understand how people lived, what they ate, when and whom they married, and how they worked and worshipped, have been dogged and innovative in uncovering different kinds of historical material that can create a fuller picture of the past. Consider, for example, the extraordinary work of Emma Rothschild, who chronicled the lives of an illiterate eighteenth-century woman from a small town in France and five generations of her descendants, based upon exhaustive research in a wide range of archives, including often-ignored municipal collections. In the process, Rothschild revealed the dramatic transformations in political, economic, and sociocultural life in modern Europe.<sup>12</sup> Intellectual historians wrestle with texts that highlight how ideas develop and seek evidence for how these ideas and beliefs shaped the actions of different societies. The history profession has seen extraordinary innovation in discovering novel forms of evidence by which to reveal and make sense of the past. These efforts also provide new insight into matters of statecraft and strategy, as they explain the sociocultural, economic, and political dynamics that often shape state behavior.

Despite having expanded their search for evidence, historians remain chaste when it comes to facts, obsessed with getting every detail right, and substantiating their arguments and analysis. This can make historians seem fussy, but they understand that people make assessments and decisions about the world based on what they think they know about the past. To historians, understanding the facts, details, and context of that past is of the utmost importance, as is offering proof to back up claims and arguments.

While the chaste side of historians' persona is well recognized, their intellectual promiscuity and audacity are less appreciated. Historians decide *what* aspect of the past they wish to recover and bring to the present and *how* a particular story will be told. This is an extraordinary power. As Ernest May puts it, "It may be that historians come closer than most scholars to engage systematically in prophecy. For they predict backwards. They construct hypotheses about the forces that produced change or continuity."<sup>13</sup> This intellectual boldness can be brought further. Great historical work demands creative insight and imagination, but it also involves naming and categorizing people, places, events, and expanses of time. Think of the daring power historians wield when they label a chronological period: the Renaissance, Late Antiquity, and the Industrial Revolution are not physical realities that can be discovered in nature. They are labels given to periods of time by those attempting to make sense of the past, which stick only if other historians and the wider world accept the designation. Sometimes historians resist their own naming. In 1974, the historian Elizabeth A. R. Brown wrote a



devastating if controversial article against the use of the terms *feudalism* and *feudal* to describe European society in the eleventh and twelfth centuries. She engendered a fascinating debate—did feudalism exist?—that continues today.<sup>14</sup> Manisha Sinha, in her magisterial study *The Rise and Fall of the Second American Republic*, boldly expands the chronology of Reconstruction in the South far beyond our traditional understanding of 1865–77, starting it with the election of President Abraham Lincoln in 1860 and extending it through to the ratification of the Nineteenth Amendment in 1920, which gave women in the United States the right to vote.<sup>15</sup> Even if a chronological marker such as the Cold War is accepted, the meaning, scope, causal drivers, and even the start and end dates may be hotly contested. The same is true of concepts. We often think that terms such as *capitalism*, *liberalism*, *human rights*, and *ideology* describe phenomena that are universal and timeless, easily “coded,” cumulated, and measured, when in fact they chronicle ideas or concepts that emerged over time and were identified and defined, often by historians, at particular historical points. In other words, core concepts that make sense of our worlds are the product of thinking historically and are identified, defined, and explained through a process of mining the past to better understand the present and the future. Understood this way, thinking historically is an outrageously ambitious way of bringing a shared intellectual order to the infinite, confusing array of facts, events, people, and causes that mark our chaotic world.

Historians wield an enormous if often unrecognized power—to identify, name, and define phenomena and to place them in a chronology, often within a named era. They decide what stories to tell, how to tell them, and who or what to focus on. Doing this requires taking a stand not only about the past but about how the world works and why. Sometimes explicitly, but more often implicitly, historians provide their views on causality and agency in human affairs.

Historians are also promiscuous in another important way. History freely borrows ideas, theories, and frameworks from other disciplines. Law, literary studies, engineering, philosophy, biology, economics, art—historians are shameless about borrowing from others.

Thinking historically, when done properly, goes far beyond simply collecting documents and threading together tales. It is far more sophisticated than the thinking about the past undertaken by most people. A historical sensibility provides coherence and meaning to an otherwise incoherent and disconnected avalanche of data and information. And historians, at their best, do at least three things that are enormously valuable in helping us make sense of the world.

First, they tell us what happened. This is far more daunting than it would appear: as the story of the umbrella man reveals, historical evidence can be scarce, incomplete, misleading, perishable, or contradictory. Even when we have a complete documentary record of an event, the evidence could have been created in a way that obscures what happened. “The facts” rarely speak for themselves and must be placed within some

context. Furthermore, historians have great power in how they tell a story, including who or what they emphasize or give voice to and what and whom they leave out. Where do they begin and end their history, and from whose perspective is it told? Is the emphasis on individual actors, collective institutions, or longer-term or structural forces? The way historians tell their story should lead us to reflect upon agency and causality, or who or what matters.

Which relates to the second task good history should perform. Historians, like other social scientists, offer explanations for *how* things happened, or at least identify the most likely causal drivers. A historical sensibility, however, approaches causality and agency differently from other social sciences. More than many other epistemological traditions, historians recognize and are often more comfortable with the idea that explanations can be elusive, complex, multidimensional, incomplete, or contested, no matter how important the issue or how much evidence exists.

This is why historians love revisiting historical questions that others think are settled, reminding us that thinking historically is not only about discovery of the new. It is also about challenging what we *think* we already know. This can be difficult, even controversial, and never more so than when it is our own history being revised. It is easy to forget that a historical sensibility demands not simply an account of what happened but an explanation of how we decide to remember, recount, and make sense of the past.

We often believe that the stylized narratives of the past in our heads are unassailable. A historical sensibility requires us to question those certainties. Ask an intelligent observer to outline the story of America's engagement with the world after 1945, for example, and he or she might offer a clear, bifurcated story: there was the Cold War and then the post-Cold War era. The Cold War would likely be described as an uninterrupted geopolitical and ideological conflict between the Soviet Union and the United States that began soon after the Second World War and ended with the revolutions in Eastern Europe in 1989 or the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. The analyst might suggest that the United States prevailed by relentlessly pursuing the decades-long strategy of containment articulated by George F. Kennan in his "Long Telegram" of 1946. With the collapse of the Berlin Wall and then the Soviet Union, the United States and the world rapidly switched, just as *The Wizard of Oz* went from black and white to color, to America's hegemonic, unipolar moment.

As we will see in [chapter 3](#), this seamless portrayal obscures as much as it reveals. Kennan's version of political and economic containment was abandoned as a failure in the early 1950s, to be replaced by a more muscular military posture that he argued against for the rest of his career. Two especially intense periods of confrontation when global war was a distinct possibility—1949–53 and 1958–62—punctuated long periods of simmering competition and occasional détente and even cooperation. Even as successive administrations worked to craft comprehensive and effective national security strategies, America's policies shifted while defense budgets rose and fell and

rose again, in a rhythm driven as much by the vicissitudes of domestic politics as by international events or any coherent long-term plan. As late as 1979, few would have thought that the United States was significantly ahead in the competition with the Soviet Union, to say nothing of being poised to prevail. Even as late as 1986, fewer still would have predicted that the great rivalry would soon be over. Nor did the United States seem especially hegemonic in the early years of the post-Cold War era: US economic prospects were uncertain and American grand strategy stumbled, appearing ineffectual against such noted great power foes as the Somali rebels, Rwandan Hutus, Haiti, and Serbia.

A historical sensibility—the kind that dares us to challenge and interrogate strongly held assumptions about the past—helps push against our natural, if unhelpful, tendency toward what I describe later as retrospective or outcome bias: since we know how the Cold War ended, we are tempted to construct a neat narrative of inevitability. The revisionism scholarly historians are attracted to also allows them to complicate our understanding of chronology and periodization. The conventional narrative of postwar international relations and US grand strategy focuses on Europe and the US-Soviet competition. Historians remind us that the world after 1945 was far messier, and as we will see, a variety of forces—such as decolonization and the emergence of new nations; regional rivalries and conflict; European integration and eventual union; the rise of political Islam; and globalization and the financial, telecommunications, and rights revolutions—significantly complicate any tidy story we may try to tell.

Or consider the origins of the First World War. While there is a rough consensus on *what* happened, there remain deep, contested views on what drove the conflict, or rather, *why* things happened as they did and how key events, forces, and decisions affected what followed. Some historians even caution against pursuing the “why” question at all and urge us to consider only “how.” The historian Christopher Clark suggests that while questions “of why and how are logically inseparable,” they “lead us in different directions.”

The question of how invites us to look closely at the sequences of interactions that produced certain outcomes. By contrast, the question of why invites us to go in search of remote and categorical causes: imperialism, nationalism, armaments, alliances, high finance, ideas of national honour, the mechanics of mobilization. The why approach brings a certain analytical clarity, but it also has a distorting effect, because it creates the illusion of a steadily building causal pressure; the factors pile up on top of each other pushing down on the events; political actors become mere executors of forces long established and beyond their control.<sup>16</sup>

For Clark, the focus must be on agency, or who drove things. Whether one focuses on why or how, the important point is that historians labor not simply to record events but

to explain them.

Unlike those working in other intellectual traditions, historians are comfortable with—even revel in—shifting understandings of the past. Just like the present and future, the past is unsettled. Key episodes can always be revisited and accepted claims reopened. A historical sensibility is also comfortable interpreting complex, critical phenomena that are hard to quantify and might make, say, an economist uneasy as causal variables: the passions of nationalism, the fears generated by superstition, the jealousies, resentments, and loyalties existing between and within communities. What matters in the past is often best explained in a compelling narrative, not an algorithm, regression table, or formula.

This brings me to the third goal of great history—to explain *what this past means*. At its best, a historian’s vision of the past shapes how we think about, understand, and define important aspects of our present and future worlds. It conveys their sense of which historical forces mattered most in shaping our world and driving outcomes we care deeply about. A historical sensibility should also provide a sense of how the present is both different from and like the past. Individuals and societies yearn for meaning, direction, and purpose in their lives and times, even judgment and evaluation. Thinking historically can help people understand the larger forces from the past while recognizing the rifts that separate us from what came before. This process, this desire to “use” the past, can be problematic, even dangerous. A well-honed historical sensibility, however, can provide intellectual guardrails against the misuse of history while illuminating deep continuities and connections.

### The Historian’s Choices and Challenges

Each of the three tasks undertaken by the historian—to chronicle what happened, to say why or how things happened, and to speak to its larger meaning—sounds simple and obvious. They are not. Doing history well requires difficult choices that engage profound questions of epistemology and the philosophy of history. The past—as opposed to history—is an infinite and often formless stream of events, people, phenomena. All but a tiny fraction is lost forever. What criteria do historians use to explore parts of the past that account for only a sliver of what came before? Why do some aspects attract greater attention from historians while other parts are underplayed or ignored?

To the surprise of many, the field of history does not provide any clear rules for determining what aspects of the past are important enough to be chronicled and what may be ignored. Such choices are often driven by little more than the interests of the historians themselves and the happenstance of what materials they can find. This lack of a shared set of priorities among historians—this inability to settle the “what matters and why does it matter” questions that shape research and teaching decisions in other fields and disciplines—can be puzzling and frustrating to those outside the discipline. It is true that at different times and in different ways, the historical profession prefers certain

lines of inquiry, certain interpretations, and certain methodologies, as reflected in the hiring and promotion decisions of highly ranked history departments, awards, and prominent publications. It can also be hard to connect these outcomes, and the incentives that drive them, to any larger epistemological concern or the interests of those outside the discipline.

Like any other discipline, history is subject to fads and trends, pursuing questions that excite those within the field while generating little excitement outside it. It is important to remember that as a field of study, history has its own history: how it is practiced and rewarded, and what subjects and methodologies are seen as most impressive, have shifted over time and will continue to do so. Many factors drive these changes. It is crucial, if at times uncomfortable, to recognize that the set of subjects or approaches that are prioritized and rewarded by the field generally reflects contemporary interests and concerns. Take the steeply declining interest and rewards surrounding the historical study of statecraft and strategy. While many factors contributed to the discipline's diminishing focus on diplomatic and military history in recent decades, one driver may have been that the threat of world war and the perceived importance of geopolitics declined after the Cold War ended. If great power war is a thing of the past and not the present and future, why study it? Concurrently, the recent focus on the history of identity reflects the interests of a public that is wrestling with complex questions surrounding race, ethnicity, gender, and sexual orientation, questions that are especially acute in a rapidly changing, postindustrial, globalizing world that is currently at war with itself over these questions. Given the global economic volatility since the financial crisis of 2008–10 and the pandemic of 2020–22, a similar motive drives recent histories of capitalism, which reach back decades and centuries to find seeds of a current world shaped by what is often labeled neoliberalism. As Philip Zelickow has observed: “Fashions in academic hiring follow contemporary interests. The postwar university boom was an age shadowed by concerns about war and peace. Academia hired accordingly. Older waves had hired scholars of industry and labor, or of national development and Western civilization. Most recently, a post-materialist, critical, and fundamentally more complacent age discouraged interest in hiring historians who studied these things, including war making, peacemaking, or governance. It prioritized scholars of schemas, identity, imperial wickedness, and the Anthropocene.”<sup>17</sup> Sometimes, the easiest answer to the question “Why is that part of the past studied and why is it analyzed in that way?” is simply, “It is the issue that is of most interest to us today for understanding our own circumstances.”

Realizing that the field of history has few rules about what parts of the past are worth studying can be deeply frustrating to people both within and outside the profession. The cost to the field's reputation, both within and outside the academy, should not be discounted. On the other hand, the ability to uncover new parts of the past, and revise our understanding of what we thought we know, is one of history's unique



strengths. When we possess few preconceived notions about the past, history can surprise us, opening our eyes to events, entities, trends, and factors we have missed. The ability to present a new opinion on what parts of the past matter more than others is an important mechanism for opening new lines of inquiry and discovery that have been foreclosed. This is obviously a precarious argument—in a world of ever-expanding data and knowledge, the “what matters and why” question is a fair one and should be answered, or at least acknowledged. It is up to historians to demonstrate, in their historical work, *why* the parts of the past they recover, reconstruct, and make sense of matters to those outside of their world, especially if it is not obvious. But for the field to remain relevant and alive, historians must be not only allowed but encouraged—even required—to answer this question in a new way. History’s greatest strength is its capacity to both surprise and illuminate not only the past but the present by offering narratives, evidence, and arguments about the past that are unexpected and open us to new interpretations, even new worlds.

Historians’ choices do not end when they have chosen their subject. Important questions continue to shape their research and writing. When a part of the past is deemed worthy of historical investigation, how do they decide what evidence to select, highlight, ignore, or underplay, and how do they connect and make sense of this evidence to shape a narrative that compels an analysis and an argument? Evidence presents its own challenges: sometimes there is too little, at other times there is too much, and at still other times its reliability is uncertain. If the historical subject involves a nonwritten culture, or a time and place where written documents or other forms of physical evidence are scant, historians need to determine how best to reconstruct chronology, events, and meaning in the face of those absences. Too much evidence, which at first glance can seem a blessing, generates its own burdens. Scholars studying the July 1914 crisis that led to the First World War confront overwhelming numbers of documents from multiple archives and countries, many of which are unclear, dissembling, or contradictory. In such a case, there is always the danger that scholars can “cherry-pick” the evidence to advance the argument they wanted to make all along. As one historian contends, “There is virtually no viewpoint on [the war’s] origins that cannot be supported from a selection of the available sources.”<sup>18</sup>

After getting a sense of what evidence exists and deciding what to use, how to weigh and make sense of it, and how to integrate it with other evidence, historians must decide what it adds up to. What is the narrative? What meaning or insight do they hope to convey about the past? What actors drove the story? Which subjects, from individuals to groups of people to larger, tectonic forces, are granted agency for historical change? What causal factors mattered most in shaping outcomes?

Then there are questions of storytelling. From which or whose perspective will the story be told? How will time and the way events unfold be handled, on scales ranging from the crucial minutes and seconds involved in consequential decisions, to the



decades and centuries over which major structural changes take place? All of these questions bear on how historians reconstruct and make sense of the past and then convey that sense to others. They must also be aware that they bring their own biases and present-day perspectives to the work. Edward Hallett Carr describes this as the “continuous process of interaction between the historian and his facts, an unending dialogue between the present and the past.”<sup>19</sup>

While these choices about subject, causality, agency, method, and perspective are rarely surfaced and debated explicitly (a fair criticism of historians, by the way), reflecting upon the choices historians made when assessing their work can provide enormous insight about the present and future. As I will suggest throughout, wrestling with important or contested historical questions bears a powerful resemblance to making critical choices or decisions about statecraft and strategy. The same fundamental questions of history force policymakers to wrestle with issues surrounding agency and structure, causality, time horizons, and multiple perspectives—all issues that emerge, explicitly or implicitly, in making decisions while facing complexity and radical uncertainty about the future. While it is no guarantee of success, an awareness of these epistemological issues may help improve how decisions are made.

I would understand if nonhistorians, including policymakers, were skeptical at this point that wrestling with obscure (if compelling) histories might help them do their jobs better. To be sure, the connection between examining the past and making decisions in the present is not always entirely clear. How can a historical sensibility be at all useful if history possesses no agreed-upon method or tool for uncovering, reconstructing, and making sense of the past? Historians not only lack a consensus or agreement about critical methodological issues but dislike discussing those issues. As John Lewis Gaddis says, “Historians don’t like to display ductwork.”<sup>20</sup> But historians argue and disagree about what happened in the past, about what this history means, and also about the best ways to resolve their disputes over these questions. History involves unending debate, with little promise that contested questions will ever be fully resolved. How is this helpful, especially when other disciplines and methodologies share a consensus on these basics?

Furthermore, even historians disagree over whether and how historical knowledge can be used to understand our contemporary world and the future. Even if you could get them to agree that an understanding of the past—and the practices of history—can and should be profitably applied to understanding and making decisions about the present and future, it might be impossible to achieve unanimity on the best way to do so. Decision-makers might be drawn to fields, such as economics, with greater confidence in their ability to make recommendations, more muscular and transparent epistemologies, and greater consensus on issues surrounding agency and causality.

As I suggested earlier—perhaps counterintuitively—this divergence of views, lack of consensus, and constant argumentation provide benefits that are often

underappreciated. There is no one way of doing history. Historians engage in constant, unrelenting revisionism. They deploy competing perspectives to look at similar time periods, places, and events, and this diversity generates novel insights. If nothing else, it may generate greater humility, empathy, and imagination. Assumptions are tested, then tested again.

Some historians look at bigger trends and structural forces over long periods, while others focus on reconstructing particular choices and decisions made by individuals and institutions in shorter timeframes. Philip Zelikow compares this to the division of labor in the biological sciences, between those who study gross anatomy while others look at the cellular level. Macro histories might take up broad themes that explain the conditions and circumstances in which people find themselves. Sometimes these circumstances are well-established facts, such as geography or demographics. At other times, the macro forces include socially constructed beliefs that evolve over time, often not in a linear or predictable fashion.<sup>21</sup>

Other historians prefer the micro level, where they can zero in on the choices individuals make under very specific circumstances. According to Zelikow, this is where the “historian’s microscope” must be used to deal with the confounding complexity and unusualness of the past: “The path of complexity is difficult,” he writes, “but the rewards include more lifelike fitness training for the intellect. And seen through a microscope, including a historian’s microscope, the world can be far stranger and more fascinating than anything that can be seen by the unaided eye.”<sup>22</sup>

To develop a historical sensibility, one may not need to delve into the debates surrounding the philosophy of history or even express a methodological or epistemological preference. It is enough simply to recognize that different historians take different approaches to the past. Those who believe that structural or systemic forces—geography, long-term economic and demographic factors, deeply ingrained beliefs and ideologies—are the most important drivers of life may be drawn to macro histories, or as Zelikow labels it, gross anatomy. Others emphasize the fluidity and consequence of choice, drilling into the details and context of crucial historical episodes, and will be drawn to a microhistorical approach. Both approaches—the macro and micro—can provide insight into the past. The best historical work, and the most adept historical sensibility, effectively combines and integrates the best insights from both perspectives.

Thinking historically is characterized by two qualities that appear to be in tension but, when combined, are quite powerful: a steadfast commitment to historical accuracy and evidence married to an almost playful recognition of the importance of perspective and the elusiveness of objectivity. This sensibility, when fully developed, provides us with a keen understanding of the past and may give us insight into the choices and circumstances we face today. This is especially true if the goal is to help decision-

makers, who confront a complex and often fixed world yet need to choose among policies that could lead to very different outcomes.

## How Historians Can Contribute

The larger world's misunderstanding of history and historians is not the only roadblock to a historical sensibility and to thinking historically. Historians often fail to recognize history's capacity to be a distinct and powerful epistemology that helps us understand, act, and make choices in the world. This reflects positive traits held by historians—a humility and epistemological modesty that often discourage bold interventions into a contentious present and an unknowable future. But such modesty also exposes less admirable traits, such as discomfort interacting with people or institutions that hold power, even though historians should recognize that action in the world—good or bad—is impossible without power and that understanding its sources and uses is a critical task that they should explore. The field of history could offer far more, to far more people, for far broader and relevant purposes than it currently does. Historians have a professional and even moral obligation to help individuals and organizations in positions of responsibility, especially in matters of war and peace, even if it is primarily to hold them accountable for their choices. Instead, however, historians are notably absent from crucial debates on the state of the world and how to navigate it, and when they do participate, their offerings can be overly modest.

To be fair, there has been little effort to either instruct decision-makers on how to access and use history or guide historians who seek to offer their services. Historians are not trained or encouraged to engage with the policy world, and decision-makers rarely encounter academic historians in their professional training.

Efforts in this direction have been modest. Consider the most important book about the uses for history to improve policy: Richard E. Neustadt and Ernest R. May's *Thinking in Time: The Uses of History for Decision Makers*, based on their course taught at Harvard's John F. Kennedy School of Government. Neustadt, a political scientist, and May, a diplomatic historian, focus much of their attention on correcting the misuse or misapplication of historical analogies; they suggest that a familiarity with history and the application of several “mini-methods” can provide marginal improvements in how policy is made. In other words, historical thinking can offer modest changes at best, and while these are well worth making, they can also lead to unintended consequences. This is an important and worthwhile undertaking. But why were Neustadt and May's hopes for history's influence so constrained?

It is important to understand that the authors and the book had a history of their own. Neustadt and May were inaugural members of the Institute of Politics, created in 1966 in Harvard's just-renamed John F. Kennedy School of Government, and they developed a popular course on the uses of history for policy.<sup>23</sup> Their scholarship, teaching, program building at the Kennedy School, and wider policy engagement

coincided with America's disastrous war in Southeast Asia, the Watergate scandal that brought down the Richard Nixon administration, the largely ineffective presidencies of Gerald Ford and Jimmy Carter, and the uncertain leadership of Ronald Reagan. Explicitly and implicitly, Neustadt and May's book reveals their belief that government is a blunt and often unwieldy instrument for producing change, a venue where entrenched bureaucracies can subvert the best-laid plans of even the most effective president. They make little effort to assess the larger structural forces shaping the decision-making environment or to argue for a broader, more expansive notion of a historical sensibility. This is not to diminish the book's importance or influence. But it is less about developing a historical sensibility and how to think historically than it is about how government and its bureaucracies—especially those in Washington, DC—work or, more often, fail to work.

I make a more ambitious claim: a historical sensibility and a capacity to think historically provide a unique and powerful epistemology that can generate significantly better insight and expand the range and quality of options available to policymakers, compared to decisions made without the benefit of historical skills. This is true regardless of the entity making the choices or the substantive area of concern. My analysis focuses on statecraft and strategy because these choices are often the most consequential. War and peace affect more people, in more places, at more times, and in more ways than any other human activity, and given the dreadful costs and consequences of war, any sustained effort to improve decision-making in this realm should be applauded and embraced. This is what thinking historically offers.

Consider the choices faced by American policymakers after the 9/11 attacks on the United States. The twenty-year US-led war in Afghanistan was deadly, costly, and ultimately unsuccessful. The Iraq War began with "shock and awe" and deteriorated into a fiasco from there. Would the George W. Bush administration, cheered on by the American public, have enthusiastically pursued such a flawed grand strategy in the Middle East if decision-makers had employed rigorous historical thinking and the national discussion possessed a deeper historical sensibility advocated throughout this book?

Imagine if policymakers had honestly wrestled with the history of America's disastrous military intervention in Southeast Asia decades earlier. Would the policymakers have rushed to war with little support, and indeed great approbation, from its allies, as it did in Iraq? Would it have recognized the challenges to the legitimacy and ultimate survival of any political regime installed and supported from Washington? Would it have pursued brutal and ultimately unsuccessful counterinsurgency campaigns, as it did in both wars? Might the recognition that, in both cases, America's freedom to act, its lack of geopolitical constraint, was as much a potential curse as a blessing?

While we cannot know for certain, thinking historically in a rigorous and searching manner should have given even the most enthusiastic supporter of America's wars in the greater Middle East pause. Even if it did not prevent unwise military

interventions, it might have provided tools for decision-makers to do it more effectively or to be more confident that their original decisions had been a mistake and to exit Iraq and Afghanistan sooner and with less lasting damage. Furthermore, a citizenry with a better historical sensibility would have likely generated greater pushback. Knowing the broad strokes of what happened in the past is not a substitute for applying historical analysis and risks compounding the mistakes of the past instead of learning from them.

Thinking historically does not mean that decision-makers will always make the right choice. A historical sensibility conditions decision-makers to recognize how difficult their choices are and how impossible it is to fully grasp the consequences, over time, of even the most successful policies. While it is daunting to grapple with this uncertainty, thinking historically is not an argument to do nothing or to choose cautious, middle-of-the-road policies. A choice to do nothing is often as consequential, and as likely to be wrong, as a choice to do something ambitious. Nor am I claiming that there are precise historical analogies whose lessons will clearly guide policy: there are as many differences as similarities between the circumstances Presidents Lyndon Johnson and Richard Nixon faced in Vietnam and those faced by President George W. Bush and his successors in Afghanistan and Iraq. Instead, thinking historically should generate skepticism about bold or monocausal claims about how the world works. It should lead decision-makers to look for and question implicitly held assumptions about causality and agency, understand when the present is *different* from the past, and generate searching questions that should be debated before difficult choices are made.

Consider a successful effort to think historically that led to bold, successful policies by imagining another counterfactual—how the United States and the world might have fared after the global financial crisis of 2008–10 if arguably the most important actor, the chairman of the Federal Reserve Board, had been someone other than Ben Bernanke. Before taking up his role at the Fed, Bernanke was an esteemed scholar steeped in economic history, who was deeply familiar with the historical causes and consequences of the Great Depression. His scholarly work had taught him how the failure of central banks to intervene vigorously after a series of bank failures in 1929, 1930, and 1931 had led to a collapse in lending and a fall in aggregate demand. He also had a historically informed understanding of the deep social consequences of widespread illiquidity and bankruptcy. Motivated by this background in economic history and alert to the danger that existed in 2008, Bernanke pursued aggressive short-term lending, accommodating monetary policy, and innovative open-market operations to contain and lessen the damage caused by the financial crisis.<sup>24</sup>

Thinking historically, Bernanke understood that the decisions made by central bankers to cut down liquidity at the start of the Depression had made the crisis far worse. He knew from his deep familiarity with that past that the best policy response was to engage actively with his counterparts around the world to supply liquidity creatively and boldly to the international financial and monetary system. Thinking

historically did not mean that he simply borrowed analogies from the past; he understood that the different conditions and circumstances the world faced in 2008–10 demanded novel, ambitious, unprecedented actions, even radical experimentation. Bernanke's deep familiarity with the past did not simply provide historical lessons; it liberated him from the fixed thinking and dogma that often dominated the economics profession. There are many reasons that the financial crisis of 2008–10 did not cause another Great Depression, as many feared, but Bernanke's historical knowledge, sensibility, and skills must rank high on the list.

If individuals and institutions embrace a historical sensibility and think historically, their decisions should not simply be better at the margins. Thinking historically should help decision-makers avoid disasters, allow them to cut their losses more quickly when their original decisions are revealed to be unwise, understand and anticipate how their allies and adversaries see, act, and react in the world, ask better, more searching questions about the choices available, evaluate tradeoffs and unintended consequences more clearly, and over the long run, make more informed choices than they would have made in the absence of historical thinking.



## 2

# History for Policy

A historical sensibility provides a deeper, richer comprehension of the world around us. Can that thinking historically be deployed to better understand and manage our contemporary and future circumstances? One might offer many objections to the claim that history can be used to inform policy and to make better decisions. History does not provide the parsimony and certainty that make other ways of understanding the world compelling to decision-makers. It does not easily support predictive claims. The past is easily and widely misused. Many people, including historians, question whether undertaking contemporary history, or doing history in “real time,” is wise or even possible. Historians are often skeptical of policy and power, and those making decisions are often skeptical in turn about what history can offer them. These critiques must be taken seriously, and I explore each below. In the end, however, working through these issues reveals that thinking historically and assessing and making policy have much in common and, when engaged, can each improve the other.

### How Is a Historical Approach Different?

One way to understand how thinking historically might function—and to assess whether it might be a useful tool for understanding not only the past but the present and the future—is to compare it to other approaches. How is it different from other ways of making sense of the world, and does it provide insights that other lenses do not?

For students or practitioners of statecraft and strategy, one obvious lens offers a helpful comparison to history: international relations, or IR, a subfield of political science. International relations scholars regularly comment on contemporary issues of world politics, foreign policy, and grand strategy and often advocate for their scholarship to be incorporated into decision-making. Some become policymakers themselves. The engagement of international relations scholars could be an admirable model for historians looking to influence policy discussions and decisions.

Diplomatic and military history, subfields in the history discipline, are the areas of historical inquiry most similar to international relations; these subfields, like IR, are concerned with questions of statecraft and strategy. There is much overlap in the way IR scholars and diplomatic and military historians understand the world, and both spend a

lot of time trying to gather evidence from the past and assess and evaluate it. Scholars from the two worlds frequently interact.

There are also sharp differences. Historians and political scientists often study the same events and actors, but they assess, analyze, research, and write about them in very different ways. There have also been debates and exchanges between the two groups about the benefits and drawbacks of each field, as well as discussions exploring a deeper collaboration.<sup>1</sup> Both approaches possess admirable qualities for making sense of the world, and both have drawbacks. Both approaches have passionate advocates, and there are benefits to contrasting the different disciplines, if only to better highlight what a historical sensibility is and is not.<sup>2</sup>

One immediate difference is how each discipline identifies itself. Political science and its subfield, international relations, proudly see themselves as firmly within the social sciences. While nonpositivist approaches exist, most social scientists affiliate their study of societies, economics, and politics with the successful methods and conceptual lens used by the natural and physical sciences to understand the world. History, by contrast, is less certain of its intellectual identity and has engaged in sharp internal debates over whether the study of the past can be “scientific.” This question has generated responses ranging from enthusiasm to outright rejection. History is often unsure how it should position itself toward the sciences and even the social sciences.

To give an example: Should history as a scholarly discipline be seen as part of the social sciences or the humanities, two distinct ways of organizing both research and teaching within colleges and universities? This is not a question most literature scholars or economists ask; but different historians would give different answers. The founders of the professional study of history in the United States in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries largely saw themselves as firmly anchored in social science. They believed in a knowable, objective past with a sharp distinction between facts and values.<sup>3</sup> Others disagreed. One of the most celebrated, influential scholars in the second half of the twentieth century, the cultural historian Jacques Barzun, believed that historical study was a way of knowing distinct from the sciences and opposed any effort to move the discipline from its orientation in the humanities. “History,” he wrote, “has no need of mathematical precision because it deals with activity and not process.... History owns affinity with art, poetry, philosophy, and religion, to which few would deny the possibility of precision and truth though they are untestable by rule.”<sup>4</sup> In 2018, *Inside Higher Ed* reported on a community college dean, trying to map out his school’s distributional requirements, who confessed uncertainty about how to answer the question “Should history, as a discipline, be classified under ‘humanities’ or ‘social science’?”<sup>5</sup> He was struck that no one had asked him that before.

Political science, where international relations resides, displays less uncertainty about its identity, methods, or purpose: it sits firmly and comfortably in the social sciences and is mostly at ease with the (admittedly contested) aim of being “scientific.”

The comparison with history is illuminating. The description of political science and international relations that follows may be, in certain ways, exaggerated for effect. Political science, with IR as a subfield, is home to many different approaches embracing a range of methodologies. Historians, of course, also use theory and generalize, and political scientists express epistemological uncertainty and often counsel modesty in making claims about the world. The comparison of goals and methods offered below is meant to highlight what might be considered distinct and valuable about a historical sensibility and thinking historically. These qualities are often overlooked or underappreciated in the study and practice of statecraft and strategy.

One important ambition many political scientists have is to develop theories—scientifically acceptable general principles offered to explain recurring phenomena—that help us understand how the world works, with the goal of using that knowledge to improve our physical, social, or political environments through policy, in the hope of making the world safer, more efficient, or more just. These theories, for many scholars in international relations, are most valuable when they possess at least some of the following five qualities.

First, the claims of any scientific theory must be falsifiable. In other words, any assertion about the world must be testable against evidence to see if it is true or false. Statements about the world that are not falsifiable are seen as unscientific and therefore less reliable. Preferably, you would want to test theories many times, and certainly more than once; the more evidence you have that the theory explains something in the world, the stronger the theory.

Second, the phenomenon or processes being studied should be classifiable; they should be collected with those that are similar, so that after being grouped, they can be aggregated and analyzed. This is not to say that political science does not recognize that many of the things it studies are unique. Rather, the hope is that by identifying strong similarities among a class of behaviors or events or actors, trends or rules or laws can be discovered that can explain the past and guide the future.

Collecting and analyzing a sample possessing similar characteristics should lead to the third goal: the theories and explanations one creates must be generalizable. A good theory should identify patterns of behavior or action in the world that apply in different places and at different times. A powerful theory of war, for instance, should be equally effective in explaining a major conflict in the seventeenth century or the twentieth, in Europe or South America, so long as the other conditions are similar. Once a generalizable theory is developed, it can and should be used to predict future behavior, events, and phenomena. Strong theories should, according to political scientists, tell us what the future will be like.

Fourth, the most elegant—and therefore the best—theories are parsimonious. The simplest theory that explains the largest number of things is always preferred. The more allowances a theory grants, the more it makes exceptions for context and circumstances, the less predictive it is, and therefore less valued.

Fifth, the best theories allow for knowledge to be cumulative. In other words, questions and puzzles the world offers can be answered definitively—no one, for instance, debates the laws of thermodynamics any longer—and once settled, the answers from these theories can provide the foundations for other theories. Science, in other words, does not revisit the same questions repeatedly but seeks to build upon settled questions to expand the scope of exploration and knowledge.

To achieve these goals, many political scientists pursue causal identification strategies. They try to identify and isolate the most important variables and combinations of variables that mark certain kinds of actors or cause certain phenomena. In so doing, they try to separate out dependent and independent variables, to clearly identify the factors or forces that drive predictable outcomes. They pursue this through a variety of methods, including controlled and natural experiments, cumulating, coding, and analyzing large amounts of data, and process tracing through a few cases or even a single case.

This is, admittedly, a shallow and incomplete picture of how international relations scholars go about their work. Even this simplistic description, however, suggests the power and appeal of a scientific approach to statecraft and strategy. The study and practice of science, after all, underlies much of humanity's efforts to understand, control, exploit, and transform the natural and physical world, to give us security against the forces of nature while increasing human wealth and welfare. Over the past few centuries, these methods have brought considerable knowledge and generated extraordinary improvements in the length and quality of human life. Even if the scientific approach to understand and improve the social, cultural, and political world has been, arguably, far more modest than that of the natural sciences, it would be foolish not to appreciate the value and appeal of scientific approaches to political phenomena whenever and wherever possible. The discipline of history, moreover, at times shares, explicitly or implicitly, many of the ambitions of social science.

But a historical sensibility also demands a healthy skepticism toward the power and applicability of the scientific approach to some of the questions involving human activity in the social, cultural, economic, and political realms. This would include a wariness about making bold, parsimonious, replicable generalizations about many political questions, including those surrounding statecraft, strategy, and war and peace. We can ask hard questions about the process by which social scientists code different historical events and actors as "similar." Do we lose more, in terms of understanding, from smoothing over the differences than we gain from increasing the sample size? A historical sensibility might view the explanatory insights or generalizable theories emerging from a statistical analysis of this cumulated data with a grain of salt. To be clear, it is not that historians don't hope for a scientific approach that might explain politics or believe that something like a scientific approach is sometimes possible. Some phenomena—say, international financial transactions or voting patterns in elections—clearly possess characteristics that make them amenable to such an

approach. But for other phenomena, such as regime types or the role of rising powers in causing wars, the usefulness of a quantitative approach is less clear. Even when historians doubt some of social science's bolder claims about the causes and amelioration of conflict, they can recognize the great value of a rigorous, transparent approach to understanding the world. Social scientists are admirably explicit about the assumptions underlying their models, about why they select certain kinds of evidence and not others, and about the benefits and drawbacks of different methodological approaches. They are ruthless in search of causes.

At the end of the day, however, historians wonder how often one can generate falsifiable, generalizable, parsimonious, cumulative theories, built by aggregating phenomena that are unique or at least dissimilar in critical ways, about the most important questions surrounding statecraft and strategy. We cannot control conditions in the world the way we can in a laboratory, and there may always be what social scientists call confounding variables—important factors that researchers haven't considered. Any attempt at a general, predictive theory may overlook crucial aspects of history that could help explain the complexities surrounding statecraft or the causes of war and peace. There is also what we might call the N+1 problem: the next case may be different enough from all previous cases that it must be studied afresh. Historians worry that although the goals of social science are admirable, unchallenged faith in their attainability may blind observers to the nuances of context, circumstance, contingency, chance, complexity, uncertainty, and agency. They further question whether there is such a thing as an independent variable in international politics that can be isolated and understood. As John Lewis Gaddis states, "Historians believe in contingent, not categorical causation.... Historians reject ... the doctrine of immaculate causation."<sup>6</sup> Or as Edward Hallett Carr (quoting Georges Sorel) explains, a historian proceeds "by feeling one's way; one should try out probable and partial hypotheses, and be satisfied with provisional approximations so as to always leave the door open to progressive correction."<sup>7</sup>

Historians, furthermore, historicize everything, even core concepts or definitions that many consider universal and atemporal. This includes scientific methods, approaches, and even basic definitions. In other words, history recognizes that the development and practice of the natural and social sciences themselves have evolved over time and will continue to do so. These scholarly fields of study were born and developed in certain times and places, and they cannot escape their own past. Historians are quick to remind the world that even our most basic, widely embraced concepts and definitions have a history. As the British historian Sir Llewellyn Woodward argues, "We have a duty to warn society against the common habit of surrender to vague words: words like *liberty*, *equality*, or complicated terms like *private property*, *ownership*, *individualism*, *free enterprise*. We can convey such warnings most easily by showing how these words and terms have had different

meanings at different times.”<sup>8</sup> There is a careful balancing act: a historical sensibility is not a call for relativism or to empty widely used terms of their meaning and power, but it urges against simply accepting claims of universality and timelessness in politics as well as other social realms, without acknowledging the fundamental importance of historical context, contingency, and circumstance. Although historians appreciate scientific efforts to understand human political and sociocultural activity, they are guided, as Ernest May points out, by the edict that “if history teaches anything, it is how uncertain and unpredictable are the consequences of what men do.”<sup>9</sup>

Yet when it tries to offer insight into statecraft and strategy, this kind of historical approach operates at a steep disadvantage compared to other, more certain epistemologies. Consider policymakers who invite a historian and an international relations scholar to their conference room to discuss some crucial issue or decision they must make—perhaps how to deal with a rising, potentially hostile foreign power. In the fifteen minutes allotted to her, the IR scholar asserts that based on her survey of how rising powers have behaved throughout the world over two millennia, she can predict with great confidence how the new contender is likely to act and how the policymaker should respond. Her presentation is sharp and confident, and she makes actionable predictions about the future. The historian struggles throughout his fifteen minutes and is visibly distracted by his IR colleague’s claims; he even questions how to measure power and its rise and finds any comparison of the current world to city-states in Ancient Greece or Hapsburg Spain irrelevant or misleading. He notes all the rising powers that are missing from the IR scholar’s data set, how there are as many differences as similarities among the various cases under analysis, and how, in the case the policymakers are currently worried about, circumstance, context, contingency, and chance are both key forces and almost impossible to measure. The historian spends his allotted time explaining all the problems with the IR presentation while offering no insight or advice of his own.

Policymakers might understandably find the IR scholar’s definitive, parsimonious explanation, delivered with confidence and certainty and backed by powerful theoretical generalizations, very appealing. The historian’s insistence on context, contingency, chance, and uncertainty might frustrate the people facing consequential choices under a pressing deadline. Telling decision-makers “it depends” or “the future is unknowable,” while technically true, does not help when choices must be made (and even deciding not to choose may have grave consequences). Policymakers do not have the luxury or time to explore all the nuances of a question or to avoid making a choice.

History’s uncertain identity—is it a social science or not?—and its wariness toward theory and generalization can be confusing or off-putting to those who need answers and to scholars trained in more muscular traditions. In fact, when handled well, a historical way of thinking can provide admirable flexibility, allowing policymakers to embrace the best of both the social science and humanistic approaches while limiting



the excesses of either. A historical sensibility appreciates and even occasionally mirrors social scientists' desire to emulate the strict disciplinary and methodological rules of the physical sciences and their search for objectivity. But it also recognizes the limits of such an effort.

My point is not to argue for one approach or another—either social sciences or humanities, thinking historically or using international relations theory—as the best way to understand, evaluate, and pursue statecraft and strategy. The goal should be to keep both perspectives—the scientific and humanistic, history and international relations—in mind when attempting to use history to generate useful insights about the world. Balancing and integrating the best of both approaches is the ideal.

### The Pitfalls of History

A discipline that has no defined identity, little consensus on method, and few uncontested core assumptions about its mission can easily be abused. These misuses can also be difficult to police. Recall that a historical sensibility demands as rigorous and intensive a training as any other scholarly field. But in other advanced disciplines and fields—for example, nuclear engineering, tort law, or oncology—expertise is obvious, demonstrable, and often results driven. It is difficult to fake expert status in nuclear physics or military logistics, since one's lack of knowledge or skill would quickly become obvious. As I've noted, thinking historically *appears* to be available to anyone and easy to employ. Anyone can access the past and make sense of it for themselves; it is easy to be a dilettante. Judged by book sales, television appearances, and visits with US presidents, many of the most successful historians have no formal training or academic standing. The accessibility of history is both a blessing and a curse.

While wrestling with the past provides important benefits, it is necessary to acknowledge the dangers the use of history can generate. One of the most important reasons to develop a historical sensibility is to become aware of and vigorously challenge the pervasive misuse of the past.

Some unwise uses of history are relatively harmless. Antiquarianism, for example, is often nothing more than assembling facts or physical objects without much effort to explore their deeper meaning or relevance. It is the scrapbook or hobbyist version of history, collecting artefacts, manuscripts, and historical novelty items. Another mostly unhazardous use of history is nostalgia. Nostalgia often imagines the past as a happier time, with better choices and possibilities. Neither of these ways of thinking about the past is necessarily troubling; they might be thought of as historical comfort food, satisfying deep if at times mysterious urges to connect with what came before, providing little in the way of healthy nourishment but safe in limited quantities.

History can, however, be misused in ways that are potentially disorienting or even dangerous. A well-functioning historical sensibility is able to identify when the past is being used in troubling ways and should call it out or prevent it from gaining

influence. There are at least four categories of misuse that a well-conditioned historical sensibility should be especially sensitive to.

#### OVERCERTAINTY AND RIGIDITY

History misused to reinforce unwarranted certainty can result in an unwillingness to challenge or modify beliefs about the world.

Individuals, groups, and societies understandably seek certainty about the world and their place in it. They look to the past for confirmation of their deeply held beliefs about their environment, circumstances, and identity and of their beliefs about others. People and institutions are usually resistant to change or challenge, either because of their comfort with traditional arrangements or because they derive special benefit from them. In the face of pressure to reform, individuals and organizations may justify their current circumstances and practices by looking to the past and arguing that things have always been done a certain way. They may contend that history reveals the costs and dangers of change to be prohibitive. They will not use the past to question their assumptions and beliefs but will borrow selectively to justify their unwillingness to alter present arrangements.

This highlights an important point: history is not the same as tradition, and rigorous, critical historical thinking is very different from blind veneration of the past. Traditions are customs, practices, and beliefs handed down through generations. While a highly developed historical sensibility respects the resilience and purposes of traditions, it should also rigorously examine their origins, assumptions, and consequences. Given the compelling attraction and power of tradition, skeptically examining it can and should be an uncomfortable exercise. A historical sensibility makes no a priori judgment on whether a tradition is good or bad. But it is skeptical of rigidity and of the idea that a practice, policy, or institution is good because it has always been that way. It also casts a skeptical eye on the simple-minded view that historical change itself is bad.

A historical sensibility recognizes that the future will likely be different from the past in important ways, presenting new circumstances, criteria, and choices to decision-makers. Sometimes those changes will be driven by long-term structural changes—new technologies, demographic or environmental shifts, the rise and fall of religions or ideologies—which will force individuals and societies to adapt; at other times, the changes involve discrete critical choices, often by policy interventions. Thinking historically can help decision-makers evaluate the costs and benefits of such choices when they upend traditions and customs. A historical sensibility will remind decision-makers that history is as much about change as continuity, and the difficult goal is to balance the necessities and virtues of each. It also reminds us which factors and variables are sensitive to policy intervention and which are less so. In an ironic sense, those possessing a historical sensibility should be prepared to point out when history matters far less to the present and future than others might believe.

The second area where history, and even some historians, have a less than ideal record is on the subject of nationalism.

There is nothing inherently wrong with the desire to use the past to strengthen ties within a social, cultural, or political community. The history of a nation (or a tribe, ethnicity, religious group, or any other community) helps to deepen those connections and bind people together while laying the foundation for common action for greater benefit. Collective entities, like individuals, often frame their present circumstances as part of a narrative that unfolds from the past, more often than not making themselves the heroes of those stories. We often select evidence from our past that makes us look commendable and virtuous while overlooking or minimizing our sins of commission and omission. We are easily convinced that our polity, ethnicity, traditions, and nationality are admirable and even superior to others.

History plays a crucial role in shaping and constructing a national identity, giving a population a shared past and communal bonds. Nations tell stories about their origins and success in the world. As Margaret MacMillan points out, “History provides the fuel for nationalism.”<sup>10</sup> National histories can read like morality plays, as if a nation arrived at its present circumstances because of its intrinsic virtues or through injustices it must correct. Such histories often invoke founding myths or tales of a long-ago past of uncertain verity. “The further back the history appears to go,” MacMillan writes, “the more solid and enduring the nation seems—and the worthier its claims.”<sup>11</sup>

These stories are often more myth than history. Some are harmless. America’s first president, George Washington, is supposed to have cut down a cherry tree as a child and, when confronted by his father, to have confessed. “I cannot tell a lie.... I did cut it with my hatchet.” Other beliefs about the past are more sinister. National communities often define themselves by who they are not. Perhaps their origin story or rise to greatness involves defeating a dreaded adversary, either within or outside the nation. Part of the nation’s identity may be invested in portraying those who are not part of the nation as the enemy, worthy of contempt. The past is often misused to make these dangerous claims. Hypernationalism, deep prejudice, and crimes against groups identified as outside of the self-defined community, or the “other,” rely on an irresponsible and incorrect retelling of the past. A historical sensibility, properly developed, should be sensitive to and protect against such excesses.

From the policymaking perspective, it is crucial to recognize the influence national history has on international relations and a nation’s engagement with the world. James B. Steinberg, looking at the complex politics of East Asia, points out that a skilled diplomat must navigate among competing national histories that are more deeply held and travel over far longer time periods than those of the typical American political leader.

East Asian countries have a tendency to recall their historical grievances with rival nations, thus increasing the risk of eventual conflict.... Their national narratives as well as their perspectives on self and others are deeply rooted in their historical experience. It is a history that in most cases—from China, Japan, and Korea to Thailand (Siam) and Cambodia (Khmer Empire)—is measured in centuries and even millennia. These images are powerful forces both constraining the choices available to policymakers and providing tools that policymakers can use to justify their actions and mobilize their publics.<sup>12</sup>

Using the past to inspire national pride can be tricky. Patriotic devotion to one's country and pride in its past accomplishments and traditions are necessary things to civic health. Such pride, however, can be dangerous when it goes unexamined, comes at the expense of others, falls into xenophobia, intolerance, and racism, and does not allow for a critical look at one's own past. A historical sensibility should guard against such dangers.

#### VICTIMOLOGY

Individuals or collective entities may use the past to highlight their status as victims. Although this is often justified, it can also be problematic.

Just as people and groups look to the past for evidence of moral superiority as the reason for their success, those in less fortunate circumstances often see history as a tale of unfairness, injustice, and illegality. In their understandable effort to change their situation or reform practices and traditions, they mine the past for evidence that they are the victims of historical crimes. At other times, a group might look to the past for previously unheard voices in order to reclaim agency and strengthen their own identity. These are important and understandable ways to explore the past.

But such efforts can also surface complex, contested, and sensitive issues and provide a challenge for a historical sensibility. The past—like the present—is full of cruelty, oppression, and discrimination. It is unfortunate when historical writing ignores the voices of peoples, communities, and nations who were the terribly exploited or victimized or who have been ignored in chronicles of the past. Efforts to overcome injustice often involve challenging national myths, upending traditions, and taking on consensus narratives. Such efforts are important. Locating previously unheard voices from the past is an extraordinary contribution historians have made to improving many people's social, economic, and political condition.

But there is a balance. A historical sensibility should display a temperament other than prosecuting injustice. The past should not be viewed as solely a crime scene where evidence is gathered to convict or exonerate a group, person, or institution. The primary goal of a historical sensibility must be understanding, explanation, and empathy, not justification, redemption, or prosecution. Justifying present normative positions by

contrasting them with those from the past can be complicated. First, there is the perspective of time: historians recognize that values and beliefs that are acceptable in one period may be seen as despicable in another. This does not mean that one should not judge past behaviors or call out historical wrongdoing. A historical sensibility should remind us, however, that our own contemporary views, including our assessments of the past and sense of what is just, may be judged harshly in the future. In addition to a temporal perspective, assessments of the past are shaped by spatial perspectives or what group or entity is doing the judging. Using history as a courtroom is tempting, but it often puts different groups with different interests, values, and histories at odds, causing them to invoke divergent and irreconcilable pasts. Such historical judgments can generate counternarratives, or what we might call reactionary victimology.

A reasonable counterargument is to suggest either that objectivity is impossible or that it reinforces historical injustices. All good historians recognize, at some level, the impossibility of comprehensively investigating and conveying the past. Thus they should be transparent about any moral claim they make, in either a historical or a universal context. They should explicitly acknowledge who and what they are judging and against what frame of reference.<sup>13</sup>

It is infeasible—and not desirable—to entirely remove judgment from history. We judge not only the past but the realities of the present and the hopes for the future. That role of judgment, however, must be handled in a self-aware, transparent, and judicious manner.

#### HISTORICAL VERTIGO

Last, the sheer vastness of the past can overwhelm and paralyze us, freezing our ability to make critical choices about the present or future. History is so enormous, so overwhelming, its lessons so ambiguous, and the dangers of misusing it so high that employing the past effectively may seem impossible. Instead of generating a new sensibility and tools for action, history threatens to paralyze us.

Imagine, again, our policymakers wondering whether a historical sensibility can help them make difficult choices about an uncertain future. Looking to the past, they might ask, “What matters? What should we remember, mark, analyze, write down, and study?” The answer surely can’t be everything. The decision-makers know that they would be very bad at their job if they could not ruthlessly prioritize, to see some issues and variables as important and others not. And what lessons does all this history provide to us, they might ask: “What does it all mean?” These questions are almost impossible to answer objectively. It depends entirely on who is asking and why, as well as where they seek their answers. Can the past tell us what is morally right and wrong and help us make better ethical judgments? We’ve just been told to be cautious in exploiting the past to justify our traditions or proclaim national greatness and to avoid using history only to prosecute previous injustices and crimes. How then can we make judgments about what came before, learn from history, and apply that knowledge today?

And if everybody's perspective must be considered, does that mean that all views and beliefs matter equally? Is it desirable for history to be value neutral, assuming that is even possible?

The vast expanse of the past can easily give us a sense of epistemological dizziness. This historical vertigo can generate an inability to judge, cause paralysis in the face of critical choices, and bring on a helpless sense of moral relativism. A properly honed historical sensibility, however, should help us guard against historical vertigo.

A historical sensibility insists that we should be open-minded and empathetic and to recognize multiple perspectives. At the same time, however, thinking historically does not mean that there is no objective truth, that values and beliefs are only historically constructed and relative, and that moral judgments have no place in scholarship. Historical objectivity is elusive, but we should not abandon our efforts to achieve it. Objectivity should be the standard we employ when generating historical questions, seeking evidence, and making causal claims about the world, even if we know that final, conclusive answers to complex historical issues are difficult, sometimes impossible, to come by. A historical sensibility, like all great intellectual tools, allows us to hold two opposing ideas at once: the need for objective standards and moral judgment in our historical work and the impossibility of generating infallible, conclusive histories based on universally accepted verdicts.

How can persons hoping to develop a historical sensibility avoid this vertigo when assessing an infinite past, whose lessons pull us in every imaginable direction? One method is to examine the questions—why are particular questions being asked, what methods are being used to answer these questions, why and in what ways do the answers matter to the persons asking the questions and to their audience, and what allowances are there for the questioners to be surprised and have their original assumptions and hypotheses challenged and even overturned? One might also explore why particular questions have priority over other plausible inquiries. In short, thinking historically should allow an answer to the “so what?” question.

Historians often suggest that no aspect of the past is more important than others, though to people outside the profession, this contention appears risible. Given that the past contains an infinity of stories, narratives, and actors, some decisions must be made about what or whom to study and how. The scholars' simple act of choosing a subject for historical research signifies that they—and if they are rewarded by the academy for their choice, the historical discipline—believe that some subjects are more important than others. How should those choices be made and assessed?

If a goal is to make a historical sensibility appealing to those outside the discipline, one standard is to ask how *consequential* certain historical events were, both in their outcomes and in the number of people affected. Other criteria might include identifying moments when individuals or collective entities faced important decisions where their choices made a clear difference. Histories that involve actors confronting



difficult, consequential choices are intrinsically interesting and valuable to decision-makers. This is not to argue that other kinds of historical inquiry are less important or that no other standards may be used in deciding what aspects of the past might be explored. Many interesting and important historical issues have little to do with statecraft and strategy, and historical events in which choice and individual agency played little role still deserve our close attention. Given the profound and often tragic consequences arising from war and peace, strategy and statecraft, international security and foreign policy, however, devoting some time and intellectual resources to understanding the causes of conflict should need little defense. Yet in the history discipline today, such questions are ignored or actively discouraged.

Asking other questions of the past is obviously important as well; the key is to discuss why we think something matters and for what reasons and to see if our arguments convince others, both within and outside the discipline. Any standard proposed to decide what historical questions matter and why will be vigorously contested. This is fine and healthy.

A historical sensibility can be disorienting because it often undermines long-held beliefs. Filtered through the lens of thinking historically, however, this initial disorientation should be productive, causing us to reassess the questions we are asking of the past, how we are generating answers, and for what purposes. This challenging of core assumptions is difficult, including for historians, but it can be illuminating if done well. Successful statecraft and strategy demand ruthless prioritization and questioning. A historical sensibility should help policymakers and others outside the history discipline in this task.

## Defense Against the Dangers of History

How can a historical sensibility guard against the unwise uses of the past? A thoughtful familiarity with the past demands three habits of mind that help guard against the misuse of history.

First, it is important to recall that the practice of history is ultimately a comparative exercise. We try to understand our own experiences by exploring and analyzing the experiences of other people in different places, at different times, and under different circumstances. Seeing the past through diverse and unfamiliar eyes allows for a deeper and more fruitful engagement with history. Our understanding of the causes and consequences of the American Civil War, for example, are deeply enriched when we understand the views of both northern and southern decision-makers, slaves and plantation owners, US presidents and foreign leaders, and men and women of every class and background. This does not mean that we must sympathize with all policies and behaviors. A historical sensibility allows and even compels us to condemn moral abominations such as slavery and better understand their pernicious legacies. Seeing events through different eyes, however, gives us a better understanding and a critical empathy for why people and groups thought and acted as they did. Margaret MacMillan

points out to us, “If you don’t know the history of another people, you will not understand their values, their fears, and their hopes or how they are likely to react to something you do.”<sup>14</sup> This is a valuable skill for those facing complex decisions; this perspectival empathy can only improve policymakers’ understanding of the circumstances that they, their allies, and their adversaries face and make for wiser, more informed decisions.

Second, a historical sensibility should encourage robust historical revisionism. Scholarship is not only about generating new knowledge but about challenging what we think we know. This can be difficult, even controversial, and never more so than when the subject being revised is our own past—personal, institutional, or national. It is easy to forget that history is not simply about what happened. It is about the way we decide to remember, recount, and make sense of the past. We often hold stylized narratives of the past in our heads that we believe to be unassailable; historical revisionism puts those narratives under a stress test.

Challenging orthodox interpretations of the past, especially if they are central to institutional or national myths, can be painful. Ultimately, however, the best historians rigorously seek out new evidence and explore new explanations for what happened and why. Societies that allow and even encourage new evidence and new interpretations, even when they don’t flatter a nation or its past, are ultimately more resilient and better prepared to cope with the world’s complexities. Self-criticism is painful, but it can generate reform and improved practices. It is easy to forget how hard it is to create an intellectual environment that encourages a willingness to challenge any conviction, no matter how widely shared or deeply held—and how rare it is for such an environment to persist. The results are often messy and unpopular, but they are well worth this price. Revisionism—the power to ruthlessly examine and wrestle with our most treasured beliefs and assumptions—is a critical path to humility and wisdom.

Historians do not pursue revisionism simply for its own sake. Sometimes we believe things about the past that are factually wrong. Take the story of the infamous baseball player Ty Cobb. Baseball fans recognize Cobb as perhaps the greatest hitter who ever lived, but they may also have grown up with stories revealing his mean-spiritedness, cheating, violence, and racism, an athlete who was hated by his fellow baseball players. This image was widely repeated over the years and accepted as true, until Charles Leerhsen started researching a biography and soon recognized that the received wisdom about Cobb was completely wrong.<sup>15</sup> It turns out that Cobb was an avid student of history descended from a long line of abolitionists who enjoyed acting on the stage. While he was a passionate and aggressive ballplayer, he was well respected and liked by his contemporaries, and he demonstrated a racial sensitivity unusual for the age. Leerhsen explains how the myth of the terrible Cobb emerged—an unscrupulous biography by Al Stump was full of sensational stories that were simply made up—and why it persisted for decades. “It is easy to understand why this is the

prevailing view. People have been told that Cobb was a bad man over and over, all of their lives. The repetition felt like evidence.”<sup>16</sup> A historical sensibility demands investigation of even the most widely held and oft-repeated beliefs about the past. This constant reexamination of episodes from history that we assumed were settled often annoys people. But good historical work offers countless examples of challenging and upending things thought to be true that were in fact false.

Last, a historical sensibility can broaden and deepen tolerance. History is ultimately the story of people, their circumstances, and their choices: who they were, what they believed, the challenges they faced, and how they acted when confronted with an uncertain future. A highly developed historical sensibility should allow us to recognize both what is unique and contextual about individuals, institutions, and societies and the common humanity and shared experiences across cultures and time. Although history is about change over time, the key actors we study—people and their societies—remain constant. A historical sensibility, by identifying and reflecting upon what changes over time and what does not, generates a critical empathy that allows for a richer understanding of why people and nations made the choices they did. This empathy can and should be imported into understanding our contemporary world. Like the past, it, too, is filled with peoples, societies, and institutions making different choices that, judged by our own standards, appear puzzling and threatening but that, when understood through a historical lens, often make far more sense.

### Contemporary History—Drawbacks and Benefits

Can the past help us better understand and make decisions about the future? There are at least two ways to think about this question. The first is to ask whether the past offers lessons, insights, and ways of thinking that we can apply to today. How can we learn from what came before? Second, can we employ historical analysis to events and phenomena as they unfold in our own time? Can we “think historically” in the present tense, using the skills we typically employ when evaluating the past and apply them to the present? Is it possible to pursue contemporary historical analysis?

Many historians believe that history is about the past and that doing history in “real time” is difficult if not impossible. They typically give two reasons for their skepticism. First, good historical work demands perspective, which comes only with temporal and perhaps spatial distance from the events and people under study. It is difficult to identify causal patterns or assess how consequential an event or decision is before we have seen what results from it. People, institutions, and phenomena that loom large in the present may fade in significance over time. Other events, ignored or underplayed as they occur, may later turn out to be much more important. What underappreciated contemporary event or movement will appear important to future generations? We can only guess. Unspoken assumptions shape our present world in ways we won’t understand until some future time when they are surfaced, identified,

and studied. Also, because we are immersed in contemporary events, they are more likely to play to our feelings, our passions, our daily interests. It may be easier to achieve the emotional distance needed for scholarly balance after years or decades have gone by. The passage of time should allow the observer to analyze phenomena at a remove, generating more analytical credibility if not objectivity. According to Bruce Kuklick, “Historical knowledge depends on a temporal perspective. Events take on their historical meaning with the passage of time.”<sup>17</sup> Will Inboden, an accomplished historian and policymaker, writes that “history goes much beyond our memories, and at the level of scholarship and understanding, more time needs to elapse for historical understanding to begin to emerge. There is no precise marker, but I have a rule of thumb that a generation should pass, or roughly two decades, for the past to become ‘history’ that can be properly studied as *history*.”<sup>18</sup>

The second challenge to undertaking contemporary history is the question of evidence. While events are unfolding, evidence may be of poor quality, disorganized, out of context, or missing altogether. In the field of statecraft and strategy, for example, sensitive documents are often classified and can remain in closed archival collections for years if not decades. Even when evidence is available, it is hard to know what materials are the most important; documents examined without a full understanding of how and why they were produced and what they led to may be misleading. In short, any effort to undertake historical analysis while events are still unfolding will be burdened by contemporary prejudices and perspectives and will lack much of the firsthand evidence historians crave.

There is merit to these critiques. Separating out the signal from the noise in a crowded contemporary landscape becomes easier with time and distance. The further we are removed from an issue, the less likely we are to be affected by our own interests, attitudes, and prejudices. A contemporary historical analysis is shaped, in powerful but hidden ways, by the globalized, interdependent world, where we have stakes and attachments. In other words, we may have implicit and even explicit “rooting interests” for dealing with events that are close to us in time and relevance that prevent a completely honest assessment. Cognitive biases are also more likely to dominate our analysis in real time, whereas such blinders may be more easily corrected or adjusted with events from which we are further removed. This is especially true when the subject of study is politics and policy, where passions can be especially intense. Such attachments would be unlikely to dominate, say, a historical reconstruction of theological disputes during the Council of Trent, even if these events did have important long-term consequences and an indirect bearing on our lives.

It is also challenging to collect evidence while events are taking place, especially when analyzing national and international security policies. As Ernest May said, “From the historian’s standpoint, it would be ideal to have all records open for free research. Most would concede, however, that this is impractical.”<sup>19</sup> The issue of government

secrecy is controversial, but no state is likely to disclose its current policies and strategies, especially against adversaries. Nor are the rules governing government documents consistent around the world: archival laws and practices vary widely. Documents are sometimes released selectively, so as to make a state or agency look good. The situation is rarely better, and often worse, with the archival records of private companies and nongovernmental organizations. Journalistic accounts, interviews, and memoirs, produced around the time of the event, can generate useful material, but the information is often incomplete, self-serving, and misleading. And if you were somehow to gain access to all the relevant evidence as a historical event was unfolding, you might find yourself overwhelmed, uncertain of how to piece it all together and make sense of it. The passage of time allows historians to assess causes and consequences more clearly, to better understand who and what mattered and why, and to select and assess evidence in a more deliberate and thoughtful manner.

Despite these challenges to pursuing contemporary history, the potential benefits outweigh the worries, and it would be unfortunate to deny policymakers and analysts these benefits simply because circumstances are not ideal. The same biases that mark contemporary history may also shape how we look at the past. Any good historian recognizes that even the most even-handed historical work reveals the explicit and implicit biases and assumptions of the time and place it was written. People excavate the past for many reasons, but one powerful reason is our contemporary curiosity shaped by the issues and questions of the present world. Eric Foner, a former president of both the American Historical Association and the Organization of American Historians, bluntly acknowledges that “the questions that interest me historically tend to come out of the moment I’m living in.”<sup>20</sup> Christopher Clark’s outstanding history of the origins of the First World War, *The Sleepwalkers*, gives vivid accounts of a rogue Serbia and the terrorist group the Black Hand that may unconsciously conjure up comparisons to Pakistan and various Islamic Jihadist groups that were a major presence in the period when the book was researched and written. Whether these resonances between histories and contemporary events are intended or unconscious, offered by the author or simply deduced by the reader, they can be powerful and instructive.

Nor does the passage of time guarantee a more objective view. As Simon Schama explained in his masterwork on the French Revolution, *Citizens*, “Historians have been overconfident about the wisdom to be gained by distance, believing it somehow confers objectivity, one of those unattainable values in which they have placed so much faith.”<sup>21</sup> Distance is, of course, a blessing as well as a curse. The historiography of the French Revolution is a perfect example: narratives of the struggle have often been used to justify present ideological preferences rather than illuminate the past. As a great historian of the struggle, William Doyle, has pointed out, “Lying at the root of so many of the trends and movements that have fashioned the modern world, the Revolution has seldom been written about in isolation from contemporary politics.”<sup>22</sup> Efforts to craft a



unified, coherent, universally accepted narrative have always been challenging. “Almost any attempt to define the French Revolution too closely, however, will be tendentious, and exclude many of its complexities. Yet what it most certainly was not, was a single event. It was a series of developments, bewildering to most contemporaries, which stretched over a number of years. It was a sustained period of uncertainty, disorder, and conflict, reverberating far beyond the borders of France.”<sup>23</sup> As a result, the French Revolution we talk about today is different than the one discussed in 1960 or 1860 or as it was experienced by those who went through it.

Historically oriented analysts might actually be *more aware* of their own biases and work harder to overcome them. Perhaps the belief in historical perspective makes us overconfident in our ability to be measured about the past, no matter how distant it is?

Another argument for pursuing contemporary history involves the nature of evidence. Many documents may be classified, but contemporary observers often have access to far more open source evidence, including their own experiences, than historians a generation or more later. There is a reason police detectives try to solve capital crimes within the first forty-eight hours after they are committed: evidence quickly disappears or deteriorates.<sup>24</sup> Memories fade or become distorted over time. Physical evidence disappears or gets lost. Immediate impressions, when handled carefully, can provide powerful insights. On the other hand, the absence of evidence can provide a false sense of understanding and unanimity. Historical consensus on distant events in the Middle Ages or Late Antiquity may be easier to achieve because new evidence rarely emerges. Less evidence provides more room for the expansive imagination but is not always a recipe for historical certainty.

If done with care and caution, contemporary historical analysis offers significant benefits. Edward Hallett Carr, quoting Lord Acton, reminds us that “history must be our deliverer not only from the undue influence of other times, but from the undue influence of our own, from the tyranny of environment and the pressure of the air we breathe.”<sup>25</sup> A historical sensibility can provide much-needed distance and perspective, from both the crush of events and our own biases. Certainly, this lens for understanding the world around us can provide insight for decision-makers.

Trying to apply a historical lens to events as they happen offers another advantage as well—one avoids the danger of outcome or retrospective bias. We know how past events turned out, and despite our best efforts, our analysis can sometimes reveal a sense that things *had to turn out* the way they did. When we are looking at events in real time, thinking historically as things emerge, we don’t know how they will end up. The importance of choice and the possibility that the future could take many different directions is a valuable insight. Such a perspective should remind observers to do the same when they examine the past: to recognize that historical actors did not know what the future held, that their difficult choices mattered and were not preordained, and that



the future could have unfolded in any number of ways if they had chosen differently. What happened in the past was not inevitable. As Christopher Clark argues about the origins of the First World War—a cataclysm many later saw as inevitable—historical actors from the past must be granted agency. Decision-makers in 1914 “walked towards danger in watchful, calculated steps,” and the “outbreak of war was the culmination of chains of decisions made by political actors with conscious objectives, who were capable of a degree of self-reflection, acknowledged a range of options and formed the best judgements they could on the basis of the best information they had to hand.” The large, tectonic forces that are often identified as the causes of the war in retrospect, such as “nationalism, armaments, alliances and finance,” are better seen as factors shaping the consequential choices of people facing an unknown future.<sup>26</sup>

Contemporary history can thus, in a strange way, be a more honest history, since we see and assess the world as those who are experiencing it do, without the luxury of knowing how events and decisions will turn out. A historical lens, in other words, does more than simply help us better understand the present; thinking historically in the present should make us more sensitive and thoughtful explorers of the past.

Historians labor mightily to understand the past on its own terms, though we understand that this standard is almost impossible to achieve, if only because we know how the story turns out and our own perspectives are hard to escape. A historical sensibility can make us aware of that trap—so we may try to avoid it—when evaluating the world around us. But it acknowledges that we cannot completely escape our worldviews and assumptions. More important, decision-makers possessing historical sensibility remain sensitive to the unexpected and the uncertain and prepare for the future accordingly.

### Do Policy and History Mix?

Few would contest the idea that developing a historical sensibility provides insight and possibly wisdom about the world. The notion that this sensibility can be used to improve how we understand and implement statecraft and strategy, however, is more controversial and contested.

The idea of systematically employing history to advise statecraft and strategy is not new.<sup>27</sup> The scholars President Woodrow Wilson assembled to help prepare the United States positions for the Paris Peace Conference in 1919, known as the inquiry, were mostly historians, though their effectiveness is open to question. President John F. Kennedy included the historian Arthur Schlesinger Jr. in his inner circle of White House advisers. Though his PhD was in government, Henry Kissinger brought vast historical knowledge and perspective to his role as national security adviser and then secretary of state under Presidents Nixon and Ford. In other countries, historians have played key roles in the foreign policy bureaucracy. This tradition has faded in recent years, and few leaders now make a systematic effort to use historians to advise policymaking.

There have been calls to bring more history and historians into the policymaking process. Graham Allison and Niall Ferguson have recommended that the president of the United States create a White House Council of Historical Advisers, staffed by scholars who do not simply study the past “for its own sake” but pursue what they call applied history. “Applied historians,” they write, “would take a current predicament and try to identify analogues in the past, with the ultimate goal of suggesting policy interventions and assessing probable consequences.”<sup>28</sup> This idea builds upon a proposal made in the 1970s by Ernest May. Worried in the aftermath of the Vietnam War that policymakers used history poorly, May wrote, “Nothing is more important than that professional historians discover means of addressing directly, succinctly, and promptly the needs of people who govern.”<sup>29</sup>

How should we improve, build upon, and go beyond these recommendations to apply historical thinking to policy? How can policymakers gain from engaging the past, and what might historians contribute to governance and decision-making? And if thinking historically can improve decision-making, why aren’t there more examples of historical scholarship and training oriented toward foreign policymakers?

Using history for policymaking can be complicated and, if not handled judiciously, counterproductive. On one hand, everyone reasons from historical analogy, and policymakers invariably search the past for usable lessons to help them navigate complex situations and make difficult choices.<sup>30</sup> As we have seen, however, the past is often misunderstood, misappropriated, and misused, and even in the best hands, history rarely provides clear predictions or recommends specific courses of action. In less scrupulous hands, the past may be mined for any answer, any justification, any cause. As May argues in his treatment of the Korean War, American policymakers did use history, but poorly, focusing on the lessons of Great Britain’s prime minister Neville Chamberlain to appease Adolf Hitler during their meeting in Munich in 1938. “They should also have recognized that they were fixing on only one piece of history,” he writes, “and that piece which had as yet been subjected to little detached examination.”<sup>31</sup> History is a dangerous and mercurial lover who will always tell you what you want to hear. A. J. P. Taylor once said that Napoleon III was like other statesmen in that “he learned from the mistakes of the past how to make new ones.”<sup>32</sup> One might even argue that relying on bad history is worse than not relying on history at all.

There are other reasons why historians are not obvious companions for those who assess and make decisions about foreign, economic, and national policy. Contemporary analysts and policymakers are not interested in the past for its own sake. Forced to make difficult choices under enormous time pressure, government officials want accessible, “usable” knowledge that provides guidance for making those decisions. They seek certainty and are grateful for clear-cut rules and simple explanations. As we have seen, these are more likely to come from lawyers, economists, journalists, policy

analysts, or international relations theorists than historians, who remain obsessed with detail, context, unique circumstances, contingency, chance, and perspective. History's comparative advantage is in exposing complexity, detailed background, nuance, shades of gray. Unlike disciplines that offer parsimony, generalization, and prediction, historical scholarship often seems to provide little immediate help to policymakers. Historians are no better at forecasting than anyone else, a fact Ernest May proved in 1973 by predicting "with highest confidence that there will not in the coming decade be another round of the Cold War." His prediction was, to put it mildly, off the mark.<sup>33</sup> Historians often point out the futility of most efforts to anticipate and prepare for the future based on what has come before.

Diplomats and strategists are sympathetic to the historian's view that the world is complicated and that context matters. Yet they are wary of being paralyzed by this view. As Gordon Wood explained, "Understanding the complexity of human affairs, seeing clearly both sides of all issues, knowing that few things work out the way we intend, may breed in us caution and indecisiveness."<sup>34</sup> Henry Kissinger brilliantly captured the tension between uncertainty about the future and policymakers' freedom of action: "The most difficult, indeed tragic, aspect of foreign policy is how to deal with the problem of conjecture. When the scope for action is greatest, knowledge on which to base such action is small or ambiguous. When knowledge becomes available, the ability to affect events is usually at a minimum. In 1936, no one could know whether Hitler was a misunderstood nationalist or a maniac. By the time certainty was achieved, it had to be paid for with millions of lives."<sup>35</sup>

There are other reasons decision-makers are skeptical about the benefits of a historical perspective. Historians often fail to describe the conceptual foundations of their work or acknowledge, let alone specify, the theories that shape it. They do not explain how they form their research questions or select their evidence, what their views on causality and agency are, and why they constructed their historical narratives as they did. Few historians are troubled by this epistemological vagueness, but for those making decisions, it generates enormous concern. Implicitly or explicitly, decision-makers recognize that their choices about statecraft and strategy are informed by their views of how the world works, what matters, and why.

Nor, as we have learned, does history provide much in the way of generalizable principles or theories to frame policy, which decision-makers understandably prize. Politics and policy are shaped by prioritizing, often ruthlessly, while historians make little effort to rank subjects from the past; one can easily get the sense that "anything matters." While historians, more than most disciplines, recognize how subjectivity and perspective shape one's understanding of both the past and the present, historians offer little practical advice to policymakers for how to get around this problem. Decision-makers act on behalf of specific national actors, in a world often marked by clear-cut friends and enemies, and the question of whose viewpoint matters rarely comes into

play. Furthermore, an obsession with history and its lessons can blind observers to new trends, new patterns, and departures from the past.

Decision-makers may also be suspicious of what a historical sensibility actually is, since it is not an identifiable, measurable skill that can be tested or quantitatively demonstrated. The skill of thinking historically is intangible, difficult to define, and gained only after years of deep immersion in the past, something most policymakers haven't had. And given that historians themselves disagree over core issues surrounding method, mission, and purpose, why should those outside the field be expected to embrace a way of viewing the world that cannot even generate a consensus on such fundamental issues?

Historians, for their part, have deep reservations about policymakers. The study of the past often generates a suspicion of power and those who wield it. Scholars warn that historical work should not be used to validate political claims and that, if one does use it that way, it should be on behalf of groups and issues that have been ignored or underrepresented by the political process. Many historians see their role as "speaking truth to power" and do not want their perspective compromised by the needs of policymakers, whose motives they often distrust. National history has a less than stellar record in many parts of the world, including at times the United States, and the past has often been exploited to justify morally problematic policies. The record of scholars, including historians, who have been close to power in the United States has not always been exemplary. The historian Bruce Kuklick has argued, for example, that the ideas of American defense intellectuals during the Cold War often "served to legitimate but not to energize policies." Often, "fashion was more important than validity," and policy intellectuals who "professed deep understanding" actually "groped in the dark."<sup>36</sup>

Historians can be skeptical about what use policymakers make of the past when constructing policy. As Margaret MacMillan points out, "History can be helpful; it can also be very dangerous."<sup>37</sup> Scholars fear that history—and especially historical analogies—will be used less to guide thoughtful decisions than to justify positions already taken or provide comfort to those in power. Historians are also painfully aware of the close relationship, for good or ill, between the modern state-building project and the rise of many of the academic social sciences. Narratives of the past are often misused as the foundation for national myths or for overlooking great injustices or mistakes. Historians often find that their carefully constructed research is distorted for political purposes. Consider John W. Dower, who found his award-winning historical work on the occupation of Japan exploited by the George W. Bush administration to defend its own occupation strategies in Iraq. If the United States had successfully converted a war-obsessed, illiberal Japan into a peaceful, democratic ally after the Second World War, many Bush administration officials believed, surely the same could be done in Iraq once Saddam Hussein was deposed. Dower was horrified by what he considered a misapplication of his scholarship of Japan to Iraq in the administration's

comments. “They keep on hitting it and hitting it and hitting it.... It’s always more and more implausible, strange and in a fantasy world. They’re desperately groping for a historical analogy, and their uses of history are really perverse.”<sup>38</sup>

Last, it is important to remember that policy is only a very small part of the past that historians study and that statecraft and strategy are only slices of the policy issues they explore. Even scholars who focus on international history or American foreign relations are likely to emphasize factors other than policy- and decision-making. Historians trying to explain global affairs often focus on structural factors such as geography, long-term trends such as demographic or economic shifts, or cultural or intellectual variables such as the changing role of race and gender or the emergence of new ideas and ideologies. This can confuse and even frustrate decision-makers in government, as culture or even ideology is hard to measure and either resists policy interventions or responds in unpredictable ways.

For many historians, it can also seem artificial to study the history of a particular policy or engage in what political scientists call process tracing. They are skeptical of the focus on “crises” or “case studies,” as if singular events emerge out of nowhere and can be understood purely on their own terms. Taking too narrow an approach to a historical event risks removing all context and missing the less obvious connections or deeper, longer-term historical drivers of important phenomena.

There are clearly many good reasons for historians to look for different audiences and for policymakers to seek wisdom elsewhere. They do very different things, following very different rules and norms, and neither makes much effort to reach out to each other. Does that mean, however, that it is a bad idea for historians to offer their way of understanding the world to decision-makers and for policymakers to take an interest in understanding how historians reconstruct and explain the past? Should history professors stay locked in their ivory towers, far from the power centers of the world? The challenges to mixing history and policy must be taken seriously. No method or epistemology, however, is perfect, and few fields would emerge from a similar interrogation unscathed.

Ultimately, the insights a historical sensibility offers decision-makers are substantial, and the benefits to policy from thinking historically are considerable. And the use of history to understand and make policy is unavoidable; human beings are wired to use the past to inform the present and future. But without conscious and rigorous effort, we don’t do it well. Richard E. Neustadt and Ernest R. May compared their program to improve historical thinking among decision-makers to teaching sex education to teenagers. Since it was pointless to try to prevent teens from having sex, you might as well teach them how to do it safely and with some enjoyment. As Sir Llewellyn Woodward quipped, “Perhaps this is just another way of saying that history, like a certain type of cinema film, is for adults only.”<sup>39</sup> If those assessing and making policy make no serious efforts to develop a historical sensibility, history will likely be



abused, with disastrous results. We have no choice but to accept history as a core part of the policy process that must be recognized and improved.

How do we achieve this adult historical sensibility and learn to think historically? Honing a historical sensibility is not easy and is often unsuccessful. As has been noted, there is no off-the-shelf textbook or course to guide analysts and policymakers. And even the best efforts at reconstructing the past can fail. As Woodward laments, “We must admit that at least some kinds of history—not necessarily bad history—have had socially harmful effects at least some of the times. Historians—good historians—have done not a little to exacerbate and even to create the pathological nationalism from which the world is at present suffering.”<sup>40</sup> Although a historical sensibility should be rewarded, even demanded, we should recognize that a sensibility alone does not guarantee success.

The most important message is that *using* history is not the same as *thinking historically*. At its best, a historical sensibility reveals not just the power of the past but also its limitations and guards against its abuse, while thinking historically helps shape and improve how we make choices based on rigorously evaluating the past. If nothing else, self-consciously wrestling with what it means to think historically should sensitize us to the most egregious abuses of misusing and abusing history when trying to understand and make policy.

While it would be surprising to many in both, the two communities—those who seek to understand and explain history and those who seek to understand and implement statecraft and strategy—have much more in common, and much more to gain from each other, than is commonly understood. Deployed properly, a historical sensibility recognizes that statecraft and strategy are about decisions made in the face of an unknowable future. Thinking historically reveals, and policymakers intuitively understand, that while structural forces may constrain and shape their options, decision-makers’ choices, made in complex environments with imperfect information and in the face of radical uncertainty about the future, matter enormously. Alternative choices would lead to dramatically different worlds, many better, some worse.

A historical sensibility generates empathy for decision-makers by reminding us that pursuing statecraft and strategy in these circumstances is extremely difficult and that decision-makers often face what Henry Kissinger called “51–49” choices, where the wisest, most thoughtful, and well-prepared leader is about as likely to fail as to succeed.<sup>41</sup> A historical sensibility also reminds us that the past is a vast laboratory of decision-making, with endless examples of “natural experiments” providing clues and insights that bear on current and future choices. History also reveals that statecraft and strategy rarely “solve for X” like a mathematical equation and that once a policy issue is resolved, a new one emerges. A historical sensibility understands that statecraft and strategy are dynamic and consequential, that point predictions are often wrong, and that even attempting them can be misguided. A historical sensibility induces humility and



prudence while also reminding decision-makers that rare but crucial opportunities sometimes arise in which bold, even revolutionary policy can transform circumstances and outcomes.

# 3

## Questioning the Cold War

Few would challenge, as a general principle, the idea that a historical sensibility may benefit our understanding of foreign policy and perhaps even improve decision-making. Who is opposed to thinking historically in the abstract? A skeptic, however, might ask what specific insights and methods a historical approach can offer to specific questions of statecraft and strategy. This is a fair question.

Earlier, I described the characteristics that define a historical sensibility and thinking historically and argued that this temperament promotes such important traits as prudence, humility, and wisdom. These concepts, however, might appear nebulous and unscientific to those in other fields, and there is no intrinsic reason that such virtues can be acquired through history alone. Analysts and decision-makers would understandably be skeptical of broad claims that history provides wisdom. Sir Anthony Eden, a Conservative prime minister of Great Britain during the 1950s, earned double firsts in Persian and Arabic at the University of Oxford; yet his deep knowledge of the history of the Middle East did not prevent him from pursuing deeply unwise policies toward both Iran and Egypt. George W. Bush was an enthusiastic consumer of history—as president, he competed with his adviser Karl Rove to see who could read more history books—yet his foreign policy record is mixed at best. Few twenty-first-century leaders have been more obsessed with history, its meaning, and its lessons than two ruthless authoritarians: Russian president Vladimir Putin and China’s president Xi Jinping.<sup>1</sup>

In the next three chapters I show how thinking historically, building upon a historical sensibility, can aid decision-makers while helping them avoid misusing or abusing the past. In this chapter, I describe how a historical sensibility often challenges and undermines our explicit and unspoken assumptions about events we think we completely understand—in this case, the conventional history of the Cold War. By upending the stylized narrative of the conflict, thinking historically does not just provide surprising insights about the past. The same way of thinking can be applied to contemporary events, phenomena, conceptual lenses, assumptions, and actors we believe we understand. In [chapter 4](#), I use this evaluation of the Cold War to generate insights and tools that can be applied to contemporary and future decision-making. The most important of these tools is generating better questions. The fifth chapter builds on

this insight to offer a historian's checklist: twelve questions derived from thinking historically to guide decision-makers confronting complexity and radical uncertainty.

## Revisiting the Cold War

Imagine you work in the national security and foreign policy bureaucracy of the United States, detailed to a principal responsible for developing America's strategies toward a rising, assertive competitor or perhaps adversary—say, China, Russia, or a rising power yet unknown. This manager specifically tasks you to identify historical lessons from the decades-long Cold War competition with the Soviet Union that might guide American statecraft and strategy against this rival. You both note that many contemporary observers are already making this comparison, either arguing that the Cold War generates insights for contemporary relations with China or Russia or suggesting that the analogy is dangerously misleading. Who is right? And what lessons from the Cold War can be applied to present circumstances? The results of this exercise need not be limited to the principal decision-makers: journalists, contemporary analysts, and international relations scholars, to say nothing of historians themselves, might benefit from these inquiries.

We often look to the past for parallels that will help make sense of our current circumstances. This is understandable. When faced with complex, consequential choices about an unknowable future, we try to identify something happened before that can provide clues as to what might unfold in the future and to assess what are the best policies to undertake and what are best to avoid. Analogical reasoning is a core feature of how humans understand the world, and comparing the present to the past, if done well, can be fruitful.

Unfortunately, analogies are often not used well. For example, historians often remind people that not every negotiation with an authoritarian power is a replay of Neville Chamberlain's concessions to Adolf Hitler in Munich in September 1938. Chamberlain's policies were labeled "appeasement," which in American policy circles became synonymous with cowardly acquiescence that brought on precisely the conflict one hoped to avoid. The Munich analogy is often deployed when the United States finds itself negotiating with less than savory states, in ways that may be inaccurate and unhelpful. Another common historical analogy is the crisis of July 1914 that precipitated the First World War in Europe. Although the causes of this war remain deeply contested, many commentators now use it to make claims about the dangers of misperception, arms races, spiral models, accidental war, and war optimism. Other historical examples, from the Peloponnesian War to the Cuban Missile Crisis to the Vietnam War, are also offered as guides to modern policymakers. Sometimes these comparisons shed light on present circumstances, but often they do not. A close look at the historical analogy can help reveal how appropriate and useful it is.

Typically, rigorous questioning of the analogy focuses on the contemporary event or phenomenon: Is the situation we face today really similar to what happened in the

past, and how so? Less time is spent examining the source of the analogy—the historical event from the past that is being compared to the present—because we often assume that we possess a shared understanding of what actually happened during the Munich conference, the July 1914 crisis, the Peloponnesian War, or the Cuban Missile Crisis and readily comprehend the consequences of and lessons from those events. A historical sensibility, however, reminds us that such a consensus may elude us as new evidence is found and new interpretations are offered. We also interpret this past through the lens of the present, meaning that our perspective inexorably changes.

The challenge of drawing analogies with the past is especially stark when the comparison is not to a singular event or crisis but to a continuous historical period that spans decades, such as the Cold War.

It is tempting to assume that there is a shared view of what we mean by the Cold War, and for many nonhistorians, there likely is. The term brings up familiar images: American planes over Berlin overcoming the Soviet blockade of the city, President John F. Kennedy giving a televised speech from the Oval Office, President Ronald Reagan and Soviet premier Mikhail Gorbachev meeting in Reykjavik, Iceland. Behind these images lies a common understanding. A smart analyst or international relations scholar might define the Cold War as the bipolar geopolitical conflict between the United States and the USSR that lasted from the end of the Second World War through the revolutions in Eastern Europe in 1989 and the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 and that, during the intervening decades, shaped almost every element of international relations.

But a historical sensibility often reveals that history is more complicated and contested than we thought, and notions of the past are sometimes even misleading and wrong. Might this be true for the Cold War? And how does undermining the stylized view of the Cold War help us think about contemporary and future challenges? The scholars would emphasize how new research, evidence, and interpretations had dramatically revised our understanding of international politics in the decades after the Second World War. They might warn decision-makers about too easily ransacking this stylized narrative of the past to apply lessons for challenges today. A historical sensibility might even suggest that the Cold War is not the most useful post-1945 narrative for understanding the contemporary world.

What core questions can we explore to demonstrate how contested and fluid our understanding of the Cold War is and, in the process, provide insight to decision-makers? The first has to do with the chronology of the Cold War: When did it begin, and when did it end? Second, what caused it? Third, what brought it to an end? Fourth, was the Cold War the most important factor shaping international politics in the second half of the twentieth century? How did it interact with other global forces? Fifth, how much of the end of the Cold War, and what followed, was a story about policy—or were there other, nonstate forces at work?

The point of the exercise is not to answer these questions definitively, a feat that any historian would recognize as contested and elusive. Instead, the goal is to highlight

how wrestling with these fundamental questions brings to the surface the assumptions that underline our understanding of the past that can generate benefits to anyone trying to analyze or make decisions.

### Question 1: When Did the Cold War Begin—and End?

The most basic aspect of thinking historically is establishing chronology. To make sense of an event or phenomenon, we must first determine the basics: When did it begin, how did it unfold, and when did it end? For a relatively long phenomenon such as the Cold War, there is an additional question: Was it continuous or episodic? Answering these questions of chronology bounds the subject of inquiry and gives it shape and form. Our answers to simple questions about beginnings and endings may also reveal deeper truths about causes, trends, and processes that would interest policymakers.

Identifying the start of the Cold War would seem uncontroversial; many believe it began as soon as the Second World War ended or in its last days. President Franklin Roosevelt's difficult negotiations with Joseph Stalin at the Yalta Conference in February 1945, where Stalin made clear his intent to dominate Eastern Europe; President Harry S. Truman's dressing down of Soviet foreign minister Vyacheslav Molotov in April 1945; Truman's decision to drop atomic bombs on Japan in August 1945. These clashes were, arguably, evidence of what many view as an ironclad law of alliance politics: coalitions fray and enmities appear once the common threat recedes. This is an argument preferred by so-called realists, who suggest that the collapse of Nazi Germany and Japan, the shrinking of British power, emerging power vacuums around the globe, and the rise of the Soviet Union and the United States as superpowers made a bipolar geopolitical competition inevitable, regardless of the intentions or ideologies of either great power. In other words, the Cold War was driven by structural forces such as the military balance of power and the nature of the international system, rather than by the decisions of individual statesmen or the nature of the American or Soviet regime.

This was certainly not how international politics were understood at the time. In the months after the war's end, there was widespread hope for continued American and Russian cooperation. A series of confrontations in 1945 and 1946, including disputes over the composition of Poland's government and control and influence in northern Iran and the Turkish Straits, revealed deep tensions between the superpowers. Relations quickly deteriorated, and for many, the true beginning of the Cold War was marked by two confrontational speeches and a long telegram that appeared over less than four weeks. In his "election" speech of February 9, 1946, Soviet leader Joseph Stalin blamed "monopolistic capitalism" for the Second World War and credited Soviet communism for winning the conflict; he made little mention of the efforts by Great Britain and the United States against the Nazis and suggested that war between the emerging ideological blocs was inevitable. Two weeks later, State Department official George Kennan sent his famous "Long Telegram" from Moscow, articulating the nature

of the Soviet threat and laying the foundations for America's containment strategy. On March 5, 1946, former British prime minister Winston Churchill, visiting Harry S. Truman's home state of Missouri, warned of an "iron curtain" dividing Eastern and Western Europe.

Many of the analysts who see the Cold War beginning in the winter of 1946 lay the responsibility largely at the feet of the new president, Harry S. Truman. Some argue that the Missourian lacked the diplomatic sophistication and understanding of Soviet Russia possessed by his predecessor, Franklin D. Roosevelt, who died in office weeks before the war in Europe ended. This kind of analysis—which sees the Cold War not as inevitable but as due to unfortunate decision-making—reflects a belief in the importance of individual leadership and statecraft, for good and bad. If the United States had been led by a different president, things might have turned out differently.

Did the Cold War begin in the winter of 1946? Tensions between the Soviet Union and the United States were certainly high. It is important to recall, however, that the United States undertook a rapid, massive military demobilization for four years after the war. Nuclear weapons were controlled by the civilian Atomic Energy Commission, not the military, and were not produced in haste or deployed in a particularly forward-leaning way. American grand strategy and foreign policy focused on economic aid and political development abroad, not on expanding US military presence or applying coercion. Stalin installed puppet regimes throughout Eastern Europe but did not give similar support to the communist parties trying to take power in Greece, France, and Italy. Regular diplomacy with the Soviets over the four-power arrangements in Germany continued until the Berlin blockade of 1948–49. In the Chinese civil war, the United States tried to serve as an honest broker between Chiang Kai-shek's Nationalists and Mao Zedong's Communists. In short, while deep tensions existed between the Soviet Union and the United States, they had not yet hardened into the deep enmity and geopolitical hostility that would mark the relationship for the next few decades.

Four events in 1949 and 1950 markedly worsened the superpower relationship and moved international politics in a more dangerous direction. First, the Soviet Union tested a nuclear device in August 1949, ending America's atomic monopoly sooner than US leaders hoped. Then, on October 1, 1949, Chinese Communist Party leader Mao took power in Beijing, raising fears that the world's most populous country would align with the Soviet Union and tilt the balance of power decisively toward the communist world. In June 1950, North Korea invaded South Korea, and in November 1950, Chinese forces intervened in Korea to throw back American and allied forces who were approaching the Chinese border. Many Americans saw these four events as connected and as a profound shift in the international system that posed a grave security threat to the United States and its allies. That sense of threat drove a radical shift in American grand strategy: massive increases in military expenditures, with a focus on increasing the size, speed, and deliverability of nuclear weapons, a spate of new security arrangements and alliances, and more aggressive policies around the world,



from Germany to Iran to Southeast Asia. In the years 1949–53, World War III was considered an imminent threat in a way it had not seemed to be in 1946–48.<sup>2</sup>

Under this view, the Cold War was not an uninterrupted, inevitable geopolitical competition shaped by unalterable structural forces but a conflict driven by specific concerns and disputes. If the Cold War is defined by a real possibility of a global hot war, then two periods stand out: the years between 1949 and 1953, where US intelligence officials argued that the danger of war was high, and 1958 to 1963, when Soviet premier Nikita Khrushchev pressured the West by creating a series of crises over the status of West Berlin that culminated in the Cuban Missile Crisis.

Both periods witnessed clear and identifiable clashes of interest. Between 1950 and 1953, the United States feared that the war in Korea was sponsored by a more aggressive, atomic-capable Soviet Union, in an effort to pin down American forces while it threatened more valuable areas such as Western Europe, which was weak, disorganized, and largely undefended. According to Marc Trachtenberg, the crisis period of 1958–63 was driven by the Soviet Union's deep concern over West Germany's political and military ambitions, especially what appeared to be its increased access to nuclear weapons. The first crisis period ended with Stalin's death and the stasis of the Korean War—and most important, with the start of bold American-led efforts to organize the military defense of Western Europe, backed by massive increases in the size of the US military. The second crisis was ended through a series of complex, interlocking diplomatic initiatives between allies and adversaries that led to what Trachtenberg has called the “constructed peace” of 1963.<sup>3</sup>

In this telling, the conflict between the Soviet Union and the United States—or at least the parts of it that could have led to a great power war—were driven by specific political issues that in theory could be resolved through statecraft and diplomacy. While tensions between the superpowers would heat up on occasion, especially in the late 1970s and early 1980s, the likelihood of a thermonuclear exchange was dramatically less after the early 1950s and especially after the settlement of 1963. In this history, the Cold War of two sharp crises looks nothing like what came after 1963. With such an understanding, you could also have the dilemma of the United States fighting a disastrous, losing war to support South Vietnam against a communist insurgency all while the superpowers signed major arms control treaties and experienced the significant relaxation of tensions called *détente*. Under this interpretation, the “high” Cold War lasted for just fourteen years, from 1949 to 1963, the beginning and end bracketing two sharp crises that almost led to war.<sup>4</sup> Some might even argue that after 1963, the Cold War arrangement benefited both superpowers by generating stability and clear spheres of influence. It should have been supported, not dismantled, and its loss is to be mourned.

Other historians believe that the Cold War began far earlier, even before the Second World War ended. Melvyn P. Leffler has a slim volume on the origins of the

Cold War that begins its analysis with the Russian Revolution of 1917, an origin point historian David Engerman also embraces.<sup>5</sup> “Russia’s Great October Socialist Revolution of 1917,” Engerman writes, “triggered a confrontation between the Soviet Union and the United States that would last much of the twentieth century.”<sup>6</sup> One of the premier scholars of the issue, Odd Arne Westad, goes even further, arguing that “the Cold War originated in two processes that took place around the turn of the century. One was the transformation of the United States and Russia into two supercharged empires with a growing sense of international mission. The other was the sharpening of the ideological divide between capitalism and its critics.”<sup>7</sup> This analysis focuses on the inevitability of a clash between two fundamentally different economic, political, and ideological systems. In this reading, the cause of the Cold War has little to do with geopolitics or the military balance of power, nor could an enlightened leader or clever statecraft have done much to alter its basic trajectory. The Cold War was a clash between incompatible ideas on how to organize societies, economies, and states, and it ended only when that competition had played itself out. In other words, the key variables explaining the Cold War were regime type and ideology.

By now, observers would note that the start of the Cold War might be defined as any time from the late nineteenth century to 1949–50. But its end should be easier to pinpoint, no? Even if tensions were dramatically reduced by the revolutions of 1989 or the constructed peace and ensuing détente of 1963, the disappearance of the Soviet Union in 1991 surely marks the end of the struggle.

Not necessarily, argues international historian Adam Tooze. “The mistake in thinking that we are in a ‘new Cold War,’ ” he tells us, “is in thinking of it as new. In putting a full stop after 1989 we prematurely declare a Western victory. From Beijing’s point of view, there was no end of history, but a continuity.”<sup>8</sup> In other words, the end of the Cold War in Europe does not mean that it ceased in East Asia, where the communist regime in Beijing not only remained but prospered. This point would be especially relevant to policymakers seeking lessons for contemporary relations with China. It might generate all sorts of questions about the role of ideology, statecraft and policy choices, and the sources and consequences of the military balance of power. Stephen Kotkin, the great biographer of Stalin, agrees, writing that “the Cold War never ended.” To Kotkin, the key year for understanding international politics in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries is not 1989 or 1991 but 1979. That was the year China’s leader Deng Xiaoping embraced globalization and opened his country to the West. Political Islam emerged as a powerful force that year with the revolution in Iran, and what Kotkin calls the “Reagan-Thatcher revolution” reenergized the Anglo-American sphere.<sup>9</sup>

Is the Cold War frame even the best way to understand American foreign policy during the second half of the twentieth century? The historian Stephen Wertheim discounts the Cold War altogether: the United States made “the decision for dominance”

in 1940, after the fall of France, and considered the Cold War an “aberration,” arguing that given America’s vast advantages in all forms of power, it is wrong to see the competition with the Soviet Union as “bi-polar.”<sup>10</sup> Other historians of American foreign relations, including Daniel Immerwahr and Daniel Bessner, agree that the United States’ surge to a “world spanning empire” was driven by forces other than the Cold War.<sup>11</sup> Nor do they see these efforts as either well intentioned or benign in their effects. According to Bessner, “From these outposts, [the United States] launched wars that killed millions, protected a capitalist system that benefited the wealthy, and threatened any power—democratic or otherwise—that had the temerity to disagree with it.”<sup>12</sup> The rivalry with Russia was not the cause but a result of this behavior, and those asking about the Cold War’s origins are pursuing the wrong question. A better question, according to this view, would be when, why, and how the United States sought global supremacy, or what Wertheim labels “armed primacy.” While agreeing that the American desire to transform the international system was distinct from Cold War impulses, Tony Smith sees a different motivation: “The central ambition of American foreign policy during the twentieth century” was, “in Woodrow Wilson’s words, ‘to make the world safe for democracy.’ ”<sup>13</sup>

Turning the tables, the historian Sergey Radchenko looks at the rise and fall of the Soviet Union’s status as a great power, which begins as the Red Army turns back Nazi Germany’s invasion in 1942 and 1943 and ends with its collapse in 1991.<sup>14</sup> Naturally, the Cold War rivalry with the United States is crucial in this story, but in Radchenko’s telling, the Soviet Union would have sought recognition as a global power regardless of what the United States did. In this history, Soviet leaders often seem more concerned about their rivalry with China for leadership of the communist world than about competing with America.

Thinking historically complicates our understanding of the past. This insight is not simply limited to the Cold War: historians Robert Gerwarth and Erez Manela argue that the First World War should be seen as beginning earlier than 1914 and ending later than 1918, while Andrew Buchanan offers the years 1931 to 1953 for the start and end of the Second World War.<sup>15</sup> The lesson for contemporary analysts, however, is not that they should be confused or uncertain. Nor is it to engage in arcane historiographical disputes. Rather, it is to bring to light hidden assumptions about who and what matters in the world and how things change. How you define something as simple and apparently uncontroversial as the start and end of the Cold War reveals whether you think that ideology, economic systems, or geopolitics is most important and how much weight you give diplomacy, statecraft, and individual leadership in shaping outcomes. When thinking about statecraft and strategy today, whether and why you choose among 1945 or 1949, 1940 or 1917, or even the 1890s for the Cold War’s starting point reveals your underlying assumptions about who and what matters in the world and why.

The same analysis can be applied to many contemporary problems. How you shape the chronology of an issue reveals your underlying assumptions, including about causality and agency.

## Question 2: What Caused the Cold War?

We look to the past to understand *why* or *how* things happen, to see if it provides lessons for today. Early in the Cold War, scholars who examined its origins often cast the question in terms of who or what was to *blame* for the confrontation.<sup>16</sup>

The early, orthodox view, at least in the United States, held that the Soviet Union was culpable for starting and then aggravating the Cold War. This view involved three interrelated hypotheses. First, the leader of the Soviet Union, Joseph Stalin, was an evil, totalitarian dictator who sought to dominate his neighbors and indeed the world. Second, communist ideology was based upon seeking world revolution. Third, the Russian Empire had been ruthlessly expansionist throughout its history, and the Soviet Union was the same entity in different ideological (and actual) clothing. Some commentators focused on just one of these arguments, while others combined two or more. All believed that the United States could have done little to prevent the clash. The best that American policymakers could hope for was to contain and deter an aggressive, revolutionary state led by a ruthless dictator.

This thesis was supported by compelling evidence. In the 1930s, Stalin had killed or imprisoned millions of his own citizens while mercilessly centralizing his own power and eliminating any possibility of dissent. He seemed very much like Nazi Germany's totalitarian leader, Adolf Hitler, but perhaps even worse. If Hitler was seen as the person most to blame for the Second World War, couldn't the same be said of Stalin and the Cold War? Wasn't the primary lesson of the Second World War that evil authoritarians are ruthlessly aggressive unless they are confronted and deterred by powerful countervailing force? Further, communist ideology explicitly called for the export of revolution throughout the world, and it was well known that the Soviet Union supported revolutionary movements abroad while also engaging in propaganda, misinformation, espionage, and fomenting unrest in foreign countries, all to advance its interests. Historically, Russia had long colonized its near abroad, becoming the world's largest empire through centuries of constant enlargement against foreign peoples in Europe, South Asia, and East Asia. Even before the Revolution of 1917, Russia had expressed interest in expanding further in Europe and Asia, as well as the Mediterranean and Middle East.

Did these factors explain the Cold War? Over time, the evidence began to pull in different directions. Stalin was an evil man who ruled through terror, but he was often risk-averse in his foreign policy. He had responded slowly and poorly to the rising menace of Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan, and when it advanced his interests he had supported noncommunists such as Chiang Kai-shek in China, even as it harmed

communist comrades such as Mao Zedong. And Imperial Russia had been no more expansionist than other European powers. Most important, Stalin and the Soviet Union had allied with the United States and Great Britain to defeat Hitler and Nazi Germany during the Second World War. Did it make sense to focus unique blame on Stalin's personality, Russia's history, and the Soviet Union's revolutionary ideology for what happened after the war?

In the late 1950s and increasingly during the Vietnam War and after, a new historical perspective, which came to be known as revisionism, offered an alternative view of the Cold War's origins. According to this perspective, the Soviet Union was not to blame for the Cold War. Whatever flaws the Soviet Union and Stalin as its leader possessed, both had legitimate security interests after suffering devastating losses in the Second World War. But after the war, American analysts and policymakers routinely underplayed or ignored these Russian interests. Furthermore, America's own ideological and economic instincts were a major source of tension. America's predatory behavior, it was suggested, was driven by its desire for markets in which to sell its goods and countries from which to extract the resources its industrial economy needed. This drive to expand—less through formal, European-style territorial acquisition than through covert and military interventions to install and prop up friendly regimes—had been part of the American political DNA since well before the Cold War. According to this school of thought, even initiatives that appeared enlightened and benevolent, such as the ostensibly anti-imperial Open Door Policy designed by Secretary of State John Hay at the turn of the twentieth century, were driven by America's desire for markets and resources. There were other accusations: Woodrow Wilson had worked with other allied countries to try to reverse the Bolshevik Revolution, keeping troops in Russia even after the First World War had ended; Truman's use of the atomic bomb in Japan was less a needed military action to end the war than a warning to the Soviet Union about American military and technological might; the United States' military escalation in Vietnam was an expression of its hegemonic desires. "Red scares" within the United States after both world wars revealed the nation's illiberal tendencies and readiness to suspend civil liberties to suppress an ideology its ruling class found threatening.

These competing interpretations were vigorously and often unpleasantly debated, both within and outside academic circles. From the beginning, the debate over the causes of the Cold War was framed in moral terms—who was to blame for the conflict? Analysts or decision-makers who were thinking historically might reflect on this debate and wonder if using history to assign guilt is perhaps counterproductive, even (especially?) when historians do it. Mining the past to pass judgment can generate polarizing, politicized, and unhelpful arguments. These debates—undertaken amid the counterculture movement's increasing distrust of the US government, accelerated by both the Vietnam War and the Watergate scandal—were a better guide to historians' contemporary concerns than sources of insight into the past.

A third interpretation, called postrevisionism, was offered by the historian John Lewis Gaddis in the early 1970s and later taken up by leading international relations scholars. Gaddis, hoping to move beyond the question of who was at fault for the Cold War, argued that it was the inevitable and largely unavoidable product of the tragic nature of the international system. In an anarchic world where the intentions of other states are unclear, misunderstanding and misperception are common. Robert Jervis captured this dynamic in his description of the security dilemma, where actions taken by a state purely for defensive reasons might be misconstrued by others as aggressive and indicating offensive intent. This perception would cause rival states to increase their own military capabilities, leading to destabilizing arms races, greater tensions, and the risk of war. In other words, neither the Soviet Union nor the United States was to blame for poor relations; the natural if tragic nature of world politics would create a dangerous security competition even if neither began with aggressive intentions.

While postrevisionism avoided the earlier historical debate's excessive focus on assigning blame, it had its own challenges. The postrevisionism/security dilemma framing reduced or even eliminated the agency of the major powers, their statecraft, and the choices their leaders made. Were the tragic workings of the international system so powerful that they left no room for enlightened diplomacy or wise grand strategy to improve relations? Was the security dilemma inescapable? Weren't the sociocultural, economic, and historical characteristics of Russia and the United States relevant to how they engaged the world and each other? Did it not matter who was in charge and what they believed?

Examining these three sets of arguments for the causes of the Cold War could be revealing for contemporary analysts exploring international politics in their own time, since each employs different theories about how the world works and what matters. One set of arguments focuses on the role of ideology, as each superpower sought, in its own way, to spread its revolutionary ideals around the globe, making conflict inevitable. Another set of arguments focuses on the inevitability of a geopolitical clash between two massive continental powers racing to fill power vacuums around the world. A third area of focus would be the role of military technology and how it shaped international politics: first, the devastating consequences of atomic and then thermonuclear weapons, followed by vast improvements in the ability to deliver these terrifying weapons anywhere around the world at unthinkable speed.

Sergey Radchenko suggests a fourth explanation for intensity of the Cold War rivalry, based on deep work in both Russian and Chinese archives. While acknowledging the fundamental importance of power, ideology, and technology, he argues that none of these factors alone or in combination can fully explain why the superpowers would risk nuclear Armageddon over Cuba or undermine the mutual benefits of détente by supporting proxies in Angola. Radchenko identifies nations' and national leaders' desire for recognition, standing, and respect as the only way to fully explain episodes that make little sense if viewed only through the lens of ideology or



power politics. Concerns about honor, reputation, and humiliation cannot be quantified and are often interwoven with factors such as beliefs and material capabilities, but they appear repeatedly in the trove of documents Radchenko unearthed.<sup>17</sup> This insight on the desire to be recognized and achieve legitimacy might resonate with analysts trying to make sense of contemporary relations among great powers.

These arguments would interest analysts or decision-makers for several reasons. First, they would recognize that framing questions in terms of blame was largely unproductive. They might identify more productive questions. Why did the Cold War rarely get hot? How did the world avoid a major global war between the Soviet Union and the United States? Did the conflict have to be as contentious and globally expansive as it was, or as expensive and bloody? Were there alternative paths that could have reduced costs and tensions? And if most of the actors understood the underlying issues driving it, why did the Cold War last so long?

Decision-makers might also ask: Were there benefits to the bipolar competition, especially during its quieter periods? John Lewis Gaddis actually labeled the struggle “the Long Peace,” a term that became quite popular: “The Cold War, with all of its rivalries, anxieties, and unquestionable dangers, has produced the longest period of stability in relations among the great powers that the world has known in this century; it now compares favorably as well with some of the longest periods of great power stability in all of modern history.”<sup>18</sup>

John J. Mearsheimer agreed, writing in 1990 that “we may ... wake up one day lamenting the loss of the order that the Cold War gave to the anarchy of international relations.”<sup>19</sup> Our contemporary analysts might note that other scholars see this sanguine view, which focuses on peace in Europe while overlooking bloody conflicts elsewhere in the world, as deeply misleading. As Paul Thomas Chamberlain notes, the Cold War drove violent clashes “that killed more than fourteen million people” on the rimlands of Asia.<sup>20</sup> “By avoiding a systemic examination of the period’s wars and massacres, we whitewash the inherently violent history of the post-1945 era.”<sup>21</sup> The rivalry took place under the terrifying shadow of thermonuclear war, a catastrophe some believed was avoided only by luck and that left deep if sometimes hidden scars on politics, society, and culture around the world.

Our analysts, looking to the past for “news they could use,” might also puzzle over the successful efforts at cooperation between the two bitter rivals. How could two countries that threatened each other with extinction find such frequent opportunities to work together? During the 1960s, for example, the superpowers collaborated, with remarkable success, to staunch two of the greatest transnational threats to human life on the planet—nuclear weapons and disease. The bipolar effort to table their rivalry and negotiate a nuclear nonproliferation treaty is especially noteworthy because the Soviet Union and United States often aligned against their own allies in limiting the number of

states that had nuclear weapons while also beginning a process to decrease the size of their own arsenals.

Less well known is the joint American and Soviet effort to eliminate smallpox, chronicled by the historian Erez Manela.<sup>22</sup> The disease was estimated to have killed three hundred million people in the twentieth century, twice the total number killed in all of that century's wars. In the mid-1960s smallpox was still taking upwards of two million lives a year. A decade later, it had been eradicated and smallpox deaths went to zero, where they have remained ever since. This amazing outcome might not have happened without superpower cooperation, which saved perhaps hundreds of millions of lives. Why didn't these extraordinary successes lead to better relations in other areas? Are there lessons from this history that might help American policymakers craft cooperative strategies with a contemporary rival, for example China, that would allow the two adversaries to put aside their differences to work on today's planetary crises, such as the climate, emerging technologies, and public health?

The purpose of this exercise of examining the causes of the Cold War, however, is to reflect upon causes and agency. What do debates over the causes of the Cold War tell us about how and why things happen in the world, what forces and actors are responsible for the outcomes we care about most, and how likely it is that these historical trends and processes can be altered through policy interventions? Is the Cold War better understood as a category within international politics—a great power conflict that, regardless of its causes, can never go “hot” because of the unthinkable consequences of thermonuclear war—or as a history of specific events and actors? Decision-makers might also ask: How is today's world different from that Cold War past, and do those differences shape their political choices today?

### Question 3: Why Did the Cold War End?

Any discussion of the Cold War's causes will naturally lead to why it ended. Looking at the debate, you might notice that the question is often posed as who “won,” a framing that might generate similar problems for understanding the war's end that the term *blame* raises for its origins.

In the first years after the collapse of the Soviet Union, the interpretative debate was rather simple. One view held that the visionary Soviet head of state Mikhail Gorbachev single-handedly ended the Cold War through his wise, brave leadership, offering grand gestures of peace and steep military reductions to reassure the West of his benign intentions. A second view suggested that these reforms were not messages to the West but desperate attempts to revive a sclerotic empire. Despite—or maybe because of—Gorbachev's efforts to spur fundamental economic and political reform, it was impossible to move an overly bureaucratized state and stagnant society toward real change. Throughout its history, the Soviet Empire had struggled to incorporate numerous national, ethnic, and religious groups into one state. Weak economic growth, a lack of

innovation or access to Western trade and capital markets, and the unmet need for more consumer goods contributed to increasing political dissent against the regime.

A third view credits the actions of the United States and its allies with ending the Cold War. For some, America “won” by aggressively confronting the Soviet Union through covert action, proxy wars, and a major arms buildup. American support of the Solidarity trade union in Poland, the Contras in Nicaragua and the mujahideen in Afghanistan, and its massive investments in defense capabilities, especially strategic nuclear forces and defenses, all pressured the Soviets to try keep pace, and the effort exposed the weaknesses in their system. Other historical interpretations held that it was not confrontation but cooperation that brought the Cold War to a peaceful end. What mattered most was that the West, especially Western Europe, pursued a policy of *détente* and engagement, which lowered the risks of war while making countries in the Eastern bloc yearn for the freedoms and flourishing consumer culture of the capitalist world.

Once again, identifying which of these causal explanations analysts prefer reveals their underlying beliefs about who and what matters in shaping foreign policy and international relations. Does the narrative—arguments about why things change and what produces outcomes we care about—focus on people, states, or the international system? Or some combination? Is this history used primarily to highlight the virtues or pathologies of a particular person, regime, or ideology? A historical account that concentrated on Gorbachev’s and President Ronald Reagan’s policies, temperaments, and personalities would show that the scholar thinks individual leadership matters most. A focus on specific policy choices, such as the decisions taken by the Carter and Reagan administrations to move away from *détente* toward confrontation and an arms buildup, would also reveal that the analyst believes in the importance of individual leadership, as these policies involved controversial and contested political choices. A narrative that emphasized the superior performance of the West’s economic and ideological system, on the other hand, would attribute historical agency to regime types. An analysis based on shifting power balances between the Eastern and Western blocs, shaped by long-term tectonic forces such as demographics and technology, could be seen as a systemic argument.

Looking over these debates, the observer might note that framing the end of the Cold War as a victory might be counterproductive, in the same way that focusing on blame was not helpful in understanding its origins. One might also wonder if scholars, commentators, and policymakers are consistent when they examine the causes for both the start and the end of the Cold War. If someone argued that ideology or the distribution of power or statecraft caused the clash between the Soviet Union and the United States, it would presumably be a shift in this variable that brought the clash to an end. In other words, if an analyst argued that the Cold War was a competition between ideological, political, or economic systems, then how the Cold War ended might be viewed as a test of those forces. If the distribution of power or diplomacy was the key variable, one would need to understand how and why these changed over time to understand why the

Cold War ended as it did. An interesting exercise would be to examine arguments made by historians, international relations scholars, journalists, and others about the origins and ends of the Cold War to see whether their arguments are consistent and, if they were not, to explain why they were different. One might continue this exercise by looking for consistency (or lack of it) in the same analysts' arguments about more recent international politics, such as the rise of China or Russia's increased assertiveness: if authors or policymakers typically provide a structural explanation for international relations but shift to explaining one case through the character of a particular leader or regime, is there a convincing reason for the change? Thinking historically, in other words, is not simply about uncovering new evidence or even about making and evaluating new interpretations. It should also reveal how we think the world works and force us to explain our inconsistencies.

#### CONTAINMENT

Reflecting on the start and end of the Cold War might generate thoughts about what made for an effective American grand strategy to deal with great power rivals. This would likely lead to assessing the strategy of containment, which many historians have identified as the foundation of American grand strategy from the Truman through the Reagan and George H. W. Bush administrations. American policymakers might ask what the relevant lessons, if any, are from the history of containment for contemporary international policy challenges.

These policymakers would likely know the conventional wisdom surrounding containment. Russia expert and State Department official George F. Kennan identified the dangers posed by the Soviet Union in his "Long Telegram" of February 1946, which was published anonymously the following year in *Foreign Affairs*. Kennan suggested that the Soviets should "be contained by the adroit and vigilant application of counterforce at a series of constantly shifting geographical and political points." The United States, following his proposal, constructed a grand strategy to prevent Russian expansion in the expectation that this pressure would expose the internal weaknesses of the Soviet system. While there was some variation, according to the consensus, the broad themes of this grand strategy were consistently adopted throughout the Cold War. Containment became the gold standard for American policies, and Kennan and his ideas became the benchmark upon which all other grand strategies should be judged. Many credit this strategy with ending the Cold War on terms favorable to the United States.

A deeper historical exploration might confound this understanding. Kennan himself was a curious character, who disliked and did not understand many aspects of American political, social, and cultural life. These dislikes ran the gamut from racial integration to television and automobiles.<sup>23</sup> Soon after he laid out the blueprint for containment, he complained bitterly about how his ideas were being misinterpreted and misapplied. For years, Kennan claimed that he had advocated economic and political measures, not military strategies, as containment's defining feature. He had a poor

understanding of the nuclear revolution, a key factor shaping postwar international relations, and in the 1950s he recommended that American troops be withdrawn from Europe and that Germany be reunified as a neutral country, positions that would have profound consequences but were rejected by his colleagues. The document NSC-68, crafted by his successor Paul Nitze in 1950 and in many respects far more influential in shaping American grand strategy, rejected key elements of Kennan's vision and emphasized military competition with the Soviet Union.

Thinking historically, one might also ask if containment explained US policy during key episodes of the Cold War. How did détente—beginning with President John F. Kennedy's remarkable peace speech in June 1963 and extending through the late 1970s—fit the containment narrative?<sup>24</sup> Consider two policies carried out around the same time: America's military escalation in Southeast Asia and the pursuit of the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty in the mid- and late 1960s. Looked at closely, the war in Vietnam seems to have had little to do with containing Soviet expansion. The Viet Cong insurgency in South Vietnam was supported by the communist state in the North, with help from communist China. A dive into the documents and historiography would show that the Viet Cong often resented their supporters in North Vietnam, who in turn feared the overwhelming power of their neighbor, the People's Republic of China, which itself increasingly viewed the Soviet Union as its main enemy. How was the massive and tragic military support for the hapless South Vietnamese regime—which often resented American intervention—part of a coherent containment strategy? During those same years, the United States and the Soviet Union, bitter enemies, cooperated at the expense of both nations' allies to limit the spread of nuclear weapons. The Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty of 1968 was the cornerstone of America's grand strategy of inhibition but is hard to make sense of solely through the lens of containment. The strategy to contain the Soviet Union and the strategy to contain the spread of nuclear weapons were at many points in tension, if not directly at odds.<sup>25</sup>

Thinking historically, policymakers might see the advantages and disadvantages of the containment narrative. On the plus side, "containment" provides a broad outline of America's grand strategic inclinations over several decades, giving shape to diverse policies that were implemented across administrations and changes in world politics. Such labels help simplify and make sense of a complicated history and more easily allow for lessons of the past to be applied in contemporary circumstances. Simply borrowing convenient parts of this broad history might be less helpful, since it would require policymakers to explain large and consequential exceptions such as the cooperation with the Soviet Union on nuclear weapons or the American focus on "containing" the political and military ambitions of allies including West Germany, Japan, Taiwan, and South Korea, countries whose unfettered pursuit of their own interests might dangerously upset the status quo.

At the same time, a stylized history of containment might explain too much. The containment narrative fits nicely with divergent interpretations of the Cold War's denouement: the strategy of containment could explain why the United States ended the Cold War by patiently waiting for the internal contradictions of the Soviet system to grow insupportable, *or* it could explain how muscular American policies, including provoking an arms race, brought the Soviet Union to its knees. In that sense, containment would offer little guidance to current policymakers facing new international challenges. If this broad story of containment fails to tell us what happened during the Cold War and why, perhaps it is not the ideal model for a grand strategy, or process to create a grand strategy, for contemporary and future policymakers.

At this point, careful observers might notice that much of what happened after 1945 might not fit as neatly into a Cold War framework as they had thought. This exercise might generate some thoughts about forces outside the Cold War that shaped the postwar period. They might even ask if the Cold War frame is the only or the best lens through which to understand the history of American foreign policy and international relations between 1945 and 1990. Could we be looking at the wrong history for lessons that could be applied today? And if other important global forces were at work, how did they interact with the Cold War?

#### Question 4: How Did the Cold War Interact with Other Global Forces After 1945?

Imagine that it is shortly after the collapse of the Soviet Union, and you are a scholar who has agreed to write a three-hundred-page history of international politics between 1945 and 1991, to be used in college classrooms in the United States. How would you structure such a book? If you were writing in 1992, much of it would have to be devoted to the Cold War, especially as it unfolded in Europe. You might give some space to other events, but you would present the Cold War as the central dynamic shaping the history of the world in the decades after the Second World War. There would be vivid descriptions of the Berlin crises, superpower summits, and the revolutions of 1989. You might highlight some of the historiographical controversies over why the Cold War began and ended.

Now imagine that you are asked to update the text every ten years, though the subject remains the same: world history from 1945 to 1991. Your second edition, updated in 2002, would be written right after the 9/11 attacks on the United States, the war in Afghanistan, and with an American invasion of Iraq imminent. Noticing how Middle East politics dominates the contemporary landscape, you might give more space to past events in the region. Some of this would be related to the Cold War: America's relations with Saudi Arabia, the birth of Israel and its wars with its neighbors in 1967 and 1973. Other aspects—the rise of Arab nationalism and Islamic fundamentalism, the revolution in Iran, the regional upheavals in the late 1970s, and the Iran-Iraq War of the



1980s—would be seen as a distinct historical force. And when thinking about Europe, you might observe that the European Union had adopted a single currency and increasingly robust political institutions, necessitating some pages on the origins and great success of the European project. You would have to trim some of your accounts of the Cold War in Europe to make room for these new subjects.

The next edition, produced in 2012, would be updated in the aftermath of a global financial crisis and a fuller recognition of the meteoric economic rise of China, as well as the increased importance of countries such as India. At the publisher's request, the book still is three hundred pages long, and still ends in 1991. But you recognize that you again need to revise the text significantly. The early edition connected the postwar international economic system—Bretton Woods and its aftermath—with the Cold War, and it portrayed liberal capitalism as so obviously superior to socialism that it helped end the Cold War and was certain to be widely embraced around the world after the collapse of the Soviet Union. Reconsidering this stance in 2012, you might see that some of the forces that accelerated globalization in the 1970s were only tangentially related to the Cold War. You might also comment on darker aspects of globalization that were more apparent in 2012: inequality both within and between states, financial crises, environmental degradation, and the decimation of manufacturing jobs in advanced economies such as the United States.

China's and, to a lesser extent, India's increased economic and political weight would also present a dilemma. You would want to understand the origins of their rise, but how much of their history is a Cold War story? You might decide that to better explain each country's history and outlook, the text would have to bring in aspects of nineteenth- and early twentieth-century imperialism and the extraordinary story of postwar decolonization and nationalism, issues you had largely ignored in the first edition.

The volume you write in 2022 also presents hard choices. You would note that the contemporary world is vexed by new challenges, and it is natural to look to the past to understand their origins. China's continued rise and global assertiveness seem to make the Cold War more relevant again, as would Russia's belligerence. But other forces require further elaboration. The ubiquitous role of technology demands that you address the historical sources of innovation. You might spend time, for example, on the computer industry, the rise of Silicon Valley starting in the 1940s and 1950s, and the expansion of this industry to places such as Japan and Taiwan. Profound shifts in how human beings identify themselves, both individually and in relation to their local, national, and global communities, sends you off to understand movements for greater rights and recognition of gender, race, and sexual orientation. These historical forces emerged during the Cold War but were neither driven nor shaped by the bipolar competition between the Soviet Union and the United States. Last, you will note that the world is threatened by enormous problems of the commons; a pandemic killed millions worldwide and a climate crisis threatens massive disruption. Can the revised world history of 1945–91

shed light on these phenomena? That would certainly better engage students—and be of keener interest to policymakers—than arid descriptions of the Geneva Conference of 1954 or the Glassboro Summit of 1967, plausible sections from the 1992 edition that might now be deleted.

When considering how to structure each new edition after 1992, you have to incorporate new evidence and new scholarly arguments into your text. Whether you admit it or not, however, what will most likely shape your editorial decisions is not a different view of what happened in the past but how past events explain current circumstances and contemporary interests. (If you resist this imperative, the people assigning your text in their classes will demand it, as will your publisher.) In 1992, 270 of your 300 pages might have centered on the Cold War, with a leading focus on the rivalry between the Soviet Union and the United States in Europe. Each subsequent edition would have to reduce that amount to make room for different histories, so that by 2022 edition, the Cold War in Europe might not even take up the majority of pages and would no longer be the central theme driving the text. Note that nothing about the past has changed. But your readers' interests, shaped by the contemporary world and its worries, have shifted dramatically. By this time, as an old hand at textbook writing, you are already asking the young assistant professor you've enlisted to carry the book forward what might be in the 2032 or 2052 edition.

We can take this exercise even further. Suppose that the first edition was completed five years earlier, in 1987, before the Cold War ended. The underlying assumption, shared by many people at the time, would have been that the Cold War was likely a permanent feature of international politics. That 1987 edition would have certainly hailed the improvement in US-Soviet relations and expressed hope for greater progress in the future. The idea that the Cold War would suddenly disappear, that the Eastern and Central European states under Soviet control would democratize and free themselves of communism, and that the Soviet Union itself would disappear during the next presidential administration would have struck most as a ridiculous fantasy. The historical inevitability surrounding the end of the Cold War that might have marked the 1992 and later editions would have seemed fanciful, even irresponsible. And naturally, the whole textbook would have an entirely different focus if the intended audience was students—and policymakers—in Moscow, Beijing, Johannesburg, New Delhi, or São Paulo.

This imaginary exercise—updating a three-hundred-page history of post-Second World War world politics every ten years—shows the often unseen power of a historical sensibility. It also reinforces something the renowned Italian philosopher Benedetto Croce observed: “All history is contemporary history.”<sup>26</sup> Nor can you simply make the text longer to include everything previous editions left out. Never mind that your publisher won't let you: the past is infinite, and history is what we choose to discover, highlight, and explain. We have a finite bandwidth with which to make sense

of the world. Thinking historically is as much about culling the past, deciding what to leave out, as about what to include. The exercise of updating the text forces us, as imaginary authors, to explain what we think matters in the past and why.

A historical sensibility would invite analysts to consider and explore any number of powerful historical trends shaping international politics after 1945 that go beyond the conventional narrative. Some of these forces were deeply interconnected with the Cold War, some unfolded in parallel, and others were largely independent of the bipolar struggle or even in tension with it. At least six broad historical trends are worthy of examining, both on their own and as they interacted with the Cold War.

#### EUROPEAN INTEGRATION AND UNION

When the Cold War is the controlling historical narrative, Europe after 1945 is often portrayed as a prostrate continent with little independent agency. It could not defeat fascism without the intervention of outside powers, and its postwar fate was shaped by the competition and policies of the Soviet Union—which dominated the eastern part of the continent—and the United States, which guided the West.

The historian Tony Judt and other important scholars have challenged this narrative. The Cold War and the division of Europe were “accidental outcomes” of history, and the relationship between the United States and Western Europe was often contested and tenuous. “The Cold War was perceived quite differently in western Europe,” Judt tells us, “from the rather alarmist response it aroused in the US.”<sup>27</sup> He describes postwar Europe’s history as largely internally driven, with the Cold War as a looming outside presence rather than the main mover. For many who focus on Europe, the most important historical development of the postwar period was the return of parliamentary democracy and strong economic growth to the continent. France and (West) Germany, bitter enemies for centuries, buried their enmity to become not only allies but deeply intertwined friends. In Judt’s view, European economic and then political integration, which laid the foundation for eventual union, mattered far more in shaping outcomes on the continent than the maneuvers of the Soviet Union and the United States. Europe not only found peace while developing into the world’s wealthiest, most educated, most tolerant political unit; it created a “European model” of economics, culture, and politics that is admired around the world. For Judt and others, Europe’s remarkable rise from the ashes of barbarism to a model of peace and civility is the most important historical narrative after 1945, one that should not be conflated with traditional Cold War narratives.

#### DECOLONIZATION AND NATIONALISM

If we measure an important event or phenomenon by how many lives it shapes, then the often chaotic end of the European and Japanese global empires, the emergence of new states after those empires’ fall, and the worldwide rise of national feeling are arguably the most significant forces shaping world history since 1945, even more important than

the Cold War. Pressures from within and without these empires led to the tumultuous and often violent unravelling of the Belgian, British, Dutch, French, German, Japanese, Ottoman, and Portuguese Empires and the rise of new nations. Scores of states emerged around the world, creating a completely new political order. The examples are numerous, but consider how the fates of tens of millions of people were profoundly affected when Great Britain left India in 1947 and Palestine in 1948. Both South Asia and the Middle East were riven by decades of conflict and political activity in which decolonization and nationalism, not the Cold War, were the central drivers. Even China's Communist Revolution of 1949 was driven as much by the legacy of imperialism and the embrace of national pride than by the Cold War.

The United States' complex, ambiguous relationship toward formal empire and European colonialism often keeps Americans unaware of how, for most of the world in the twentieth century, global history was shaped by imperialism and efforts to escape it. International conflicts that Americans tended to view through a Cold War lens were understood by the participants as driven by different historical forces. The histories of these events—the sources, causes, key actors, and larger meaning—were understood differently by different groups and were often used to advance various claims, including claims to political legitimacy. The Cold War, nationalism, and decolonization were interconnected in ways that, for much of the period and most of the non-European world, are impossible to disentangle.

#### NUCLEAR HISTORY

During the Cold War, many assumed that the history of the bipolar conflict and the history of nuclear weapons were one and the same. Cold War history was often told through the lens of nuclear events. Atomic and thermonuclear tests, the Cuban Missile Crisis, and the signing of major nuclear arms control treaties such the Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty and Strategic Arms Limitation Treaty of 1972 were seen as key turning points in the Cold War narrative. This view is not wrong: these crises and treaties were central to the relationship between the Soviet Union and the United States.

But nuclear weapons and the policies around them followed their own historical path. The enormous destructive power of the bomb and the increasing ability to deliver these weapons at great speed anywhere in the world would have transformed the international system regardless of how relations between the Soviet Union and the United States—or any other state—unfolded. While it is impossible to prove, nuclear weapons and the emergence of mutual assured destruction between the superpowers was perhaps the most important force keeping their confrontation “cold” and preventing a third world war. Large-scale, fully mobilized conflict, formerly a normal if profoundly destructive part of history, ceased to be a rational instrument of policy. The nuclear revolution would have sharply limited great power wars whether there had been a Cold War or not.

Major powers increasingly focused on how to prevent or deter wars, or keep them limited, rather than how to win them, even as the relationship between these goals became complicated. This changed focus revolutionized war and statecraft in ways that began during the Cold War but continued long after it ended.

Second, the spread of nuclear weapons was often driven by a logic only loosely related to the Cold War. Great Britain, France, and China were motivated to acquire the bomb both by Cold War considerations and for regional, imperial, and historical reasons. China's nuclear weapons eventually served more as a defense against its communist neighbor, the Soviet Union, than against the United States. India, Pakistan, Israel, and South Africa's weapons programs were shaped less by the Cold War than by regional tensions.

Third, the Soviet Union and the United States—bitter ideological and geopolitical rivals—surprisingly managed to cooperate to limit nuclear weapons. This cooperation was reflected in arms control treaties to restrict and sometimes eliminate whole categories of weapons. They also worked together to prevent other states—even allies—from getting their own nuclear weapons. These efforts included creating the International Atomic Energy Agency in 1957, negotiating a partial test ban treaty in 1963, and negotiating the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty of 1968. They also informally shared information about other nuclear aspirants with each other and generally tried to keep the number of nuclear-armed states as low as possible. This cooperation in the midst of a titanic ideological and geopolitical struggle, which defied many of our international relations theories, was enormously consequential. It also confounds a more traditional Cold War narrative.

Fourth, the history of the nuclear age continued after the Cold War ended and the Soviet Union disappeared and, short of complete global nuclear disarmament, will go on indefinitely. The catastrophic dangers associated with a nuclear war and the power of nuclear deterrence have profoundly altered the dynamics of war and peace. For this reason, nuclear history is perhaps the most consequential history since 1945. It is also the most difficult to assess in that it is largely a history of something that never happened: thermonuclear war.

#### GLOBALIZATION

The history of the world economy after 1945 has a clear dividing line, and surprisingly, it is not 1989 and the end of the Cold War. For the first two and a half decades after the Second World War, the world economy grew in impressive if uneven ways. This growth was based largely on national reconstruction and regional economic interaction, rather than global growth, finance, and opening markets. The Bretton Woods economic system emphasized stability and national management, fixing exchange rates while allowing managed trade and capital controls. To understand why and how this system developed and was popular, you would look to a different history from the Cold War: the volatility of the global economy after the First World War, the collapse of the US stock market in

1929, and the spread of the financial crisis to Europe with the failure of the Creditanstalt bank, headquartered in Vienna, Austria, in 1931. It is the history of the Great Depression—its origins, its terrible consequences, and the desire to avoid a repetition—that shaped much of postwar economic history.

After the Bretton Woods system disintegrated, in the early 1970s, the world economy became very different. Exchange rates were volatile, capital flows increased dramatically, and the volume of trade exploded. Decreases in the cost of transporting people and goods, a revolution in computing and profound innovations in finance and capital markets, a rising global middle class interested in consumer goods, and the popularity of free-market ideologies led to a newly intensified, globalized economy. Globalization drove growth in Western Europe in the 1950s and 1960s, then propelled the economies of East Asian countries including Taiwan, South Korea, Singapore, and Indonesia in the 1970s and beyond. This history is critical to understanding China's meteoric economic rise beginning in the 1980s, and it has been a key factor shaping international relations ever since. Billions of people emerged from dire poverty as a result.

A history focusing on the rise of what has come to be called neoliberalism would devote far less attention to military and geopolitical tensions and much more to the economic and ideological competition that marked the second half of the twentieth century. The historian Fritz Bartel contends that outcome of the Cold War was determined by the West's ability to adapt more quickly to changing global economic circumstances in the 1980s. In his interpretation, democracies, ironically, were better able than communist states to "break the promises" supporting the postwar social welfare state and embrace neoliberal practices.<sup>28</sup> Gary Gerstle uses the Cold War competition between the Soviet Union and the United States less to evaluate the conflict itself and more to understand a phenomenon that, for him, is more important—the emergence of the neoliberal, free-market order that he contends has dominated the United States and much of the world since the 1970s. "The collapse of communism," he writes, "cleared the world of capitalism's most ardent opponent."<sup>29</sup> Other historians, motivated by the intense and highly politicized contemporary debate, have gone back to the 1930s and earlier to understand the intellectual roots of globalization and neoliberalism. These histories focus less, if at all, on the geopolitical calamities of the world wars, the enormous shadow cast by nuclear weapons, or the conflicts that shaped the Cold War and more on capitalism as the driving force.<sup>30</sup>

#### ARAB NATIONALISM AND POLITICAL ISLAM

The 2002 and 2012 editions of our imaginary book, *History of International Relations, 1945–1991*, would devote much space to how the turmoil in the greater Middle East came to dominate contemporary politics. Readers would want to understand the deeper origins of these issues. Such a historical reconstruction might focus its attention on the



Suez Crisis of 1956, the 1967 and 1973 Arab-Israeli wars, the fall of the shah of Iran and his replacement by a fundamentalist theocracy, the rise of Palestinian nationalism, the civil war that ravaged Lebanon, and the political rebirths of Shia and Sunni Islam. The bloody war between Iran and Iraq, Muammar Gaddafi's erratic rule over Libya, and the Afghan mujahideen's battles against the Soviet occupation would be prominently featured. The 1992 edition might end, not with the dissolution of the Soviet Union, but with the American-led expulsion of Iraq from Kuwait. The 2022 edition—written as the United States left Afghanistan and reduced its focus on the Middle East—might see these sections as ripe for pruning. How much of this history is connected to the Cold War, and how much was it driven by other forces?

#### THE RIGHTS AND IDENTITY REVOLUTION

Since 1945, what it means to be a human being—in terms of both individual identity and how individuals relate to their social, cultural, and political communities—has been transformed in unimaginable ways. Although it sounds trite, the human experience for most people today looks almost nothing like what it was at the end of the Second World War, with profound consequences for social, cultural, economic, and political life. How people live and work, where and with whom they live, and how they identify and affiliate have all been transformed. Some of this was driven by global horror at the pogroms, genocides, and appalling human rights violations that plagued earlier decades; preventing more such crimes became a focus of international law and institutions in the middle of the twentieth century and later emerged as a powerful norm. While uneven and often contested, combating racial, ethnic, gender, and sexual orientation prejudice became a priority both in politics and in the larger culture of many societies and states around the world. Profound upheaval in the structure of the global economy, which generated enormous wealth focused on consumer consumption, combined with revolutions in technology, increased ease and decreased cost of travel, demographic shifts, and normative changes to put increased emphasis on the empowered individual. In many places (though certainly not most), individuals could—often for the first time—act and identify as they chose, without interference from traditional institutions or communal entities. This revolution in rights and identity may be the most important historical story for the largest number of people around the world, yet it is also the most complex to uncover and explain. Unlike foreign policy, it is not a history of singular events but of a tectonic shift in socioeconomic, demographic, and cultural forces.

We could easily identify other important, powerful strands by which to organize the history of the world in the late twentieth century. Is the Cold War the best frame for understanding this history? “As the Cold War continues to recede into history,” Matthew Connelly suggests, scholars will “have to work harder to explain its importance to future generations,” who will live in a world marked by different concerns.<sup>31</sup> Imagine a historical narrative focused on technology or the revolutions in food production, energy, entertainment, and culture—or on population and demographics, or the human-caused

destruction of the planet's ecosystem. My point is not that one subject or issue is more important than another. It is that history is often the contemporary act of deciding what in our past is important to us and why. These judgments are revealed by the histories we choose to tell. Challenging them should force us to explain and defend why these narratives and explanations deserve to matter more than others. It should also help us understand why others focus on histories different from the ones we choose. All these lessons can be applied to how we perceive our contemporary circumstances and make decisions about our future.

### Question 5: How Much Did Policy Matter During the Cold War?

Analysts and decision-makers understandably look to the past to identify times when interventions by governments produced good or undesired outcomes. Looking at the Cold War, what policy choices led to better outcomes, and which decisions led to worse—and what can we learn from these episodes? Might those lessons be applied to contemporary policy choices? Imagine that we wanted to look at what historians now see as a crucial decade of the Cold War: the 1970s. This period presents a fascinating puzzle; although the United States had “won” the Cold War competition by the late 1980s, that outcome seemed anything but certain a decade earlier. By the early 1990s, the United States had attained such a dominant position in the international system that many referred to it as unipolar. Does wise grand strategy alone explain this sudden and unexpected shift in fortunes?

In many respects, the 1970s were a dark time for America. The United States withdrew from the disastrous war in Vietnam in 1973 after fifty-eight thousand American soldiers and far more Vietnamese, Cambodians, and Laotians had been killed. Two years later, South Vietnam was conquered and incorporated into North Vietnam. The Middle East witnessed war, crisis, and instability, with the United States increasingly the target of the region's ire. Transatlantic relations were strained, as traditional Western European allies, whose economies had recovered impressively from the devastation of the Second World War, were less inclined to toe the American line in world politics. Independent states increasingly distanced themselves from the Cold War and instead defined international politics as a struggle between North and South, not East and West. United States politics were tarnished by the Watergate scandals and weak national leadership. Crime and drug use plagued American cities, and political life was polarized by race, ethnicity, and gender. The American economy suffered episodes of inflation mixed with recession, called stagflation, while the global economy endured debt crises, resource shortages, and currency volatility. Productivity increases and new technology seemed far more likely to emerge from Western Europe or Japan than the United States. Even the détente between the superpowers, signaled by the strategic arms control treaties, reflected the fact that the Soviet Union had caught up to the United States in nuclear weapons capabilities and surpassed it in conventional military power. The Helsinki Accords of 1975 acknowledged Soviet geopolitical

equality with America and legitimized its ruthless rule over the once independent states of Eastern Europe. There was a sense in some quarters that the United States was in decline, and the world was moving toward multipolarity. America's future as a world power did not seem especially bright. What happened?

There is, of course, a policy narrative to explain this extraordinary turnaround. The first place to look would be at the presidents of the time. President James Earl Carter, for all his other deficiencies, embraced a human rights framework that highlighted the abuses of the Soviet system and other authoritarian regimes. He also reversed his earlier policies to authorize a significant increase in American military expenditures. The real hero of the policy story, however, at least in certain accounts, is Ronald Reagan. Three policies have been identified as especially important. First, the administration dramatically increased the defense budget. Second, it supported anticommunist insurgencies in places as distant as Afghanistan and Nicaragua. Third, it pursued free-market reform at home, unleashing economic growth and innovation. The Reagan administration, it is claimed, abandoned détente and cooperation and instead sought to both reduce Soviet influence abroad and compel the USSR to cease its aggressive behavior.

As I mentioned earlier, some analysts believe that these policies forced the Soviets to adapt, leading eventually to the accession of a reformist leader, Soviet premier Mikhail Gorbachev. Gorbachev pursued economic and political changes while reducing and even eliminating various foreign adventures. Ultimately his reforms could not reverse the decline and eventual breakup of the Soviet Union. There are furious historiographical debates about which policies mattered more in ending the Cold War, the Soviet Union's or the United States', and how their policy decisions interacted with each other throughout the 1980s. Policymakers looking at the history of this decade might conclude that renewed ideological commitment, support for insurgencies, and renewed arms races (with a focus on technologically advanced weapons) are what won the Cold War. More important, they might decide that similar policies are the way to deal with current geopolitical challenges and authoritarian adversaries. The lesson for contemporary policymakers from this narrative seems clear: imitate the decisions made in the 1980s while avoiding the poor choices of the 1970s.

This is a compelling interpretation of the past and a beguiling guide to the future. It may well be correct. But there are some holes in the narrative. The Reagan policy process could hardly be described as ideal, as his administration was often unfocused, disorganized, and marked by bitter rivalries. Reagan himself was often disconnected from the debates within his administration. He supported nuclear disarmament, and especially in his second term, he sought to stabilize relations with the Soviet Union, not defeat it. American economic policies led to massively increased budget and balance of payments deficits, while the United States suffered deindustrialization, currency volatility, and banking failures. Furthermore, there were other important political actors, such as dissidents in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union and Pope John Paul II,

who played critical roles in the politics of the time. Nor were any of the decade's dramatic developments—glasnost and perestroika, the revolutions of Eastern Europe in 1989, the collapse of the Soviet Union—predicted or expected. There is a danger of retrospective bias when we try to apply causes to events that caught everyone by complete surprise at the time.

Which leads to a more profound point. The last quarter of the twentieth century certainly witnessed a profound shift in international relations. But how much of it was the result of wise statecraft? What if the factors, forces, and realities that changed the most—and mattered the most—were not driven by policy or political decisions made in such world capitals as Washington, London, and Moscow? To put it another way—if you were to ask visitors from outer space to identify the most important and consequential historical shifts in the half century after the 1970s, would the aliens even mention American foreign policy and geopolitics?

The aliens might instead point to three interlocking revolutions that emerged and gathered momentum in the 1970s.

The first is a revolution in rights and identity. Fixed notions about hierarchies of race, ethnicity, gender, and sexual orientation were upended. Discrimination based on these categories came increasingly to be seen as unacceptable, both legally and normatively. Adherence to a collective identity—based on one's birthplace, for example, one's church, synagogue, or mosque, or one's profession—gave way to complex, often individually crafted and flexible identities. This idea of freedom of identity, taken for granted in the twenty-first century, that a person was “free to be you or me,” was historically novel when it began to emerge during the 1970s. While it has had downsides and has generated intense counterreactions, the revolution in rights and identity grew popular in many places around the world.

Second, a more universal global culture emerged, at both the mass and elite levels. In many places, this global culture supplemented or replaced local, traditional norms and practices. This change was facilitated by a telecommunications revolution and a dramatic economic shift that allowed wider and cheaper mass consumption of both goods and culture. Governments and societies were increasingly judged by their ability to provide access to these global goods, be it movies, rock albums, microwave ovens, or computers.

Third, the private business sector experienced a dramatic makeover. This transformation had at least four elements. First, a revolution in telecommunications and computing power led to great increases in productivity in offices. Developments from the personal computer to the Internet made all the world's information available to anyone with access to computing hardware, disintermediated from legacy institutions or the state. Second, there were great changes in finance capitalism. On a global level, the volume, speed, and complexity of capital flows exploded. On the local and national levels, innovations from consumer credit cards to venture capital dramatically increased individuals' and firms' access to credit. Third, the global economy witnessed

a dramatic increase in the volume of trade, as the decreased costs of shipping goods around the world combined with the computing and finance revolutions to create complex, interconnected global supply chains. Fourth, the sources of economic and financial innovation changed. Historically, war and geopolitical competition, guided by the state, had driven many of the most important changes in technology, finance, and even governance. Much of the innovation from the 1970s onward, however, was created by the private sector to meet the consumption demands of an ever-growing global middle class.

These changes had at least two consequences for policymakers. First, the United States was the epicenter for these revolutions, and the transformations in identity, rights, culture, finance, and technology helped reverse America's decline in the 1970s and led to a rebirth in American power in the 1980s and beyond. Not only did the United States generate more wealth and technology to effectively compete with (and if necessary defeat) potential adversaries. The structure of its society, culture, and economy, focused on individualism, technology, and mass consumption, attracted adherents worldwide (while also generating sharp counterreactions). Second, the nature of the international system was transformed in ways that decision-makers are still struggling to understand. During the first three-quarters of the twentieth century, power was defined by a state's ability to mobilize a unified citizenry and exploit its demographic, natural resource, and industrial capabilities to both conquer and avoid being conquered. As a result of the changes that began in the 1970s, how we define power—and the ends to which a state can put it—have changed dramatically.

Analysts and policymakers might note that with this account of what mattered over the past half century, our aliens are making big arguments. The aliens would naturally ask: What were the sources of these great changes, which the world is still wrestling with? What policy did decision-makers in Washington during the 1970s implement to make them happen? The aliens would politely suggest that to understand these world historical shifts, the decision-makers might spend less time reading minutes of National Security Council meetings or memos from the State Department's policy planning staff. Instead, the aliens might be better served trying to understand what had happened out in sunny California during the 1970s.

The aliens might point observers to a young Arnold Schwarzenegger, the future movie star and governor of California, weightlifting on Muscle Beach with his friends, or to the rise of the pornography industry in the San Fernando Valley, both of which reflected profound shifts in attitudes toward the body and sex. Or they might turn their lens to the politics around sexual orientation and gender that were upended by Harvey Milk and the gay rights movement in San Francisco and by the legalization of no-fault divorce and abortion, both signed by none other than California governor Ronald Reagan. California-driven movements around identity politics fueled profound changes in politics and norms that, in time, spread to the rest of the country and eventually to much of the world.

On the cultural side, Hollywood's global rebirth in the 1970s, reflected by the international popularity of *Star Wars* and other blockbuster movies, revealed America's increased global heft in mass culture, while Napa Valley's emerging dominance in wine might join Alice Waters's Chez Panisse restaurant revolution to reveal elite cultural appeal. To understand the heart of the telecommunications revolution, observers would no doubt place Silicon Valley—a deliberate project of Stanford University, whose first company, Hewlett-Packard, opened its doors in the late 1930s—and the rise of Apple Computer at the center stage. Audiotape, videotape, the semiconductor, the integrated circuit, the personal computer, and many other life-changing devices all emerged from Silicon Valley. The aliens would also point out the novel ways of financing this new technology through private equity and venture capital firms located on Sand Hill Road in nearby Menlo Park, California. A trip to the port of Long Beach and Los Angeles and the new box container shipping method—in which a fully packed container can be quickly transferred from a ship to a railroad car or tractor trailer—would highlight the importance of exploding global trade, especially to the burgeoning economies of East Asia. All sorts of other California phenomena, from discount airlines to antitax populism, foretold the dynamic, chaotic world to come. In the years that followed, these complex and often confusing changes traveled first from California to the rest of the United States before eventually reaching almost every corner of the world, with profound socioeconomic, cultural, and political consequences. This historic change was driven, not by political choices made in world capitals, but by cultural, economic, technological, and social processes.

This argument, to be clear, may be exaggerated or even wrong. It might also underplay the role policy had in unleashing or channeling these sociocultural forces. The computer revolution, for example, had at least some of its roots in Cold War defense spending by the United States. And even if these forces did end up transforming how individuals live and societies operate, they may not have changed the fundamental rules of war and peace and of statecraft and strategy or the nature of world politics. Individualism, tolerance, consumerism, and technological innovation, it could be argued, were neither new nor unique to California, nor have they ended conflict. Instead, they have generated their own troubling global consequences, ranging from inequality to political polarization to a planetary climate crisis. Still, even if all this is true—that the California story is not crucial to understanding how the Cold War played out—this kind of unfamiliar analysis should remind decision-makers that policy is only a part, often a very small part, of what generates outcomes in world history and international relations. By posing the simple question—what was more important to how the Cold War ended and the post-Cold War world developed, Apple Computer and Levi's jeans or various US national security strategies?—analysts and policymakers are forced to think about and assess historical forces outside the foreign policy process and better understand how they shape the world they are trying to navigate. Sometimes,



decision-makers do best to recognize that policy itself can be of limited influence, or even irrelevant, in the outcomes we care about most.

## 4

# Insights and Tools

A historical sensibility allows us to revisit a past we thought we understood and see it through fresh eyes while challenging our core assumptions about how the world works. Can the insights generated from reexamining the Cold War provide guidance on the vexing challenges of statecraft and strategy that decision-makers face today? Can they be helpful in dealing with a rising China or a belligerent Russia, international economic turbulence, emerging technologies, the climate crisis—or future challenges yet unknown? In other words, how can the insight of a historical sensibility be converted into the power to think historically to inform better choices?

Richard E. Neustadt and Ernest R. May's *Thinking in Time* offered three ways for policymakers to use history to evaluate and make decisions. First, asking historical questions such as the ones we explored in the previous chapter should help reveal what is known, what is unclear, and what is presumed in their thinking about a policy choice. Historical thinking might help decision-makers better answer the questions “Why is a decision called for?” and “What is the hoped-for objective?” Second, policymakers would ask how any historical analogy that is put forward—in this case, the Cold War—compares with the current situation, such as the rise of China or renewed Russian belligerence. Fulfilling Neustadt and May's simple advice to determine likenesses and differences from the past would be illuminating. Third, they suggest that decision-makers follow what they call the “Goldberg rule”: instead of asking “what the problem is,” they should find out “what is the story.” This exercise, which involves asking questions about the origins and nature of the issue at hand, is similar to the exercise we pursued in the previous chapter, but a bit narrower.<sup>1</sup>

Neustadt and May's valuable insights—which built upon the legendary course for future policymakers at Harvard's John F. Kennedy School of Government—are a good start. The exercise of exploring the history of the Cold War, however, shows that thinking historically can provide decision-makers with even more powerful tools.

Several complementary insights stand out. First, thinking historically allows decision-makers to think deeply about causality and agency. Second, history forces them to reflect on time horizons and critical junctures. Third, a historical sensibility provides insight into the question of historical perspective. Fourth, thinking historically, like

policy, demands precision. Fifth, a historical sensibility highlights how different historical narratives, especially micro- and macroanalyses, need to be woven together into a coherent whole. Sixth, effective historical thinking protects against “paralysis by analysis” and reveals the necessity of choice. Seventh, it encourages policymakers and analysts to think about the questions they are asking about a choice they are facing and to explore whether they can craft better, more useful queries and apply them in a rigorous manner.

### Agency and Causality

Wrestling with simple but fundamental questions about the Cold War—or any major historical event or period—forces analysts and decision-makers to identify what they believe matters in the world and what generates historical change. What actors, forces, and processes matter most, and how can policy affect them?

In his classic work *Man, the State, and War* (1959), Kenneth N. Waltz identified three images or levels of analysis for those trying to understand international relations. The third image is the international system. The second is the units that make up the system, namely states. The first image is individuals and leaders who lead states. While not perfect, Waltz’s three levels make a good heuristic for thinking about what matters in the world and why. Perhaps, when looking at the Cold War, you are drawn to historical explanations that emphasize leaders and their choices: Truman and Stalin, Kennedy and Khrushchev, Gorbachev and Reagan. Employing a counterfactual analysis, you would argue that different individuals making different decisions at key times would substantially affect the origins and outcomes of the Cold War—or determine whether it happened at all. In trying to understand current China-US relations, you would spend a lot of time assessing the biographical details, background, and interests of particular leaders in the countries of concern. Understanding how Xi Jinping or Vladimir Putin thinks about the world would be critical. Looking to the future, you would keep an eye out for new leaders and try to understand their temperament, interests, history, and vision.

If, instead, you think that the most important determinants are the nature and characteristics of the states involved, you would focus on variables such as the political and institutional orientation of a state, its ideology, and its economic system; these, you believe, matter far more than who is in charge. If you think that the Cold War began because of ideological incompatibility between the Soviet Union and the United States, or the difference in economic systems, and that the United States ultimately prevailed because its political system and society performed better, then you might carry over a similar insight to today. Your analysis of China might focus on the incompatibility of its authoritarian system, on Russia’s personalist rule, and on America’s messy but open-market democracy. You might also concentrate on each state’s particular histories and cultures: you would note each country’s sense of exceptionalism and their divergent

experiences with foreign states interfering in their internal affairs. This insight would guide your statecraft and strategy moving forward.

If, alternatively, you were convinced by a historical explanation that highlighted systemic forces such as geography, resource bases, and economic and military power, you would be revealing a preference for third-image approaches. The coming of the Cold War, in this view, may have had a certain inevitability, based on the bipolar distribution of military power and the anarchic nature of the international system, which made cooperation between the two superpowers difficult if not impossible. You might find a so-called structural realist approach appealing and be convinced by theories that predict outcomes based on shifts in the balance of military power—such as Graham Allison’s book *Destined for War* (2017) on the phenomenon he labeled Thucydides’s Trap.

As you reflected on these historical viewpoints, a few things might cross your mind. You would wonder whether analysts consistently apply their worldviews to all the questions you asked about the Cold War. If they believed ideology or the balance of military power or specific diplomatic choices made by key leaders caused the Cold War, then you should expect *changes* in those variables to play important roles in their accounts of how the Cold War unfolded and why it ended. You would also expect these analysts to apply a similar lens to more recent or contemporary problems. As you dig into it, you note inconsistencies and realize that people often if unknowingly begin their analysis with their preferred policy outcome, often shaped by implicit normative beliefs, and apply an explanation only *ex post*. Thinking historically would help you, as a decision-maker, avoid the same mistake.

You might also find the sharp division among the three images too stark and undefined. Are demographic changes, shifts in norms, and emerging technologies—all key forces in world politics—a second- or third-image force (or, if a particular leader creates a technology or inspires a norm shift, first-image)? What about the economic or resource bases of power, which can change based on particular leaders’ policy decisions and vary among different kinds of states? Reflecting upon the sociocultural, economic, and technological changes that emerged in California in the 1970s, analysts might wonder about the times when policy and political choices, to say nothing of traditional considerations such as the military balance of power, mattered less to the outcomes they care about. How would Waltz’s typology explain other sources of power, such as Silicon Valley, modern finance capitalism, Hollywood’s global cultural reach, or the rights revolution—all forces that reshaped American power and the international system and affected the outcomes of US grand strategy?

This question would lead to an even more important observation. Waltz argued that the fundamental features of the international system (namely anarchy) are unchanging, meaning that states face the same challenges and dangers in the twenty-first century as they did during the Thirty Years’ War or the Peloponnesian War. This argument, however, would strike historically informed analysts as nonsensical. A

historical sensibility would tell them that over the past century, life expectancy had nearly doubled, nuclear weapons had transformed calculations about war and peace, the sources, nature, and purposes of state power had been transformed, and core features of what it means to be a human being in society had been revolutionized.<sup>2</sup> Given that so much else had changed, why would the structure and fundamental features of international politics be uniquely permanent? Consider demographics, one of the most important variables shaping the international system. As Matthew Connelly observes, “If one turns to the history of populations and public health—the kind of ‘structural’ history favored by the followers of Fernand Braudel—the period coinciding with the Cold War can be shown to have witnessed changes that were comparable to the impact of global nuclear war, only these changes unfolded over decades and had nearly the opposite demographic effects. The number of people living on earth more than doubled between 1945 and 1989.”<sup>3</sup>

Acknowledging such dynamically shifting structural forces would not lead decision-makers to throw up their hands in the face of a variable that was largely immune to policy.<sup>4</sup> Instead, it would sensitize them to the importance and volatility of demographics and cause them to incorporate this awareness into their policies.

Decision-makers might accept Waltz’s claim that international relations are like the state of nature and anarchic, but the image is not of a vacuum or the often-used billiard table and billiard balls. Instead, the state of nature that marked the international system would look more like the ecosystem of a pond and surrounding marsh, which could change in ways that might make it unrecognizable over time. Like all intended or unintended products of individual or collective human agency, the international system has a history that evolves. While the lessons of Thucydides or the Peace of Westphalia remain illuminating and instructive, there are limits to what they could reveal to people who live in a world that is in many ways fundamentally different from that of the past. Relying too much on these historical narratives could be as misleading and dangerous as ignoring them altogether, and thinking historically would help analysts recognize when the present and future are different from the past.

Analysts or decision-makers might also conclude, thinking historically, that the outcomes we care about are rarely explained by action on just one level of analysis. Understanding the past requires looking at forces that are hard to affect through policy, such as geography, culture, and demographics, long-term trends such as technology and economic growth, and the political disposition and structure of a state, as well as factors that are more open to influence, including the choices made by leaders. In analyzing any given situation, you likely would not only come up with a composite of influences but would recognize that each level or image—the system, the state, and the individual—interacts with and affects the others in complex and powerful ways. It would be hard to model those interactions, to say nothing of separating out each level to

analyze separately. Trying to simplify this complexity might do greater damage than recognizing and working with it.

### Time Horizons and Critical Junctures

Thinking historically compels decision-makers to reflect upon time in at least two important ways. First, they need to wrestle with time horizons. Second, they must think about critical junctures and pivot points.

A revealing mental exercise makes this point clear. Imagine that you told a government leader that within three decades, the country she or he led would transform itself. It would go from being the world's eighth or ninth largest economy, with an authoritarian, overly militarized domestic government, surrounded by enemies, to a nation with the world's second largest economy, built on one of the most innovative and stable societies in the world. Furthermore, it would become a peaceful liberal democracy with far fewer strategic challenges than in the past. What leader would not be thrilled by this development? The leader would imagine that their state would achieve this impressive result through a brilliant grand strategy.

In fact, this describes the change in Japan's global position between 1941 and 1970. In 1941, an overly militarized Japan made one of history's most foolish grand strategic decisions when it attacked the far larger, much stronger United States. At the end of 1942, the gamble appeared to many to have paid off, as Japan acquired an enormous empire throughout the Asia-Pacific region and seemed unbeatable on the battlefield. It was clear by 1943 or 1944, however, that the decision was bringing the country to utter devastation and defeat and, by 1945, to humiliation and foreign occupation. But by 1970, Japan under American protection had reinvented itself as a technological powerhouse, with a dynamic economy larger than every country but the United States. It was a peaceful liberal democracy with few pressing security concerns. Japan and its citizens were in a far better position in 1970 than anyone could have imagined three decades earlier.

Though not as extreme, wrestling with the history of the Cold War also provides insights into how to think about short-, medium-, and long-term policies and their consequences. There are limits, of course. Few political leaders will say, "Let's undertake a grand strategy that will lead to short-term ruin but miraculous long-term transformation." The story of Japan's postwar rise reminds us that as history unfolds, it is filled with ironies and unexpected outcomes. This should condition policymakers to avoid the temptation to seek only short-term political gain and to bear in mind that some policies take time to bear fruit. A policy, event, or outcome that is "good" six months later may be disastrous in six years, and vice versa.

Decision-makers must constantly calibrate time horizons and make temporal trade-offs, much as managers handle an investment portfolio: "How do I balance between immediate worries and opportunities and longer-term security?" Decision-makers will have noted in their analysis of the Cold War that some historical forces



shaping the conflict were long-term and structural while others were immediate and involved discrete choices. One Cold War historian, Odd Arne Westad, looked back to forces in the late nineteenth century to understand the Cold War. Another historian, Mary Sarotte, focused on the highly contingent choices made on one day and in one place—a small group of government officials in East Berlin on November 9, 1989—to show that there was nothing inevitable about how the Cold War ended.<sup>5</sup> Similar temporal trade-offs—understanding the interplay between short-, medium-, and long-term causes—will no doubt shape decision-makers’ policy choices.

There is also an interactive element. Short-term decisions affect longer-term considerations and vice versa, often in nonlinear ways. A political leader familiar with history’s unusual rhythms will also interpret evidence in a more subtle manner: what looks like a victory may generate long-term problems, whereas today’s disaster may produce future opportunities. These interactions remind us that history, strategy, and statecraft are similar pursuits—there is no “solving for X” or reaching an ultimate goal or end point. History, like statecraft, continues, and even the greatest successes breed new challenges and threats.

Time horizons can also work in reverse—as we move further away from an event, its power and hold over us changes, shifting our views about the present and the future. American Cold War planners operating in 1955 were only a decade removed from the carnage and total mobilization of wars against Nazi Germany, Imperial Japan, and fascist Italy. The Second World War cast an enormous shadow over how policymakers viewed their goals and the risks and rewards they faced. As time went on, this shadow of world war weakened. Policymakers in 1985, for example, had obviously not forgotten the Second World War, but it was deeper in the past and not as relevant to the challenges they faced. The immediate past dominates our thinking about the present as much as the immediate future. Thinking historically should make analysts aware that they have to calibrate the historical relevance of an event, regardless of when it occurred.

This highlights a second aspect of how decision-makers might think about historical time. Not all historical moments offer the same opportunities; some provide better chances for policy interventions to be especially significant. James Steinberg, writing about the Northern Ireland peace process, argued that “it is a vital tool of statecraft to be able to spot an opportunity when it is emerging.”<sup>6</sup> Thinking historically is the best training for that insight. The political leader looking at the Cold War will notice that certain times and circumstances were propitious for major policy efforts. President Dwight D. Eisenhower, for example, gave an address following the death of Soviet leader Joseph Stalin in early 1953 that is referred to as the “chance for peace” speech. Its conciliatory tone did little to soften the Cold War rivalry between the Soviet Union and the United States. Ten years later, John F. Kennedy gave a similar speech, “A Strategy for Peace,” at American University that many historians recognize as marking a

critical turn away from Cold War confrontation toward détente. While there are many reasons that Kennedy's effort succeeded where Eisenhower's failed, circumstances and timing were key. Eisenhower offered peace at a moment of unsettled relations within the Soviet bloc, when those who remained from Stalin's inner circle were jockeying for leadership in an environment of intrigue and mistrust. Kennedy's speech came less than a year after the terrifying crisis over missiles in Cuba had forced policymakers in both Moscow and Washington to reconsider their grand strategies and find opportunities to transform the rivalry.

Thinking historically allows policymakers to be sensitive to whether the environment is propitious for policy to generate desired change. The image for policymakers might be one of pivots and pulleys. Structural constraints make it far too difficult for them to lift an object or change a landscape on their own; but if they can identify the fulcrum of activity and attach the right machinery, they can dramatically affect outcomes. Thinking historically helps them identify the key leverage and pivot points, where a well-timed, well-crafted policy intervention can dramatically turn underlying forces in the right direction.

### Historical Perspective

After reflecting upon agency and causality, what matters in the world and why, and how to understand and assess varying time horizons, your historical sensibility would bring you to the question of historical perspective. Different issues matter to different people in different ways at different times. Consider, for example, the historical debates about the end of the Cold War. It is important to recognize an obvious point: that different actors have different interpretations of the events that shaped world politics between 1989 and 1991. Even the same actors may assess the events differently at different times.

In Washington, DC, many saw the end of the Cold War as validating the policies of containment. The decisions that maintained pressure on the Soviet Union, sometimes with economic and political means, at other times through proxy wars and covert operations, and at still other times through military buildups and arms races, however controversial these actions were when they were taken, were seen in retrospect as wise. Even those who thought that arms races accomplished little, and believed the Soviet Union had collapsed from internal weaknesses, largely conceded that those pathologies had been exposed by competition with the West. It would be natural for American analysts or policymakers in the decades after the Cold War to embrace these lessons as a guide to dealing with future challenges.

A different history and set of lessons might have emerged from Brussels, Bonn, and Paris. From the European perspective, perhaps the peaceful end of the Cold War was due less to competition and an arms race and more to the deescalation, cooperation, and institution building that took place on the continent in the 1980s. By focusing on integration, union, and turning "swords into ploughshares," the European

project had let the Soviet Union believe it had nothing to fear—and much to gain—from orienting toward Western Europe. If France and Germany, once bitter enemies, could bury their enmity and reconcile, and if Europe, the scene of murderous violence in the first half of the twentieth century, could be pacified, then perhaps the armed camps of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and the Warsaw Pact could relax and demobilize.<sup>7</sup> This lesson may have led European policymakers to emphasize trade and economic integration over security in the decades after the Cold War, as countries such as Germany and Italy dramatically decreased their defense expenditures. It may have also shaped their views toward China and Russia in ways that diverged from those in the United States.

In the decades after the Cold War, Moscow's narrative of 1989–91 might emphasize the Soviet leadership's tragic incompetence and their betrayal by the West's broken promises. Whereas the demise of the Soviet Union is a celebrated event in the United States and Europe, Russian president Vladimir Putin now calls it “the greatest geopolitical catastrophe of the century.”<sup>8</sup> The historical lesson Russian leaders glean from the Cold War might be that efforts to mirror the reforms of the West were doomed, embracing the liberal international order is folly, and the promise of a peaceful Europe from the Atlantic to the Urals always excludes Russia. Russia might look to a different history—its imperial history and past glories—to shape its future policies. Policymakers in the Kremlin, in other words, take much different lessons from the Cold War from those in the White House.

Beijing might have accepted part of Moscow's historical lesson but given it a different spin. Yes, the way the Cold War unfolded demonstrated that the West, and the United States in particular, can never be trusted. Yes, political reforms such as those undertaken by Gorbachev are reckless and unwise. But this lesson does not apply to economic reforms, which had to be dramatic and thoroughgoing to generate a dynamic, technologically advanced economy that would allow China to compete with and ultimately supplant the United States and its allies as the shaper of world order.

The perspective shifts once again if, after looking to the past, the analytical frame shifts from the Cold War to another historical stream. From the view of New Delhi, Lagos, Amman, Johannesburg, or Cairo, 1989–91 may have a different meaning altogether. The lens shifts further if we look outside the narrow confines of statecraft—perhaps to Silicon Valley or Hollywood. What we take from the past, in other words, often depends on who is asking, where they are, and when. For analysts or political leaders, it is important to recognize that their foreign and even domestic interlocutors may understand the same events in completely different ways from themselves.

Recognizing these competing histories goes a long way toward explaining disagreements and misunderstandings among global actors. This does not mean these contrasting histories have to be accepted. Statecraft and strategy will be more effective, however, if one acknowledges these contrasting visions of the past. Thinking

historically, in other words, helps decision-makers understand the historical sources of what, in the absence of a historical sensibility, appear to be irrational and irreconcilable worldviews.

### Precision

Decision-makers could be forgiven, after our detailed dissection of the Cold War, if they complained that the most important question—what precisely was it?—was never addressed. On offer were several different causes, actors and agents, starting and ending points, and drivers and forces, usually shaped by large themes and macro arguments. How do these big, expansive ideas help decision-makers make difficult choices about the typically narrow, often technical policy issues they regularly face?

It is understandable that discussions of foreign policy and international relations often use broad terms to describe the world and how it functions. Phrases such as *world order* or *the international system* are deployed, strategies are given labels such as *offshore balancing* or *primacy*, and decades-long historical periods receive names. As we saw in the last chapter, even a widely accepted, commonly defined term such as the *Cold War* contains complexities, controversies, and multiple perspectives.

But thinking historically also demands strict attention to the micro level. Like our policymakers, historians need to be precise—what exactly are the issues at hand and what options are available to us? Recall Philip Zelickow and the “historian’s microscope,” a tool he deploys brilliantly when reconstructing a controversial, consequential, but often misunderstood policy such as President William McKinley’s decision to take the Philippines in 1898–99. Only by thinking historically, and by carefully and expertly unearthing, examining, and placing together critical and often unseen evidence, can we understand important policy decisions and take lessons from them: “When it comes to historical episodes of import, even those that have been extensively written about and researched, it is often difficult to identify when the critical choices actually occurred. It is even more difficult to reconstruct, with policymakers’ eyes, the information available at the time, the institutional context, and the plausibly available alternative courses of action.”<sup>2</sup> Despite this difficulty, Zelickow lays out, with great precision, the choices and constraints McKinley faced as he considered his policies toward the Philippines, an approach that overturns more conventional interpretations of 1898–99.

A focus on precision does not imply that a historical sensibility requires ignoring broader, even structural forces. Marc Trachtenberg, in his history of the “constructed peace” of 1963 that settled the most dangerous issues of the Cold War rivalry between the Soviet Union and the United States, reconstructs in minute detail the intense, top-secret, often unconventional negotiations among adversaries and allies in a way that policymakers would recognize and appreciate. But Trachtenberg explains these detailed negotiations within the interlocking dynamics between two broad issues: the “German

question,” which concerned the military and political status and ambitions of the continental power that had plagued European politics for a century, and nuclear weapons, which had revolutionized world politics.<sup>10</sup> Trachtenberg and Zelikow both highlight how a historical sensibility uniquely combines and integrates the micro and macro in ways that reflect the realities of statecraft and strategy.

The Cold War exercise reveals how crucial it is to be precise about the historical—or policy—question you are asking. While not forgetting the larger, macro forces shaping statecraft and strategy, policy and history are similar in that they are about specific details and often involve nuance, context, and circumstances that can only be understood through Zelikow’s historian’s microscope. As James Joll reminds us, “General economic or sociological explanations are important in providing us with a broad sense of what is happening in history. It is only rarely that they can give us the precise link between the general and the particular which we need to account for the individual event the historian is trying to explain.”<sup>11</sup>

### Historical Integration

When constructing a history, good historians need to achieve something much like what effective policymakers often do: integrating cross-cutting and conflicting information and evidence of different kinds and qualities to create a cohesive, unified whole. Historical streams emerge from and are understood through varying spatial and temporal locations, and they come at us at different velocities. Historians collect, cull, and combine these streams in order to craft coherent narratives about what happened and why it matters.

Thinking historically allows us to make better sense of at least four different aspects of the past. First, it reconciles parallel and at times competing histories. Second, thinking historically requires one to appreciate divergent perspectives. Third, good history, like effective statecraft and strategy, must consider the interplay between micro and macro historical forces. And fourth, historians reflect upon and assess time horizons, or how causes and consequences differ depending on whether your focus is on the short, medium, or longer term. Good policy, like good history, should effectively weave together all four.

Integrating the first two aspects of the past—parallel histories and competing perspectives—might be done together. The history of the Cold War is instructive. Decision-makers, like historians, would come to understand that many different forces, from decolonization and nationalism to revolutions in technology, identity, and human rights, decisively shaped the world after 1945 and define our current circumstances. Even histories that were assumed to be largely the same, such as the histories of the Cold War and the nuclear age, might on closer inspection appear distinct and even in tension. How can these competing histories be reconciled? When is it best to understand them as distinct historical strands, and when and how should they be integrated and

understood together? Consider nuclear history. No state has used thermonuclear weapons, so there is no history of thermonuclear war. This makes it is easy to forget the powerful, often revolutionary, but hidden impact of the bomb on world affairs. Since the threat of thermonuclear use, no matter how unlikely, can never completely be ruled out, it casts a shadow over every historical stream.

Decision-makers will soon recognize that making sense of the contemporary world is not that different from efforts to understand the past. Many historical forces shape the world today. To better understand and make policies in the face of a rivalry with China, for example, American political leaders might gain much insight from the history of the Cold War, but they would recognize the power of other historical forces, such as globalization and decolonization. They might also see that there were new, emerging forces that had little effect in the past or that certain historical trends—such as technological changes or questions around human identity—had intensified to such an extent that they upended the international landscape, making it different from the world that came before. This might make the leaders skeptical of direct comparisons between their current policy choices and stylized narratives of the Cold War. They would ask those advising them to examine these comparisons with caution.

Decision-makers would not only need to integrate and make sense of these competing historical streams. They would need to account for divergent understandings of the past among adversaries (and allies and even fellow citizens), which often reveal the underlying causes of contemporary disputes. Comprehending Beijing's and Moscow's dramatically different understandings of the end of the Cold War might help them see their perspective of world politics in more recent times. This does not mean that policymakers must embrace these contrasting interpretations of the past: far from it. Understanding this divergence, however, would provide a level of "strategic empathy" that might yield a diplomatic advantage and help avoid unnecessary conflict. It could also create larger spaces for compromise or highlight an adversary's vulnerabilities.

Historical integration allows analysts to weave together different strands of reality—from the long-term and structural to the immediate and short-term. Much like policymakers thinking about Waltz's three levels, analysts must sort out which forces matter most and how they interact, to weave together the macro with the micro, as Trachtenberg did in his historical reconstruction of the "constructed peace" settlement of 1963 and as Zelikow did with the history of President McKinley's decision to take the Philippines in 1898. At the same time, policymakers must weigh varying time horizons—short-, medium-, and long-term.

These aspects of thinking historically—integrating varying historical forces and accounting for diverging time horizons—are related. Some macro forces, such as sociocultural, normative, economic, demographic, and technological changes, unfold over longer time horizons, while micro forces often reflect specific choices made in constrained time periods by individuals who had no idea how the future would unfold. The events, actors, and phenomena we seek to understand come to us through a mixture



of shorter- and longer-term causes, and both structural forces and particular choices. Historians must integrate and create coherent narratives that can be understood and assessed by larger audiences. Good policy should do the same—understanding different historical streams of causal forces and varying perspectives of different agents while incorporating both the short and long term, the micro and macro, in any analysis.

### Counterfactual Analysis

Thinking historically allows us to evaluate contrasting perspectives —temporal, spatial, and other—of a shared past. Although what actually happened is not always in doubt, why the past unfolded as it did, and more important, why it mattered and what it meant, are often contested.

Thinking historically should also sensitize observers to the idea that what happened might have turned out differently if one or more variables had been altered. In other words, it involves counterfactual reasoning, or exploring alternative pasts and futures. Any historical analysis or explanation is necessarily a causal account, which, unless we believe that the world unfolds according to a preordained plan, means that had one thing or another been different, it could have produced other possible worlds.

Counterfactual examinations ultimately come down to a practical question we all ask: Are our present political and socioeconomic circumstances the result of inevitable historical forces, or could things have turned out differently if people had made different choices, if circumstances had been different, or if chance events had intervened? While many of our larger explanations convey a certain path dependence, if not inevitability, we intuit that there is far more room for different outcomes if different conditions had held sway. The very act of decision-making requires us to envision at least two different worlds that would unfold if we made one choice rather than another. If we can imagine different futures, we must also imagine that there could have been different pasts. Recognizing the malleability of the future forces us to look more closely at the past and ask when, where, and how things could have turned out differently.

Counterfactual reasoning is controversial. Historians are not alone in resisting it, arguing, quite reasonably, that correctly identifying and understanding what happened in the past is difficult enough without the additional burden of evaluating what didn't happen. It is hard to say anything meaningful about agency and causality concerning events or phenomena that don't exist or did not occur, and there is no way to prove statements that emerge from counterfactual assertions. Furthermore, a historical sensibility highlights the difficulty of isolating one variable with which to run a counterfactual experiment for complex sociopolitical phenomena. There are few singular historical causes, and most variables are so deeply intertwined that it is impossible to separate them out; recall John Lewis Gaddis's assertion that for historians, there is no such thing as an independent variable.<sup>12</sup>

These are important considerations. But if observers are aware of the challenges of counterfactual exercises and employ them responsibly, they can provide enormous insight. It is often suggested that a plausible counterfactual exercise should tinker with the past as little as possible. If changes are made, they should not be unreasonable. For example, it is pointless to speculate what nineteenth-century world politics would have looked like if Napoleon had possessed nuclear weapons, since such a variable is historically implausible. This does not mean, however, that a small shift in past variables can't lead to big changes in how history unfolds. The key is to identify factors or choices that would have led to different outcomes if they were changed while also recognizing how interconnected (and sensitive to change) the variables are. This reasonableness requirement must be balanced with an openness to changing unusual or unexpected variables and to resist hindsight bias when constructing the counterfactual exercise.<sup>13</sup> Given that the future often surprises us and presents us with challenges or circumstances no one could have predicted, we should keep the same openness when altering variables in the past.

Edward Hallett Carr claimed that the study of history is the “study of causes”; statecraft and strategy are also the study of causes with an aim toward adjusting to, manipulating, or altering causes to generate more desirable outcomes. Done well, counterfactual thought experiments give us valuable insight into why things happen. For example, they can highlight when randomness or luck plays a key role. On June 28, 1914, Serbian nationalist Gavrilo Princip and his colleagues botched their first effort to assassinate Archduke Franz Ferdinand. Later, however, the archduke's motorcade made a wrong turn and, in the effort to reverse, stalled the royal car near a café where Princip happened to be. He seized the unexpected chance to carry out the murder. Any number of random changes in either Princip's or Ferdinand's path that day would have avoided the tragedy. Would the First World War, and all the geopolitical and revolutionary earthquakes that followed, have been avoided if only Ferdinand had had a better driver? Wrestling with that plausible tweak to the past can uncover much about how we think about causes, in both history and policy.

Counterfactuals can also highlight the role of individuals. In our Cold War exercise, it is difficult to imagine the end of the Cold War unfolding as it did with someone other than Mikhail Gorbachev as the Soviet head of state. There are other illuminating examples. In 1944, during his last presidential campaign, President Franklin D. Roosevelt dropped Henry Wallace as his vice president and replaced him with Harry S. Truman. Wallace's views on the Soviet Union and the need to build upon the wartime alliance were far different from Truman's. Would the Cold War have played out differently—or not have happened at all—if Wallace and not Truman had succeeded Roosevelt after his death in April 1945? Or consider the two great decision points the United States faced about military involvement in Southeast Asia, in 1954 and 1965. President Eisenhower's vice president, Richard Nixon, enthusiastically supported

American military involvement in 1954 to rescue the French from their faltering position. President Lyndon B. Johnson's vice president, Hubert Humphrey, thought in 1965 that American escalation in Vietnam was unwise. The mental exercise of imagining that Nixon and Humphrey, instead of Eisenhower and Johnson, had been the decision-makers allows us to evaluate whether the outcomes would have been quite different under different presidents.

Counterfactuals also allow us to look at specific decisions and their consequences. Can we construct a plausible counterfactual where President Harry S. Truman decides not to order United States forces to intervene to support South Korea against an invasion from the north in June 1950? Months earlier, Secretary of State Dean Acheson had suggested that protecting Korea was not a vital American interest. How and why did that assessment change? Or what if, instead of boycotting the United Nations Security Council on June 25 and June 28, 1950, the Soviet Union had attended those meetings and vetoed the resolutions that authorized the American military reaction? What if the United States had decided not to devote scarce resources and forces to the conflict in Korea and instead focused on defending more strategically important, vulnerable areas such as Western Europe, the Middle East, and Japan? What if Truman had decided to intervene in Korea but not deploy the US Seventh Fleet to defend Taiwan? There are endless examples of highly contingent decisions made that could have produced much different historical outcomes.

Counterfactual thought experiments can reveal how you think about what drives history. A structural realist, who focuses on systemic material forces as the primary driver of important outcomes, presumably would not say that the world would be much different if you changed variables such as specific leaders or the political nature of the regime making decisions. A structuralist view, focused on the balance of material forces as the key variable shaping outcomes in the world, might discount what a President Henry Wallace (instead of Truman) would have done, or wouldn't necessarily think that a democratic Russia would have done much after 1945 that a Stalinist one would not. Gorbachev and Ronald Reagan would have been epiphenomenal variables, not of primary importance to understanding why, how, and when the Cold War ended.

Although decision-makers differ on what historical forces and causes matter most and in what combinations, they all believe that discrete choices made by specific individuals matter—otherwise, why make decisions or pursue statecraft and strategy at all? If you believe that decision-makers face choices, that these choices are consequential, and that some choices are better than others, then examining the past through a counterfactual lens is unavoidable. This is not to say that decision-makers—or historians—are unaware of the restraints placed on the freedom of action by larger factors, including structural forces. The whole process of policy makes little sense, however, if you don't think there is room for choice, that the choices matter, and that they must be evaluated in comparison to other choices. Thinking historically allows one

to responsibly identify those choices in the past while exploring plausible alternative histories.

## The Necessity of Choice

A historical sensibility, properly honed, should help us understand, evaluate, and make these consequential choices.

This might not be obvious at first. Recall the earlier discussion of historical vertigo. The past can be so overwhelmingly complex that we freeze in the face of it. The Cold War exercise reveals the potential for a historical sensibility to make this “paralysis by analysis” even worse. The decision-makers were exposed to competing histories that revealed different lessons and insights. Actions in the past were judged wise or foolish based on when they were assessed, and different timelines produced different judgments. Divergent perspectives on the past could also unsettle the decision-makers, leading them to wonder whether there is no “right” decision, only choices that advance a particular interest.

But thinking historically also guards against historical vertigo and paralysis by providing four key insights.

First, historically induced caution is not necessarily a bad thing. Policymakers pursuing statecraft and strategy are often biased toward action. Although paralysis should be avoided, the prudence and humility a historical sensibility urges can be beneficial. It produces more thoughtful, nuanced, well-considered decisions and avoids rash mistakes. More and deeper knowledge is always better than less.

Second, thinking historically reminds us that *not acting* is also a decision with consequences. Action and inaction must therefore be analyzed through similar metrics and the same analytical lens. Deciding *not to choose*, through paralysis or for other reasons, is a choice, and it can lead to catastrophe as easily as an activist bad decision.

Third, a historical sensibility helps analysts or decision-makers recognize that not all choices, at all times, are created equal. Some policy interventions, well timed for when conditions are “ripe,” can have profound, nonlinear consequences. In other words, thinking historically should improve our understanding of timing and circumstances: when it is most advantageous to intervene. Thinking historically is not just about cautioning against bad decisions; it should help alert decision-makers to opportunities that might otherwise be missed. The Marshall Plan, the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty, Kissinger and Nixon’s opening to China, President George W. Bush’s Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief in Africa—history might inspire bold, creative policies that more conventional epistemologies might abjure.

Fourth, policymakers and analysts often focus on the initial decision or choice but then will not revisit it. Thinking historically, however, should lead decision-makers to continually ask, after the initial decision has been made, if the choice was correct or should be updated, adapted, or corrected. Similar to what social scientists call Bayesian updating, thinking historically should allow quicker course corrections to a

policy as new evidence emerges and is evaluated. The modesty and humility induced by a historical sensibility allow us to recognize bad choices earlier and to be less committed to sticking with a poor decision to the very end.

### Asking Better Questions

Thinking historically assigns great importance to how we both ask and answer questions, whether about the past, the present, or the future. By revisiting the Cold War, we learn that framing questions in certain ways—such as around “blame” or “winning”—can be counterproductive to cool-headed analysis. Other questions, which appear to be crafted in neutral or scientific tones, turn out to reveal normative biases. Perhaps the most important tool thinking historically can provide to analysts or decision-makers is to improve their ability to ask better questions, to sharpen the focus of their queries, and to be more aware of the assumptions behind the questions they ask, why they are asking, and how. In this way, thinking historically can lead to better questions, better answers to those questions, and, it is hoped, better policies.

Two images capture how this historical sensibility translates into effectively thinking historically through better questions. We may think of it as a powerful magnet, drawing in relevant information that may be hidden, enmeshed in nonmagnetic materials, or too far away to obtain without the magnet’s power. The magnet—or historical sensibility—pulls into view people, events, and historical forces that are often not seen or are obscured in other forms of analysis. To move to the act of thinking historically, another image emerges: a chemical dye, dropped in a large sample, that bonds to and highlights what truly matters. In other words, a historical sensibility married to thinking historically, at its best, pulls out the necessary and important knowledge while ruthlessly eliminating the overwhelming mass of extraneous or distracting information. The past is infinite, and without the powerful, well-thought-out filters and guidance that thinking historically provides, it will likely overwhelm decision-makers.

Learning how to best deploy the magnet and use the dye properly is crucial. Asking better questions is essential to those tasks.

## 5

# The History Checklist

The most important element thinking historically offers is generating more and better questions: a historical sensibility leads the observer to question everything. As we saw in [chapter 3](#), interrogating the sharp debates on the origins and causes, consequences, varying perspectives, historical weight, and end of the Cold War demonstrates the extraordinary power and insight generated by historically oriented questioning. This type of historical exercise, of course, is not limited to understanding the Cold War; these methods and questions could be applied to any historical event, period, or phenomenon to provide insight while challenging what we think we know. It allows for a whole different way of understanding and evaluating the past and its relationship to today.

Rigorously exploring the past should be the standard practice for anyone interested in statecraft and strategy. But few decision-makers possess the patience or time for deep, at times disorienting historical analysis and revision. Such an exercise, while useful for a graduate seminar in historiography, appears to be far removed from the intense daily pressures that often consume a life of making difficult, contentious, consequential choices. Decision-makers, quite understandably, might not have the time, inclination, or political capital to question widely held assumptions or accepted narratives about crucial subjects. Furthermore, decision-makers are unlike scholars in one important respect: their perspective, the lens through which they view the world and its challenges, is clear. They represent and advance the interests of the entity that employs them: for example, the US government, located in Washington, DC, on behalf of the American people. They hold no brief for the 1950s or the sixteenth century, nor do they speak for New Delhi or Lagos or peasants or Jacobins or a multinational firm. Their colleagues in other capitals—and, indeed, boardrooms—no doubt feel the same way. Nor does in-depth historical autopsy provide a clear answer to the question they care about the most: What should they do?

One of the great insights of a historical sensibility is that there are few foolproof methods to provide indisputable answers about what decision-makers should do when facing complex, interdependent challenges in the face of radical uncertainty about the future. Thinking historically makes this problem worse: it encourages useful skepticism about parsimonious, hedgehog-like frameworks, often associated with the more



muscular social sciences, to guide human political and social behavior. But while historical thinking cannot tell policymakers what to do, it can improve their decision process. Of the seven insights and tools offered in the preceding chapter, the last—asking better questions—is both the easiest and the most important.

What should those questions be?

During the 1930s, as American plane manufacturers were developing larger, faster, more complex planes that might need to be flown by better-trained pilots, a novel but powerful concept was developed: a checklist. The checklist was a series of simple but important questions the pilot and crew would ask to check the status of the airplane before taking off. Were the turbos and autopilot off? Check. Were the tailwheel locked and the gyro set? Check. A uniform list allowed flight crews to dramatically reduce crashes caused by pilot error. It is now a standard operating procedure for pilots around the world.

After it was adopted by emergency room physician Atul Gawande, the checklist concept dramatically reduced human error and mortality in hospitals. “Medicine,” Gawande wrote in his book *The Checklist Manifesto*, “has become the art of managing extreme complexity—and a test of whether such complexity can, in fact, be humanly mastered.”<sup>1</sup> Similar to statecraft and strategy, “intensive care succeeds only when we hold the odds of doing harm low enough for the odds of doing good to prevail. This is hard.”<sup>2</sup>

The checklist has been applied to any number of important, complex activities. Can it help decision-makers manage complexity and minimize harm while making foreign policy? Might a checklist help the analyst or scholar make sense of statecraft and strategy? Below are twelve historical questions worth asking when approaching a contemporary dilemma, challenge, or choice. Each question, while simple and clear, is connected to an important and at times counterintuitive historical insight or practice. The checklist can be employed by scholars seeking to understand the past, analysts assessing the present, or policymakers making choices about the future.

It is not a perfect comparison; there are profound differences between the checklists for aviation and medicine and the historical one I present here. The first two are meant to generate simple, binary answers—yes or no—or specific measurements, whereas the questions on the history checklist are open-ended, interpretive, and often messy. Also, even though an effective checklist should contain a uniform and limited number of clear queries, there are also more than twelve historical questions worth asking. One could imagine more detailed, ultimately more effective checklists developed for specific areas of statecraft and strategy—implementing foreign aid, for example, or defending against an amphibious invasion. As Gawande points out, checklists for medical procedures are constantly adapted, tailored, and sharpened with experience. I offer this list in the hope that others—both historians and decision-makers—might improve it.

To be clear, the purposes of a historical checklist should not be limited to making better policy or wiser choices or to comprehending the contemporary world. These historical concepts and queries should be used to improve our understanding of the past and its relationship to the present. This list—or one like it—might be exploited by historians and other scholars whether they are connected to decision-making or not. Historians, for reasons we’ve discussed, are not always explicit about the assumptions shaping their work, their methods for arriving at answers, or their understanding of agency and causality. Wrestling with these questions requires them to bring those beliefs to the surface.

Below are the twelve questions that comprise the historical checklist, as well as the historical concept each is associated with.

1. How did we get here? (vertical history)
2. What else is happening? (horizontal history)
3. What is unsaid? (unspoken assumptions)
4. How are things trending? (time lags and historical anamnesis)
5. How is this understood by others? (historical perspective)
6. Why does this matter? (chronological proportionality)
7. What are the possible unexpected outcomes? (unintended consequences)
8. Was this inevitable? (outcome bias)
9. Are things changing rapidly? (punctuated equilibrium)
10. Are we using the past correctly? (historical malpractice)
11. Was this unprecedented? (historical myopia)
12. What does it mean? (historical purpose)

### Question 1: How Did We Get Here? (Vertical History)

When policymakers face a crisis or a critical choice, the first question they should ask is, “How did we get here?” This is also what historians explore when trying to understand an event, a person or group, or a phenomenon. What factors and forces, what actors—either individuals or large, nameless structural forces—brought us to this moment? When did this event or phenomenon begin, who or what is responsible, and how did it happen? These are obvious but critical questions that policymakers, in the heat of the moment, may forget to ask or may investigate haphazardly. If done right, the question “How did we get here?” is not simply asked once and forgotten but revisited as new facts, circumstances, and perspectives are brought into play.

Vertical history involves the most basic historical skill, one we learn in history classes well before we get to college: establishing the chronology, or figuring out what things happened and in what order. Though it probably seemed boring and repetitive in our grade school and high school classes, historians rigorously demand attention to the chronological order of events for a reason: within the timeline lies the answer to who or

what matters, how, and why. Chronology is the first step toward revealing agency, causality, and historical direction. To find out why and how things happened, we must first determine what followed what. While constructing this chronology, we often become aware of important facts, data, connections, interactions, and circumstances that earlier analyses have left missing or incomplete. Vertical history tells us what evidence we possess and what we might need to search for.

When trying to make sense of an event or phenomenon, historical thinking first identifies its temporal origins while trying to understand how it unfolded over time. Asking how we got where we are appears simple—when did the thing we care or worry about start? But in trying to answer that question, we are soon faced with important choices. How far back in time should we go? When and where does a historical process begin? If we have identified a series of events or phenomena as potential starting points, which are the most important? This is especially challenging when the candidates for an origin or starting point vary in how recent they are. Do we focus on the short term, the medium term, or the longer term—and where are the boundaries of these terms? As we saw in earlier chapters, this task is not always straightforward. How and where we begin is not simply a narrative convenience; where we begin our analysis and the story we reconstruct reveal what causes and agents we think matter most in the world.

To provide an obvious but extremely important example, imagine that you want to understand the origins of the First World War. It is easy to see why you might investigate this: that war had enormous consequences, both immediately, in the century that followed, and even today. Millions were killed and several European empires collapsed, spawning revolution and new nationalism, while the United States completely reoriented its relationship with the world. How do we construct a chronology of the events and forces that led to the First World War?

A short-term history might focus on the events after the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo on June 28, 1914, and the political and military crisis this provoked in major European capitals in the six weeks that ensued until war broke out in early August. This sort of analysis would concentrate on the intense diplomatic exchanges within and between governments and on each state's military and mobilization plans. Day-to-day decisions and the individuals and institutions making them would take center stage.

A history focused on intermediate causes might examine the great power rivalries that emerged in the decade or two before the war. One view might start with Germany under Kaiser Wilhelm II—its rapid economic ascent, its aggressive foreign policy, and Wilhelm's belief that Germany's newfound strength should be reflected in a global imperial presence. If you believed that the main driver of the war was the ongoing crisis in southeastern Europe, you might start with the First and Second Balkan Wars, the Bosnian Crisis of 1908, or, as Christopher Clark does in his landmark study *The Sleepwalkers*, the coup of May 1903 in Serbia. Another perspective might emphasize

the development of the two European alliance groupings: the Triple Entente, made up of France, Russia, and Great Britain, versus Germany and Austria-Hungary.

What if you believed that the war's roots went deeper and further back? Perhaps the intensifying late-nineteenth-century arms races among the European powers—especially the naval competition between Germany and Great Britain—was the driving cause of the deepening tension. Maybe larger phenomena, such as the growing imperial rivalry throughout the world, generated the tensions that made conflict inevitable. The profound socioeconomic changes wrought by industrialization, nationalism, and urbanization, combined with dramatic demographic shifts, might be identified as the driver of world war. Or cultural forces such as social Darwinism might play the leading role.

What causes are most important—short-, intermediate-, or long-term? The natural answer, for both historians and policymakers, is to say, “All of them!” That answer doesn't help us. Recall the exercise in the third chapter, which required you, as a hypothetical author, to fit the history of international politics between 1945 and 1991 into just three hundred pages. What events, factors, and forces would you focus on, and what important events would you be forced to leave out? The past is infinitely large, and in our desire to understand and explain how we got where we are, we must identify and focus on the most important factors. The same is true for making policy. To be useful, an explanation requires choices about what matters, when, and how. And what you choose reveals how you think the world works.

Consider another three-hundred-page book, this time exploring the origins of the First World War. At one extreme, if you believe that the assassination of the archduke was the key event that generated the crisis, you might spend a good part of the book focused on the events of June 28, 1914, in Sarajevo. It turns out that there were many plot twists: as we saw, after an earlier assassination attempt failed, the archduke's driver made a wrong turn while trying to get to safety, where his car stalled in full view of the surprised assassin. There was an element of randomness to the whole day. If Ferdinand had left Sarajevo unscathed—or, as many advisers had begged him, had not gone in the first place—would the First World War, and all that followed, have been avoided?

Perhaps you take a different view—that deep, long-term structural forces were at work in the decades before the war, driving Europe to conflict. The events of June 28, 1914, might deserve a paragraph or two, but not as a driving cause of the conflict. Instead, you might discuss how many Europeans feared that geometric population increases would outstrip the limited supply of food and other resources, generating pressures to acquire new territories, on the continent or elsewhere, to provide for citizens. Your analysis might focus on the causes of this population surge and the anxiety it generated—perhaps manifested by intensifying nationalism and social Darwinism. In this kind of deeper explanation, a conflict may have been, if not inevitable, then highly

likely, and the strange events of June and July 1914 were less consequential than the underlying forces that brought Europe to crisis.

The important insight is that how you construct the vertical history reveals your beliefs about causes. Recall our discussion, in the third chapter, of Kenneth N. Waltz's classic text *Man, the State, and War* and the three levels of analysis one could bring to international relations: first-image variables, or the decisions of individuals; second-image explanations, or the characteristics and operations of particular states or regimes; and third-level, structural or systemic explanations. What matters more in the outcomes we care about—the decisions of particular people, especially leaders? The actions of collective entities such as states? Or impersonal structural forces, such as the balance of military power, geography, or demographics? Naturally, these forces interact with each other. How can that dynamic be captured in both a historical analysis and a policy evaluation? The historical forces that you consider most consequential will shape the narrative you construct, and even if you aren't explicit about causes, how you tell your story will reveal your assumptions about what matters.

Most convincing explanations include elements of all three levels. The challenge for both policymakers and historians is how to integrate them into a coherent whole while also recognizing that each historical driver and level influences the others. The First World War likely does not start in August 1914 if the archduke's driver makes the correct turn on June 28. That a wrong turn could cause a global conflagration, however, may reveal that the war was the product of long-simmering intermediate and longer-term causes, caused by deep structural forces as well as the choices made by European states and empires and their leaders in the preceding decades. Some types of historical causes, such as culture, technological innovation, or economics, may not fit strictly into Waltz's three images; they might contain elements of two or three levels, or they might need their own category.

When undertaking this kind of historical integration, both historians and policymakers must ask: How far in the past should I look? Consider America's contentious relationship with Iran. How much does the Central Intelligence Agency-aided coup in 1953 against Iran's prime minister Mohammad Mossadegh explain the revolution of 1979 in Iran, or the poisonous Iran-US relations in the 2020s? Is it determinative, irrelevant, or in between? Similarly, does NATO's decision in the 1990s to expand to include former Warsaw Pact states help explain Russian aggression against Ukraine, and if so, how? Is there a limit to how far back we can go, an "expiration date" for historical causes?

The question "How did we get here?" has few cut-and-dried answers. As we saw in [chapter 3](#), even defining the precise start or end of a crucial event is not always as obvious as we think. This concern may sound interesting only to scholars, but it is also critical for policymakers. The very act of asking how we got here, and of continually revisiting and reframing the question, allows us to think more clearly and carefully about why the things we are focusing on have happened. It tests our assumptions about

agency and causality and thus allows us to identify how and where we might intervene—what policy choices we might make—to shape the outcomes we desire.

## Question 2: What Else Is Happening? (Horizontal History)

Thinking historically should cause the analyst to ask, “What else is happening?” Understanding the past doesn’t just reveal how things relate over time; it can expose horizontal connections over space and in depth. Good historical work can move laterally to reveal linkages between issues and entities that are not apparent at first glance. This is the horizontal or spatial-depth axis on a historian’s imaginary graph. Policymakers are likely familiar with this phenomenon at some level; much of what they do or choose is connected, often in unexpected ways, to other issues and choices.

Consider an example from American foreign policy in the early 1960s: the obscure issue of the US balance of payments deficit. For a variety of reasons, including the inefficient and contradictory rules of the Bretton Woods monetary system, the United States began hemorrhaging dollars abroad, and during the later years of the Eisenhower administration and the Kennedy presidency, countries used these surplus dollars to purchase US gold. Both presidents became obsessed with stopping the gold and dollar outflow because they both connected the deficit to their own lessons of history—the economic conditions that caused the Great Depression of the 1930s. Both administrations sought to end the dollar and gold drain without resorting to deflationary policies such as interest rate hikes, trade barriers, and capital controls, which would depress the domestic economy.<sup>3</sup>

Both presidents demanded that their administrations identify and decrease the sources of the balance of payments deficit. But it turned out that much of the US current account deficit was produced by the nation’s costly overseas military commitments, particularly in NATO countries. And the most expensive part of the military account was the stationing of almost three hundred thousand fully supplied US troops and their dependents in the Federal Republic of Germany, the country that, not coincidentally, ran the largest payments surplus with the United States. Reducing these foreign exchange costs, either through troop redeployments or by getting the West Germans to offset these outlays by buying US military equipment, became the primary foreign economic policy goal of Presidents Eisenhower, Kennedy, and Johnson.

But this focus on the balance of payments costs of US overseas military commitments created enormous difficulties in other critical policy arenas. What if the West Germans refused to offset the costs of American military expenses? And even if they were willing to pay, would it appear mercenary to charge an ally on the front line of the Cold War what would look like a protection fee? At a time when mutual vulnerability to a devastating nuclear response with the Soviets was emerging, wouldn’t pulling troops out of Western Europe undermine the credibility of America’s commitment to defend its allies? And how would the Soviets interpret a troop



withdrawal? How would this clash of economic and security issues affect the cohesion of the Western alliance?

The issue becomes even more complex when we consider the influence of nuclear policies and politics. Europeans on both sides of the Iron Curtain were loath to see the Federal Republic of Germany develop or acquire atomic weapons, and the Soviet Union (and France and Great Britain) made it clear that an atomic West Germany would cause them grave concern. But if the Americans even considered pulling out troops for something as prosaic as balance of payments reasons, could West Germany responsibly leave its security in the hands of the United States? And if it faced a nuclear-armed Soviet behemoth and the Warsaw Pact while relying for its defense on an unreliable and mercenary ally, wouldn't it be prudent to at least consider acquiring nuclear weapons—especially since France and Great Britain had them?

In the end, a series of complex and hard-fought deals were worked out that persuaded West Germany to maintain its nonnuclear status, protected the dollar, and lessened the outflow of US gold. The Americans pulled out some troops, and the West Germans agreed to buy significant amounts of US military equipment while not cashing in their surplus dollars for gold. What is interesting for both policymakers and historians was how this obscure and secondary issue—the balance of payments deficit—influenced a wide range of issues, from international trade negotiations to the politics of the German question to the so-called flexible response strategy to a dramatic shift in America's nuclear nonproliferation policies.

To give just a taste of these unexpected linkages, consider National Security Adviser Walt Rostow's response to a memo from the presidential negotiator Averell Harriman to Lyndon Johnson in October 1966. In it, Harriman lays out a plan that would settle all of the Cold War's most troubling problems, from Vietnam to nuclear proliferation to international monetary instability. The Russians would be told that the Germans would get no nuclear hardware, allowing the Soviet Union to sign a nonproliferation agreement. In return, the Russians would "commit themselves to getting Hanoi to make peace in Southeast Asia." Last, the United States would "pay off the Germans by making balance of payments concessions."<sup>4</sup> Walt Rostow argued against the proposal, largely because it was "wrong to let the Germans off the hook on balance of payments offsets."<sup>5</sup> What is amazing—and hard to discern without detailed historical work—is how these obscure monetary questions influenced America's military strategy in Europe and had a direct bearing on relations within NATO. As Rostow's response to Harriman's memo reveals, these questions even spilled over into discussions about ending the Vietnam War.

Many analysts—international political economists, nuclear strategists, experts on Germany, trade experts—have looked at a particular issue during this period in isolation. And short of those at the top of government—the president, perhaps the secretaries of state and defense, and the national security adviser—most policymakers

worked on one or two of these questions and were unlikely to make broader, more complex connections. Treasury officials demanded troop withdrawals, State Department officials insisted that the troops had to stay to reassure West Germany, and Department of Defense officials, focusing on such questions as force readiness and the worldwide demand for troops, stood somewhere in between. Good horizontal historical work, however, can reveal the interconnections and trade-offs that permeate most important foreign policies. This bird's-eye view, provided by historical thinking, offers a more holistic picture of how policymaking actually works, allowing government officials to consider horizontal linkages more effectively in their work. It forces both scholars and policymakers to recognize how complex the policy environment can be.

Undertaking horizontal history—asking “what else is happening”—also generates much-needed empathy and recognition of the challenges decision-makers face. Return to American foreign policy during the 1960s, this time to the weeks and months following Johnson's landslide victory in the presidential election of 1964, when the crucial decision was made to escalate US military involvement in the war in Southeast Asia. Historians and the public look back at the choices made by the president and his advisers as foolish and tragic, leading to arguably the most disastrous foreign policy conducted by the United States in the latter half of the twentieth century. At the same time, however, the same administration, and many of the same decision-makers, constructed bold and innovative nuclear nonproliferation policies in response to China's detonation of a nuclear device. The decision in the fall and winter of 1964–65 to act aggressively to limit the spread of the bomb reversed previous policies and was seen by some experienced analysts at the time as deeply unwise. To succeed, this new policy would require the United States to work with its geopolitical foe, the Soviet Union, often at the expense of allies including West Germany, Australia, Italy, and Japan. But this decision led to the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty of 1968 and to policies that, against all expectations, kept the number of nuclear weapons states in the single digits for several decades.

This generates a puzzle: arguably the worst and best American foreign policies of the postwar period were developed at the same time by many of the same people. There is some argument that, implicitly, the decisions were connected: the United States' willingness to defend its South Vietnamese ally in the aftermath of China's detonation of a nuclear device in October 1964 may have been a signal to other allies that the United States would provide security, allowing these allies to forgo their own nuclear weapons. Thinking historically allows both for empathy and understanding—these officials did not lose twenty IQ points when the discussion switched from nuclear weapons to Vietnam—but also for more intelligent critique. Most important, regardless of the logic or merits of either decision, undertaking horizontal history—asking “what else is happening”—exposes often hidden linkages that are crucial to understanding and acting in a complex world. This is a crucial question for scholars, analysts, and practitioners of statecraft and strategy.

### Question 3: What Is Unsaid? (Unspoken Assumptions)

In April 1968, the historian James Joll delivered a lecture at the London School of Economics entitled, “1914: The Unspoken Assumptions.”<sup>6</sup> He presented these reflections several months after the English-language translation of German historian Fritz Fischer’s controversial book *Germany’s Aims in the First World War*, for which he wrote an introduction.

Joll confronted the challenge of recognizing unspoken assumptions—what is left unsaid when people make consequential decisions.<sup>7</sup> When assessing any critical choice, either past or in the present, we analyze the decision-making process by looking at written documents and private and public commentary. But often, the core assumptions and worldviews shaping these decisions are not explicitly laid out. “When political leaders,” he lectured, “are faced with the necessity of taking decisions the outcome of which they cannot foresee, in crises which they do not wholly understand, they fall back on their own instinctive reactions, traditions and modes of behaviour. Each of them has certain beliefs, rules or objectives which are taken for granted; and one of the limitations of documentary evidence is that few people bother to write down, especially in moments of crisis, things which they take for granted. Yet if we are to understand their motives, we must somehow try to find out what, as we say, ‘goes without saying.’”<sup>8</sup>

How do we uncover these unspoken assumptions? Historians regularly examine the *mentalities* of individuals, institutions, communities, and states that shape how decisions are made. This exploration demands that they make sense of the intellectual and cultural dynamics the decision-makers operated within. Joll argued that it was impossible to understand how decisions were made in European capitals during the summer of 1914 without recognizing the pervasive influence of a “doctrine of a perpetual struggle for survival and of a permanent potential war of all against all” that emerged from a witch’s brew of social Darwinism and a popularized distortion of Nietzschean thought. These fueled both a shared sense that war was inevitable and an almost palpable relief, even excitement, when it came. Uncovering these unspoken assumptions helps make sense of actions that, from a reading of the diplomatic documents alone, are hard to comprehend. Joll states, “If we are to understand the conflicting beliefs which lie behind the actions of statesmen and the reactions of their followers, we must look at a number of ideas, attitudes and assumptions which are not always to be found in the archives.... It is as important for the historian of international relations to understand these changes in what Hegel calls the spirit of the age as it is for him to understand changes in the structure of the economy or developments in military technology.”<sup>9</sup>

This is good advice for historians. But can it help those who are confronting consequential choices in the present? Almost by definition, policymakers are not aware

of their own unspoken assumptions, or they consider them so obvious as to be not worth discussing. However, by simply recognizing that their environment and circumstances are shaped by a shared set of unspoken beliefs and mentalities, decision-makers might force themselves to dig deeper into the set of choices in front of them. Are their choices limited or shaped in unhelpful ways because of ideas they simply accept but that may, in time, be found wanting?

Perhaps it is too much to ask of policymakers to deconstruct the presumptions and prejudices of their time. It is worth trying, however. Imagine that they were in a decision-making capacity in the United States after the 9/11 attacks. Might a familiarity with the unspoken assumptions that shaped the consequential—and ultimately disastrous—decisions of July 1914 have given them pause about the policy pressures they faced in the fall of 2001? The records we have from the time, including declassified documents, interviews, memoirs, and journalistic accounts, reveal important aspects of the policymaking process that led, ultimately, to the decision to invade Iraq in March 2003. But do these contemporary accounts effectively capture the volatile mix of intense fear and vulnerability that combined with moral outrage, a sense of unlimited power, and the (in retrospect, bizarre) sense that the 9/11 attacks had somehow “changed everything”?

As policymakers considered the invasions of Afghanistan, Iraq, and other elements of the global war in terror after 9/11, it might have been asking too much to expect they might have been persuaded to reflect upon how the supercharged milieu of July 1914 led to catastrophic blunders. But they could have been pointed to the assumptions and worldview that shaped the Johnson administration’s actions during what Fredrik Logevall has called “the long 1964”—the period between the summer of 1963 and the fateful decision two years later to dramatically escalate America’s military involvement in Vietnam.<sup>10</sup> They would recognize that the mistakes that led to the fiasco in Vietnam emerged less from a broken policy process than from the decision-makers’, and the larger culture’s, unspoken assumptions about the world and America’s role in it. Might they have concluded, after similar reflections between 2001 and 2003, that unchallenged assumptions and worldviews could lead to mistakes then, too?

Asking what is unsaid may not provide a precise answer to those trying to make sense of contemporary choices. It does ask decision-makers to think historically, to identify what unspoken assumptions and worldviews are shaping decisions, and to recognize that these mentalities are not fixed or final. What will historians twenty, fifty, or one hundred years in the future say about the decision-makers’ current assumptions and choices? What mistakes could our unspoken assumptions lead us to, and might they be avoided if those assumptions were revealed and scrutinized?

#### Question 4: How Are Things Trending? (Time Lags and Historical Anamnesis)

Thinking historically allows us to ask what longer-term trends we are experiencing, how they affect or change the choices available to us, and whether we are recognizing and updating our ideas, policies, and practices accordingly. It is difficult, in real time, to calculate precisely how much our environment is changing and impossible to say whether the shifts will continue, accelerate, cease, or even reverse. Important historical trends are often clear only in retrospect. They may unfold in a nonlinear fashion, are often not unidirectional, and may reveal new processes or phenomena that have no exact parallel from the past. Determining who benefits often depends on evaluating historical perspective, or who is asking and when. While it is difficult to comprehend change as it is happening, a historical sensibility jars us from our sense that the present and future will be like the past. Thinking historically allows observers to identify time lags in earlier periods, when the world was clearly changing but people and institutions failed to recognize these shifts or respond in a timely way. This sensitizes analysts to ask whether there are similar historical time lags today while urging decision-makers to update their practices, processes, and policies to meet new realities.

Even if a historical trend cannot be fully identified and described, thinking historically should help us understand its direction and estimate whether the trend is making the situation better or worse, the world more prosperous or poorer, more safe or more dangerous, with more knowledge or more misinformation. This brings up another important feature of thinking historically. Analysts, institutions, and even historians are understandably skeptical about overly rosy projections based on the supposed direction of history, cautioning against what historians label a Whig version of history that simply assumes steady progress over time. Yet as dangerous as it is to downplay risks and overestimate our ability to elude danger, the opposite instinct can be just as debilitating. Thinking historically should allow decision-makers to avoid historical anamnesis, or the inability to recognize and accept that circumstances are improving. Avoiding this trap should allow policymakers to update and adapt their conceptual lenses, policies, and practices accordingly.

Recognizing and combating historical anamnesis is an especially important skill for political leaders and strategists. Over the past century, for example, states, leaders, and populations have been slow to recognize that the darker demographic, agricultural, technological, sociocultural, and economic forces that once dominated human existence and shaped earlier worldviews and policies have, in many cases, been transformed. Even as contemporary policymakers seem surrounded by doom and gloom, thinking historically reminds them that by almost every measure of human well-being—lifespan, access to basic resources, medicine and public health, technology, literacy, knowledge about the world, personal and communal safety, and much else—life is better for far more people in more places than ever before. The percentage of people affected by the collective ills that routinely plagued the past—fire, flood, famine, deadly illness, revolution and rebellion, mass violence, and especially total war—is far smaller than in previous periods. If you were to deploy almost any metric and apply it to individual

well-being, social and political health, or international political stability and security, you would discover that the world in 2025 is safer, stabler, and more prosperous than the world of 1975, which was much better than the world of 1925, which was much more advanced than the world of 1875, which possessed greater wealth and security than that of 1825.<sup>11</sup>

Why does this matter? Consider policymakers who are told that they must confront the historical return of great power rivalry and intense geopolitical competition. They are urged to revisit the years and decades before the First World War or the period between the world wars to understand the choices they face. They might recognize certain similarities between their current circumstances and world politics in the summer of 1914 or the 1930s. Thinking historically, however, would help them recognize that world politics has undergone profound changes since these times. They might note that many of the historical trends unfolding since the First World War—many of which are continuing and even accelerating—make the “lessons” from the first half of the twentieth century less germane than first assumed. They would risk grave errors if they based their policies on an out-of-date understanding of the world.

The inability to recognize these tectonic historical changes is not entirely surprising. Millennia of deep scarcity, conquest, empire, and mass violence—and governing institutions and sociocultural habits that emerged to deal with those conditions—have left unshakable institutional memories and political scars.<sup>12</sup> Faced with a rapidly changing world and global phenomena they don’t understand, many leaders and analysts understandably fall back on long-held, often unexamined beliefs about how the world works, based on how they comprehend the past, as opposed to trying to better understand how the world has changed. Explicitly or implicitly, many of the international relations theories that decision-makers rely on don’t allow for fundamental, systemic change in the nature of international relations, the components of power, and how states determine and pursue their interests. Thinking historically helps correct this mistake.

It is difficult to recognize and evaluate systemic historical change as it is unfolding, and it is even harder to update policies, practices, and institutions to adapt to these changes. And obviously, not every historical trend is positive or even prone to the kind of normative evaluation implied by identifying it as “better or worse.” Over the same period where many aspects of human life have improved, other, potentially catastrophic changes have emerged that political leaders and strategists must account for, ranging from the climate crisis to deepening inequality within and among states to the uncertainties of powerful new technologies, all in an environment of increasingly polarized politics. When making choices about war and peace, however, it would be dangerous and irresponsible for policymakers not to recognize that powerful historical forces have made world politics, if not safer, then certainly much different from how it was in 1914 or the 1930s. Historical anamnesis puts decision-makers at risk of missing



opportunities for change while overinvesting against the wrong dangers and overlooking new dangers.

Thinking historically emphasizes that past performance is no guarantee for the future, nor does history move in a constant upward or downward direction. Powerful historical trends often generate formidable but obscure forces and antibodies that may modify or reroute their original direction. And as historical perspective reveals, assessing the world depends very much on when and from where you are evaluating it. That said, thinking historically cautions us that ignoring or misunderstanding positive developments can be just as foolish as ignoring or underestimating threats.

### Question 5: How Is This Understood by Others? (Historical Perspective)

In the movie *Rashomon* (1950), directed by the legendary Japanese filmmaker Akira Kurosawa, four characters provide four alternative recountings of the same event: the murder of a samurai. The film is often invoked when different parties offer plausible but contradictory accounts of the same occurrence, shaped by factors ranging from their own self-interest to subjective perspectives, cognitive biases, and ambiguous evidence. Historians must often make sense of contested chronologies and events, which force them to develop skills that can be useful to decision-makers facing similar dilemmas.

We always hope that the phenomena we care about and analyze can be easily apprehended and objectively measured. Much of social science assumes this objectivity, both in collecting data and in analyzing it. Thinking historically, however, reminds us that for many complex social and political occurrences, “what happened and why” can be understood differently by others. A historical sensibility sensitizes observers to perspective, the idea that events, phenomena, and beliefs can look different depending on who is perceiving them, when they are trying to understand them, and from where.

To be clear, thinking historically does not mean abandoning objectivity or the search for a singular “truth.” Historians doggedly try to uncover missing evidence, square contested facts, and reconcile competing interpretations. Sometimes, however, what happened and why is unclear or disputed, with little chance for a final resolution accepted by all. More often, the *meaning* of what happened is contested. A historical sensibility recognizes that a consensus on difficult questions from the past can be hard to achieve, especially when viewed through different political, social, or cultural lenses. Thinking historically requires us to balance two difficult, contradictory tasks—seeking an objective past and recognizing that it may always elude us—so that the power and pull of competing histories can be better understood and accounted for.

There are at least three ways to understand and evaluate historical perspective: immediate, spatial, and temporal.

Immediate perspective is when participants in the same event recount them differently, as in *Rashomon*. This happens in policy more than one might expect. Consider the meeting between President Dwight D. Eisenhower and President-elect

John F. Kennedy to discuss American policy in Laos on January 19, 1961. Five different written accounts of the meeting emerged, with five different views of what Eisenhower said to Kennedy about whether he would recommend the United States use military force in Southeast Asia if circumstances called for it. As Fred I. Greenstein and Richard H. Immerman point out in their article about the meeting, “Each of the four note takers and [Secretary of State Dean] Rusk would have entered the meeting with his own preconceptions and expectations.”<sup>13</sup> The scholars tried to determine whose account was correct, both by laying out the backgrounds of the five and by reconstructing how President Eisenhower had previously discussed military intervention, especially toward Southeast Asia. An objective truth proved elusive: “No absolute answer is possible to the question of what Eisenhower told Kennedy, and, above all, what he meant.”<sup>14</sup>

Historians are more aware than most that the events that we assume are well understood by all are often contested by those who participated in them. In the world of American foreign policy, comparing the memoirs of key participants in a major decision can be as revealing for their differences as for the similarities. As the Eisenhower-Kennedy episode reveals, even historians’ tried-and-true approach—acquiring and analyzing documents produced at the time—does not guarantee a clear account. Historians, while working diligently to find out precisely what happened, are more comfortable than most with this uncertainty and the contrasting understandings offered by participants.

This is an important lesson for decision-makers. Being aware of challenges generated by conflicting eyewitness accounts allows analysts to reflect upon their own cognitive biases, as well as those of their interlocutors, when discussing important decisions or events. Being aware of these biases may allow for self-correction and adjustment, as well as understanding (while adjusting for) contrasting accounts that emerge.

Spatial perspective is simply the understanding that where you stand on certain events depends on where you sit. In other words, how you view history—why and how things happen and what it means—depends on your observation point. Financiers’ understanding of a booming economy that generates greater overall wealth for a country but increases income inequality will obviously be different from farmers’ or factory workers’ perspectives. Financiers might see this historical outcome as a product of wise policies that unleashed market forces, increasing efficiency and innovation. Others might see the same policies as enabling predatory capitalism to make a few people wealthy at the middle class’s expense. Spatial perspective also acknowledges state boundaries. Recall how we earlier saw that how people viewed the Eastern European revolutions of 1989 and the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 diverged dramatically depending upon whether they made sense of these events from Moscow, Beijing, Washington, Brussels, Lagos, or Silicon Valley. Why does this matter for decision-makers? Because how the past is interpreted shapes actions in the present and future. It

matters greatly if you think that the Cold War's ending and the Soviet Union's implosion are to be celebrated, lamented, or, as in Beijing's case, avoided and whether you think that they were shaped by deep structural forces such as technology and culture or by individual policy choices such as those made by Gorbachev or Reagan.

Temporal perspective reflects how our views of the past change over time. Edward Hallett Carr expressed doubt that the Middle Ages were dominated by religious fervor, given that "the facts of mediaeval history have almost all been selected for us by generations of chroniclers who were professionally occupied in the theory and practice of religion, and who therefore thought it supremely important, and recorded everything relating to it, and not much else."<sup>15</sup> Or take the more recent example of the war on the Korean peninsula. While there is not a universal consensus, many international relations scholars today portray the painful intervention by the United States, under a United Nations mandate, as a necessary step in the effort to contain communist expansion, which ultimately led to its prevailing in the Cold War. Writing in 1973, as the disastrous American role in the Vietnam War came to an end, Ernest R. May—no left-wing revisionist—portrayed the Korean War as a mistake that emerged because American policymakers had misread the past. "It was the policy of the United States in June 1950," he wrote, "to avoid using American military forces in Korea."<sup>16</sup> But in their reliance on overly simplistic comparisons to world politics in the 1930s, May argued, Truman and his advisers "discarded previous calculations because of a presumed historical maxim" and spent "life and large sums of money and some risk of precipitating general war" to defend territory that, just months earlier, had seemed to lie outside of America's declared area of interest.<sup>17</sup> In 1973, the Korean War clearly looked like a mistake, but twenty years later, with the end of the Cold War and the rise of East Asian economies, it was seen in a better light.

Historical judgments change with time, and they often tell us as much about the time in which they were written, where, and by whom as they reveal about the past. Peer beneath the surface, and Fritz Fischer's monumental work, published in 1961, on German responsibility for the First World War provides great insight into the cultural and intellectual milieu of an early postwar Federal Republic of Germany coming to terms with its dark past. Since the raid on Harpers Ferry in 1859, the radical abolitionist John Brown has been portrayed as anything from terrorist to enlightened liberator. The facts about Brown and his fateful attack have not changed, but historical observers' perspectives have shifted enormously.

Thinking historically conditions the mind to empathize with how issues are seen by other people, at other times, and in other places. As C. S. Lewis commented, "A man who has lived in many places is not likely to be deceived by the local errors of his village; the scholar has lived in many times and is therefore in some degree immune from the great cataract of nonsense that pours from the press of his own age."<sup>18</sup> This

sensibility can and should be embraced not only by those who seek to understand the past but by those who make decisions in the present for the future.

### Question 6: Why Does This Matter? (Chronological Proportionality)

How do we assess the long-term significance of a policy or issue of present concern? Events and phenomena that seem extremely important when they happen can turn out, when viewed through a longer-term historical lens, to be less consequential than originally thought. Other issues that command less attention in the present often turn out to have important long-term consequences. The standard that many present-day observers use to assess the importance of an issue or policy response—media coverage—is often a misleading barometer of long-term impact. How do we weigh the long-term significance of a contemporary event? Thinking historically helps analysts wade through the noise to figure out what matters.

There are lots of examples of day-to-day political or cultural events that grabbed headlines or even policy focus but then dissolved into the historical ether over time. There are other examples, however, of obviously consequential events crowding out even more important longer-term developments. Consider the Vietnam War during the last two years of the Johnson administration. This brutal and to many minds misguided conflict took tens of thousands of lives, strained the US economy, and left a bitter political and cultural legacy that permanently damaged American institutions. Every aspect of the Vietnam War in 1967 and 1968—from the battlefield to the war's influence on popular culture to the discord at the political conventions—monopolized media coverage and public debate, was the primary focus of policy attention, and dominated scholarly accounts of the administration's foreign policy.

Looking back six decades later, however, we can ask whether the Vietnam War, as important as it was, was the only American foreign policy issue of great significance at the time. Was the war in Southeast Asia even the most important *long-term* US foreign policy question of the day, judged by historical weight? Other events, happening at the same time, may have mattered as much or arguably more yet received far less contemporary attention.

Take, for example, the long-term historical consequences of the Six-Day War of 1967 in the Middle East. Before this war, the region was not a primary concern of the United States, coming after Europe, East Asia, and even Latin America in political significance. The United States tried to balance its interests between Israel and its Arab neighbors, and as recently as the Kennedy administration, US relations with Israel had been quite strained. Great Britain was understood to be the guarantor of Western interests and stability in the region. Starting in the late 1950s and continuing through the 1960s, however, the Soviet Union increased its presence in the region, targeting it as an area where they could make geopolitical inroads by supporting Egypt, Iraq, and Syria. When tensions between Israel and its Arab neighbors sparked a war in 1967, the United States was caught flat-footed. The financial crisis and devaluation of sterling brought on

by the war forced the British to renounce their responsibilities in the region. Bugged down in its military quagmire in Vietnam, the United States could not intervene on its own.

Unwilling to cede the region in the Cold War conflict with the Soviets but unable to meet the threat head-on by deploying US military forces, first the Johnson and then the Nixon administration developed a “pillar” strategy of providing massive military and political support to their allies in the region. The most important of these allies, from the US perspective, were Saudi Arabia, Iran, and Israel. In the years following the Six-Day War, each was given or sold billions of dollars’ worth of cutting-edge military equipment. This created a deeper and more complex relationship with all three, although in the case of Iran, the relationship soured when the shah was deposed. America’s post-1967 strategy in the greater Middle East had some success in blunting and reversing Soviet advances in the region, but it produced consequences that persisted well beyond the end of the Cold War. Given the Middle East’s centrality, for better or worse, to American grand strategy in recent decades, this history has a salience it might not have possessed before. Any history of America’s complex and often tragic engagement with the region over the past half century plus would see the Six-Day War as a crucial origin point.

There are other examples of foreign policies that were more important than was appreciated at the time. Consider the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, which was opened for signature on July 1, 1968. Although it was not ignored, few imagined that the treaty would in time be understood as the most important arms control treaty ever signed, with implications that would shape world politics for decades. Few seem to have anticipated that the number of nuclear weapons states would remain in the single digits six decades later—but the treaty has been a core reason for that unexpected success. Other developments at the time, such as the emerging stability and détente in Central Europe and the evolving thaw between the United States and China, had equally important geopolitical consequences. Lacking a singular event or crisis, these tectonic shifts were underplayed, at least until Nixon’s visit to China in 1972. A deeper historical sensibility, however, might have identified them. Technological advances, such as the spread of semiconductors, the creation of the Internet, and the development of satellite communications, drew little attention during the 1960s but generated profound long-term changes.

My point is not to diminish the historical importance of the Vietnam War. It is merely to highlight how some events, such as sharp crises or wars, can crowd out other, less noisy developments that may have equal or even greater long-term consequences. By developing historians’ skill of chronological proportionality, policymakers can learn to see the bigger picture. What events or phenomena are unfolding today that may be underappreciated?

## Question 7: What Are the Possible Unexpected Outcomes? (Unintended Consequences)

Thinking historically excels at allowing one to see ironies, dilemmas, and unintended consequences. This emerges from how a historical sensibility orients us to view the world. Unlike many social science models, a historical sensibility does not seek some elusive equilibrium. History tells us that when looking at a complex, interdependent, ever-changing world, we can never perfectly capture all the relevant variables or fully grasp how they interact with each other. The circumstances you seek to explain are never quite like those that came before or will emerge after, so creating a perfect algorithm to capture every aspect of complex social, cultural, economic, and political forces is impossible. Small, unseen changes can produce large, unexpected shifts. Particularly in international political life, things rarely go as expected—seldom is predicted outcome C easily achieved when policy B is applied to problem A. Even if outcome C is achieved, however, historians understand that unexpected and second-order consequences D, E, and Z will generate new policy challenges. The best you can hope for is to apprehend some part of the larger puzzle.

A historical sensibility illuminates how the past is filled with surprise, causing observers looking at an event or a phenomenon to ask: Was what happened unexpected, and if so, in what ways? What unanticipated outcomes might emerge from the decision-makers' choices, given the forces and factors they observe?

Consider a plausible counterfactual—the consequences for the United States if it had achieved a military victory in the Vietnam War and created the conditions for a cohesive, stable government in South Vietnam. This was not an impossibility. Perhaps increased military escalation, deeper domestic support in the United States, or better leadership from the South Vietnamese government might have made the war winnable, at least in the sense that the United States was not forced to withdraw in disgrace. Such an outcome would have been celebrated by American policymakers.

Would it have been the best outcome for America's position in the world over the long run? One plausible outcome of a victory might have been an American obligation to continue pouring resources into Southeast Asia. More important, if the United States had won, the People's Republic of China and the Soviet Union might have overcome their mutual enmity to serve the larger goal of reducing American power in Asia. It is certainly hard to imagine the rifts between North Vietnam and China flowering into open conflict if the United States had won the war.

But the United States lost the war in Southeast Asia, bringing its forces home and reducing its grand strategic presence in the region. That military defeat, though a terrible, humiliating drag on American power and reputation, ushered in a period of intense reassessment within many institutions, particularly the military. This arguably had great long-term benefits for American power.



China and the Soviet Union had been quarreling bitterly for years, and the prospect of a US withdrawal may have intensified the split and brought it into the open, since they no longer needed to fear undermining their mutual interest in seeing the United States defeated. With that goal almost achieved, China and the Soviet Union both competed for America's interest and affections—through détente and arms control on the Soviet side and through President Richard Nixon's remarkable visit on China's. The Nixon, Ford, Carter, and Reagan administrations later exploited this division to their geopolitical benefit.

By the late 1970s, China had become, if not quite an ally, an associate of the United States, often working with it in tandem against the Soviet Union, a turn that had important consequences for how the Cold War developed and eventually ended—not the least of which was the Soviet Union having to maintain large military forces on its border with China. Equally surprising—and certainly unexpected a decade earlier—was China's attack on a unified Vietnam in 1979. From the perspective of America's power position in the world, a US defeat that divided the communist world in Asia may ironically have been better for the nation's long-term power than a victory in Vietnam, which could have led to an expensive, decades-long commitment facing a unified communist front. Furthermore, it is reasonable to ask if the United States' "weakened" status perhaps tempted the Soviets to intervene more deeply in Africa and Afghanistan, to Russia's long-term detriment. Would the so-called East Asian tigers—Hong Kong, Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan—have pursued their thoroughgoing economic and political reforms, which transformed the region's economy, in a world where the United States had not reduced its presence there? Thinking historically allows observers to wonder: In a world where the United States "wins" in Vietnam, does the Cold War end a decade and a half later and on terms less favorable to America? Of course, the end of the Cold War and the collapse of the Soviet Union—correctly celebrated as an extremely positive development for world politics and the United States as they occurred—soon generated their own unexpected problems.

Thinking historically allows analysts and policymakers to appreciate that there is no "end point" to the unfolding of time, no permanent solving for X, no solution that ends history. The same is true for statecraft and strategy: even the greatest success generates new problems. Consider the headaches that plagued US policy in the Middle East in the decades after the successful liberation of Kuwait, when the United States defeated Iraq on the battlefield in 1991. Failures and disasters, on the other hand, may provide opportunities. To give an extreme example, the scourge of the bubonic plague, the so-called Black Death that ravaged Europe during the fourteenth century, caused unimaginable suffering and loss. But it also laid the foundation for profound, positive, and irreversible economic, social, and political change, particularly for countless peasants and the urban poor. This is not to say that we should advocate poor choices or root for disasters. It is simply that the ironies and unintended consequences observed by a historical sensibility should induce profound humility.

## Question 8: Was This Inevitable? (Outcome Bias)

Looking at the world we live in and thinking about how the past became the present, it is sometimes hard to imagine that things could have turned out much differently. Indeed, many social science models suggest that you can capture the underlying causal mechanisms that led to an event or phenomenon and thereby explain why there was only one way things could have turned out.

A historical sensibility pushes back against this way of thinking, asking observers to take seriously the question “Was this inevitable?” When looking at the past, we must avoid what economists call the curse of knowledge, the cognitive bias that claims, in hindsight, that the outcome of a historical event was predictable. A historical sensibility should work to understand the world as people at the time saw it, facing radical uncertainty about the future, and who had to make decisions not knowing how they would play out.

In other words, we must recognize what might be called the puzzle of the Third Balkan War.

Historians, policymakers, and the larger public study, argue, and even obsess over the crisis of July 1914 largely because of the horrors that followed: a catastrophic and largely senseless world war that killed millions and unleashed years of revolution, pandemics, genocide, economic disaster, and a second, even bloodier world war. We look at the tragedy that unfolded in the summer of 1914 through the lens of its horrific aftermath, which shaped the world we still live with. Few events, in retrospect, seem both more consequential and more inevitable than the First World War. The combined power of nationalism, imperialism, arms races, and interlocking alliances appear to have guaranteed a global conflagration.

But that is not how many at the time understood their world, when they had no idea what the future held. Europe had escaped far more serious crises—in Morocco in 1905 and 1911, Libya in 1911–12, and the Balkans in 1912–13—without a world war. When crises did lead to conflict, the wars were localized, as was the case during the First and Second Balkan Wars. As James Joll and the issue of unspoken assumptions suggest, many policymakers dreaded the worst in July 1914, but others believed that a new war would be short or even localized—a Third Balkan War. Imperial crises had abated, and by some accounts Europe was no more nationalist or militaristic in the summer of 1914 than it had been in years earlier.

Nor did the assassination of Archduke Ferdinand provoke a sense of crisis or impending disaster. Leaders went on their previously scheduled holidays. In July 1914, the headlines in Paris’s newspapers were dominated by the trial of Henriette Caillaux, the second wife of the French minister of finance, who had shot and killed the editor of *Le Figaro* for publishing her husband’s private correspondence. The tale had everything—sex, politics, intrigue—and seemed to matter quite a bit. The story of Austria-Hungary’s ultimatum to Serbia, issued after the assassination, took a distant second

place.<sup>19</sup> British citizens, meanwhile, were focused on domestic crises that seem far more threatening: labor strife, the suffragette movement, and the increasing risk of a military mutiny over the question of Irish Home Rule.<sup>20</sup> Global conflagration was far from people's minds. Indeed, when the assassination happened, members of the British and German fleets were together at a party in Kiel—at which the German kaiser donned a British admiral's uniform—during a naval review.<sup>21</sup>

European decision-makers were tragically wrong about how events would unfold. That does not, however, remove the obligation to try to understand how they viewed the world and saw their choices and to interpret their actions not solely through the lens of the horrors that followed and that, had they known what would happen, surely would have forced them to reconsider their decisions in the summer of 1914. Nor is it to deny that deeper structural forces were at work that might have made a Europe-wide conflict difficult or impossible to avoid. As Joll points out, many Europeans *believed* that war was inevitable, perhaps creating a self-fulfilling prophesy. Outcome bias, however, can prejudice us toward seeing systemic, ineluctable forces as causing the things we care about, while randomness, choice, and circumstance get crowded out.

Asking “Is it inevitable?” is especially important for decision-makers. Policy is premised on two conditions that are easy to forget unless we think historically: first, that choices matter and can shape history; and second, choosing correctly is very difficult when facing radical uncertainty about the future. As former National Security Adviser Samuel R. “Sandy” Berger once pointed out, “History is written through a rear-view mirror but unfolds through a foggy windshield.”<sup>22</sup> Policymakers are used to having their decisions second-guessed and criticized. But most complex and difficult policy choices are the “51/49” Kissinger identified: it is very difficult to know in advance whether a policy choice will turn out correctly, even if it seems obvious in retrospect.

### Question 9: Are Things Changing Rapidly? (Punctuated Equilibrium)

In world politics, years or even decades can pass without great change, whereas at other times the international system can be transformed seemingly overnight. When looking at the past—or trying to understand the present—a key question that a historical sensibility generates is, “Are things changing rapidly?”

A deeper historical awareness tells us that although time unfolds in a linear matter, history, meaning the changes we care about most, often does not. There are times when very little of consequence appears to happen, and then big, important changes emerge suddenly, violently, and seemingly out of nowhere. One way to think about this unpredictable rhythm is to borrow from the great biologist Stephen Jay Gould and his concept of punctuated equilibrium. When the environment is stable, a species can remain static for tens of millions of years; but if conditions alter, dramatic changes or even the emergence of new species can occur in a dramatic, rapid, nonlinear fashion.

Although much of history unfolds gradually, there are times when phenomena explode onto the scene in a manner that “accelerates” history. History, in other words, possesses its own velocity: under certain conditions, circumstances and realities change exponentially faster than in more stable times. After the start of the First World War, for example, both domestic and international politics changed faster and more dramatically than perhaps ever before in recorded history. Important aspects of European conditions and circumstances may have been in stasis, with slow and linear changes in the century after the Congress of Vienna, but new forms of revolutionary politics, war, and culture exploded onto the scene in the years after 1914. The political revolutions in Europe in 1989 might be thought of in a similar way. As we saw in [chapter 3](#), a person arguing in 1984 that the Cold War would soon end, the Iron Curtain would collapse, and the Soviet Union would disappear within five years would have been seen as foolish. Yet unthinkable, rapid, and transformative change did occur in a brief time.

Historians develop a sense for when historical velocity intensifies, a skill that can also be useful to political leaders and strategists. C. Vann Woodward, explaining why James McPherson’s monumental history of the Civil War was the longest volume in the Oxford History of America series while chronicling the shortest period, writes that “precious little correlation exists between the importance, complexity, and abundance of historical events and the length of the time it takes for them to occur. Some history of momentous consequence requires centuries to unfold, while history of comparable importance can take place with staggering speed.”<sup>23</sup> Thinking historically helps us recognize, in a way often not captured in linear models, that not all periods and events unfold at the same velocity or with the same consequence.

### Question 10: Are We Using the Past Correctly? (Historical Malpractice)

Unlike other methods of understanding the world, history is not plagued by underuse. As I have discussed, everyone uses it. Few arguments made in public or private life do not rely, implicitly or explicitly, on a particular understanding of both what happened in the past and how and why history unfolds. Almost all individuals and organizations use the past in some way to make sense of their cultural, socioeconomic, and political circumstances.

But do we do it well? An important question for sizing up arguments that rely on an understanding of history is, “Are we using the past correctly?”

Thinking historically shows us that most of these arguments use history poorly. But it can be challenging to convince individuals, institutions, and communities that their own arguments do so. Other epistemologies have ways of policing when their tools, methods, or conclusions are used poorly. Science has a time-tested, universally embraced method backed by replicable experiments. Legal arguments are adjudicated in courts by juries and judges, basing their decisions on laws and precedents. If engineers

are wrong, a building collapses or a plane falls out of the sky. The consequences from the poor uses of history can be just as lethal but are harder to trace and prove.

In theory, an academic discipline should be able to weigh in against malpractice. Doctors and lawyers who perform badly or unethically can be sued or even thrown out of the profession, while failing engineers and scientists lose the opportunity to work, receive grants, or publish. Lacking a shared epistemology and recognizing the value of different temporal and spatial perspectives, historians have a harder time ruling out or eliminating different approaches, methods, or conclusions. Even as historians seek objectivity, they accept that there is no one right way to understand the past. And as I have suggested throughout this book, the academic discipline of history has forfeited a good deal of its credibility trying to pass judgment on whether a historical argument is good or bad. One of the unfortunate results of the crisis within the discipline is that the views and judgments it offers are held in lower regard than those of other academic fields, such as law, engineering, the natural sciences, medicine, or economics. What's more, there is a thriving community of nonacademic historians who see validation in their robust book sales and public engagement, not the opinions of scholars in the field.

In the second chapter, I highlighted some of the commonest ways in which history is misused, from the relatively benign, such as the use of the past as comfort food, to dangerous forms of weaponization. How might thinking historically help us distinguish good historical arguments from bad? There are commonsense approaches to making the distinction, applicable to any kind of argument, historical or otherwise. First, what is the quality of the evidence used? Has the historical record, especially the primary sources, been fully mined and examined? Second, is the argument logical? While these questions provide a good first cut, given the complexity of history, they get you only so far.

Thinking historically tells us that certain kinds of assertions about the past have flaws that go beyond a lack of evidence or logic. Historical malpractice usually has four characteristics: weak and facile analogies, a focus on historical inevitability, monocausal explanations, and binary morality.

#### FACILE HISTORICAL ANALOGIES

Like much of human reasoning, thinking about the past is comparative and analogical. But as I discussed earlier, historical analogies often do more harm than good. They blur key differences while overemphasizing similarities between the present case and the object of comparison, losing context and nuance in the process. Furthermore, it is often assumed that our historical understanding of the past event being analogized—the crisis of July 1914, the Munich Conference of 1938, the Cuban Missile Crisis, the financial collapses of 1929 and 1931, the Cold War—has a well-understood and undisputed meaning. This is almost never the case. Reliance on simplistic analogies is a warning sign of malpractice.

#### HISTORICAL INEVITABILITY

Thinking historically allows for alternative histories and different outcomes if circumstances or choices had been different. Many bad historical arguments lack this openness to alternative histories, suggesting that where we have ended up is the only true and proper result of how “history” operates.

#### MONOCAUSAL EXPLANATIONS

Poor historical arguments often focus on one causal force to explain why things happen. Parsimonious, all-encompassing explanations of world events—whether it is the struggle of the masses, the emergence of reason, the rise of the state or the market, God’s will, or the unchanging dynamics of great power politics—are powerful frames for understanding the world, and they often contain important elements of truth. Rarely, however, can one “independent” variable explain the issues we care about, especially in the world of statecraft and strategy. Parsimonious theories can play an important role in explaining certain phenomena; even when they don’t reveal everything, they help us think about what causal forces and agents matter most. But monocausal explanations of history should be treated with great caution. The past is all too often exploited in service of the master theory or singular cause, and exceptions get ignored or explained away.

#### BINARY MORALITY

Historical malpractice often involves using the past to celebrate a particular value, ideal, group of people, or practice. These accounts often deploy history in binary terms—good versus evil, patriots versus the disloyal, progress versus the enemies of progress, members of the nation, tribe, or community versus the other. This kind of malpractice has generated all manner of tragic results, including racism, sexism, authoritarianism, and ethnic cleansing.

All of these forms of historical malpractice employ excessive certainty about the world and a rigidity in explaining it. They do not allow for historical revisionism. A proper historical sensibility is marked by humility, curiosity, wonder, epistemological modesty, and unceasing reexploration and revision. It appreciates challenges to long-held orthodoxies.

#### Question 11: Was This Unprecedented? (Historical Myopia)

As we have seen, history is easily misused. Events from the past are contorted to fit an existing narrative and deployed more to justify than to explain. At other times, relying solely on history—focusing too much on the past—can confuse or distort our understanding. Not everything has happened before, and some events and phenomena truly are unprecedented or novel. In such cases, the past can be misleading as much as explanatory. Looking to history, we often select what is familiar rather than ask how the present and the past are different. We should ask, “Is the event or phenomenon we are



evaluating in real time something we have seen before, or is it new?” We might think of this as un-history.

History recounts what has happened. Thinking historically, however, can also help us reflect on what has *not* happened, which can be as important, if more difficult to ascertain. There are at least three ways of thinking about excavating “un-history.” First, we might reflect upon plausible alternative histories, or counterfactuals, and what they reveal about the world and what matters. Second, we can try to understand why important nonevents—such as thermonuclear war—remained nonevents. Third, we should be sensitive to when events or phenomena may in fact be unprecedented and where historical comparisons are as likely to deceive as inform.

What are the benefits of exploring what has not happened? As we have seen, counterfactual reasoning—if employed plausibly and responsibly—can help reveal what historical forces matter and how. This is especially true for decision-makers. Policy is about choosing among options, with the belief that those choices are consequential, and one of the best ways of evaluating a choice is to explore how different decisions might have led to different worlds. The other benefit of exploring alternative futures is to push back against the sense that what happened was inevitable, that the past could not have unfolded in any other way.

Sometimes, however, we care deeply about events or phenomena that have no history to explore. The history of the nuclear age is an example. Thermonuclear weapons have cast an enormous shadow over international politics for decades. Ideological and geopolitical adversaries aimed thousands of weapons at each other, bringing dangers that increased during tense crises and from simple accidents and mistakes. A thermonuclear war could kill hundreds of millions of people and generate climate, ecological, and radiation effects that could kill many more. It could end civilization and even risk human extinction. Although two fission bombs were used by the United States against Japan in August 1945, a thermonuclear war—which would be orders of magnitude more destructive—has never happened. Yet it was and remains a terrifying possibility.

It is obviously important to explore this un-history to understand why something like thermonuclear war has not happened, but doing so generates deep methodological challenges. You cannot run a regression if  $N=0$ , nor can you be fully confident of insights that emerge from a detailed process tracing of a nonevent. Some argue, quite plausibly, that the horrific destruction that would ensue from thermonuclear war both deters these weapons’ use and also deters state actions, such as invading a nuclear-armed state, that might escalate to nuclear use. Nuclear deterrence has been the foundation of American grand strategy and a key factor in world politics for eight decades. But with no history of thermonuclear wars to investigate, how can we know whether it was nuclear deterrence that prevented World War III? How have we avoided thermonuclear war so far, and how likely is such a war in the future? How can decision-makers best capture the benefits of possessing thermonuclear weapons, such as

detering great power war, without risking the catastrophic consequences of a thermonuclear exchange?

When there is no direct history to rely on, it is natural to look for things in the past that look similar to what we care about. Great power conflicts have been around for millennia, and at first glance, they might provide guidance on the question of nuclear war. But what if thermonuclear weapons are unlike any factor we've ever seen before, essentially revolutionizing world politics? Might the lessons drawn from prenuclear histories mislead us?

Thinking historically cautions us against believing that an event or phenomenon is new while helping guard against alarmist declarations that some new trend or development will either doom or liberate us. Rare is the technology or change in practice or political figure that doesn't have some historical antecedent. Yet some things are unprecedented, and thinking historically should help protect against mining the past for similarities when what we should worry about is not a development's precedents but its novelty.

Often, a change contains both novelty and historical precedents. When the Nazis undertook the mass killing of Jews in the Holocaust, genocide was not new; but the thoroughness of the industrial and bureaucratic effort to efficiently eliminate a whole people was, to that point, almost unimaginable. History may have blinded contemporaries to the enormity of the Third Reich's plans. Or consider the story, mentioned in [chapter 3](#), of the profound changes in human identity and relations that emerged starting in the 1970s, which began in California before spreading globally. Attitudes toward gender, race, and sexual orientation, as well as beliefs about a wide range of sociocultural phenomena from marriage to work, were transformed. How human beings thought of themselves and their relations to their communities changed profoundly in a single generation. Much of this rights revolution was unprecedented, while other parts of deepening and broadening tolerance and individualism had roots in cultural, socioeconomic, religious, and ideological trends dating back millennia.

Thinking historically sometimes demands that observers loosen their ties to the past. We must be sensitive to occasions when we should be guided not solely by what happened before but should recognize when something is new.

## Question 12: What Does It Mean? (Historical Purpose)

Do historical events, trends, or phenomena reveal a larger direction and meaning? At first glance, this is an uncomfortable question. Modern scholarship is far more focused on epistemology, or how we know things, than teleology, the purpose of events. Science can tell us, in a mechanistic way, what forces or factors cause events to occur, but it cannot tell us what those events mean or whether they are driving to some end point or purpose. Many scientists rigorously define such questions as outside science's remit. Decision-makers looking at a policy choice wrestle with what outcome they wish to achieve, those they want to avoid, and how best to navigate risk and uncertainty. They

rarely ask if that choice serves some larger historical purpose or direction. Yet we know that attaching ourselves to such a larger purpose is a core part of culture, politics, and human identity, all factors that shape statecraft and strategy.

Teleological discussions can be awkward. Science's discomfort with the idea that the natural world has "goals" often transfers over to the methods used to study human and social behavior. Yet we intuitively sense, and may explicitly believe, that both individual and collective human experience is powerfully shaped by a larger meaning. We also see, in our own lives and in broader cultural and political realities, that there are competing visions of purpose, meaning, and direction. These competing visions of meaning and purpose shape statecraft and strategy and are an important cause of conflict and war. It is at the heart of our modern politics and current polarization. It is difficult, therefore, to think about either history or our contemporary challenges without wrestling with teleology.

One of the most powerful motivations of historical work in centuries past was to uncover the larger purposes and direction of life. Sacred religious texts like the Bible and the Quran chronicle and interpret history so as to reveal God's designs. During the European enlightenment, Jacques-Bénigne Bossuet and Voltaire offered competing visions of history's direction: it moved, for Bossuet, toward the triumph of Catholicism through divine intervention, for Voltaire, toward the victory of reason over superstition. Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel believed that history progressed, through a dialectical process, to its ultimate destination in the state, where reason and freedom prevailed. For Karl Marx, a similar process, shaped by material and socioeconomic realities, would lead to the triumph of the working class over the owners of capital, the end of exploitation, and universal economic freedom.<sup>24</sup> National histories in the modern era often highlighted the sources and purposes of a particular state's rise. There are countless other examples of history being used to express a larger meaning, purpose, and direction.

Modern historians understandably resist what is sometimes called Whig history, the view that history moves toward human progress and improvement. Directional narratives such as Marxist and Hegelian histories have largely been abandoned, and many nationalist histories are viewed with skepticism. Can thinking historically allow us to chronicle the passage of time while remaining silent on whether events move with direction or purpose? The man often called the father of modern historiography, Leopold von Ranke, pushed back against teleological visions of history, arguing that the historian's role was to uncover a value-free, objective history, based more on discovering facts than on advancing concepts. Ranke also argued for historical empathy, suggesting that no historical period was "greater" than others and that historical events were unique and interconnected. In other words, like many contemporary historians, he was both a positivist, believing in a discoverable, objective past, and a historicist,

arguing that one historical practice or perspective was not necessarily better than others and that our beliefs and understanding of the world are the products of history.

For the purposes of this checklist, it is not necessary to embrace a historical teleology. But thinking historically demands awareness that such teleologies exist, implicitly or explicitly, in how many people understand the world. The past tells a story that reveals not only causality and agency but purpose and direction—or, in some tellings, their absence. Thinking historically requires considering our own position on the question of historical meaning and direction while recognizing its salience in the arguments and positions taken by others. Human beings, their social groupings and communities, and their larger political organizations cannot be evaluated like a collection of atoms, nor do they behave like billiard balls. More than most epistemologies, thinking historically recognizes that people and societies are motivated by beliefs that are hard to measure, including a confidence that their existence over time contains and conveys purpose and more than an instrumental significance.

A historical sensibility encourages boundless curiosity. Thinking historically helps the analyst ask questions and then sharpen and refine them. The historian's checklist provides a template for simple but consistent queries, grounded in history, that can aid decision-makers in making difficult, consequential choices in a complex environment when they face an unknowable future. Like the checklists for aircraft pilots or emergency room physicians, the twelve questions offered here are simply a start. With time and experience, questions can be amended, added, or replaced. By themselves, these questions can never provide the precise, "correct" answer for the best statecraft or strategy to pursue, since unlike in medicine or flying, such an answer may not exist. They will, however, allow policymakers and analysts to examine their and their colleagues' assumptions about causality and agency, open their mind to options they might not have known existed, and help them avoid dangerous, potentially catastrophic decisions. The checklist should improve their ability to understand the thoughts and motivations of others, both within their institution and society and among their allies and adversaries. They may better recognize the unexpected consequences of their decisions as well as reflect upon why a policy that seems wise for tomorrow may seem unwise a year or two from now. By constantly asking these simple but powerful questions, they may come to recognize missteps or mistakes more quickly and possess the courage to correct course. Over time, decision-makers, institutions, and societies that regularly and rigorously apply such questions to their choices will generate wiser and better outcomes.

# Postscript

## What Is to Be Done?

Because it generates important benefits for both individuals and society, a well-honed historical sensibility should be part of any broad-based education. Such an education would train students in curiosity, humility, prudence, an appreciation for temporal and spatial perspective, a sensitivity to circumstances and contingency, an openness to surprise, and a willingness to hear challenges to orthodox beliefs and widely held assumptions. Building upon this sensibility, thinking historically provides powerful tools for understanding, evaluating, and making consequential choices when faced with complexity and radical uncertainty about the future. It forces decision-makers to think deeply and precisely about causality and agency, time horizons, and when and how best to pursue policy interventions. These habits of mind are especially valuable for statecraft and strategy, enormously far-reaching activities affecting countless people, where outcomes would be much improved if thinking historically was widely employed. Policy choices would be better, and when they proved to be mistaken, decision-makers would recognize this sooner and correct course. Although this book has focused largely on issues of foreign, economic, and national security policy, as well as grand strategy, there is no reason why its lessons could not be effectively applied wherever decision-makers face difficult, important choices in the public or private sectors. Thinking historically provides an intelligent, adaptable approach to whatever we find foreign or that we don't know or fully understand.

How should thinking historically be incorporated into the larger world outside of history departments? How can it be made both part of our general education for all citizens and required for any person or organization making consequential choices?

My answer is largely shaped by three narrower queries. First, what professions, activities, or institutions would most prize and promote a historical sensibility? Is there a demand from the world of statecraft and strategy—and perhaps the decision-making world beyond—for people who can effectively think historically? Second, what are the best ways to impart a historical sensibility and generate the skills to think historically? What curricula, activities, and training are needed to learn those skills? Third, who should offer this pedagogy? These are complex issues, deserving wider debate and study.

Unfortunately, there exists no organized effort, within or outside the academy, to explore these questions. Given the potentially catastrophic costs of poor statecraft and strategy and the enormous benefits that successful statecraft and strategy offer, we should make a more sustained effort to encourage a historical sensibility and the deployment of historical thinking toward understanding and solving our most pressing global problems. If only a fraction of the time and resources that are dedicated to evaluating the impact of emerging technologies, for example, were devoted to exploring how thinking historically might benefit politics and policy, the rewards to the nation and the world could be extraordinary. Not that the two are mutually exclusive. Understanding the profound changes that the Gutenberg printing press unleashed on Europe after its invention in the fifteenth century, for example, might suggest ways to think about the challenges brought by our current age of machine learning and artificial intelligence.

In the absence of deeper study and discussion, any answer to the demand for a historical sensibility is largely speculative. But I can offer some tentative hypotheses.

Is there a demand for people who think historically? Few careers explicitly require a historical sensibility, let alone training in history. Many, however, demand other qualities that a training in history arguably provides as effectively as any other discipline: critical thinking and analysis, an ability to challenge assumptions and understand diverse perspectives, clear writing, and a capacity for complex research. Thinking historically improves how we analyze, evaluate, and make difficult choices in complex environments facing an uncertain future. Individuals and indeed institutional cultures that emphasize a historical sensibility should be better positioned to make wiser decisions and achieve better outcomes.

Part of the challenge is that the organizations and professions that conduct our statecraft and design geopolitical strategy are largely unaware of the benefits of a historical sensibility. This sensibility, and the historical thinking that emerges from it, demands both individual and institutional advocates and champions. Historians who care about statecraft and strategy—and consequential decision-making writ large—might organize and make their case for what they do and how they do it. Institutions dedicated to improving statecraft and strategy, indeed, policymaking and decision-making more broadly, should assist these efforts and support rigorous study and training in history.

What does a person need to learn to develop a historical sensibility?

The skills and insights needed to think historically exist on several levels. To become a historian of statecraft and strategy, you must pursue the rigorous training that culminates in earning a PhD. Doctoral students master an enormous substantive literature, learn how to conduct primary research—often in multiple languages and from sources that are difficult to access—and produce original historical research and scholarship. As part of their training, they create new knowledge and insights, either into a historical question people have debated for years or on a subject of which we had



no previous awareness. Their scholarship is evaluated and anonymously peer-reviewed by other PhD-trained historians. Books and articles might follow, which would shape the contours of our knowledge of the past.

Most PhD-trained historians, if they are fortunate, take up tenure-track positions in universities and colleges, continuing and expanding their research. Within these institutions, historians determine the content of classes and degree requirements for students majoring in history. They may also train and mentor future historians in graduate programs.

There is no reason to believe that the only use for advanced historical training is to become a professor of history. The skills and insights acquired by historians should allow them to thrive in other fields. In the United States, recent national security advisers have included people possessing PhDs in the fields of international relations and political science, while others have earned law degrees. As this book has shown, it is not clear why advanced training in law or political science prepares a person better than history for these tasks or a career in foreign and national security policy more broadly. Thinking historically lends itself to undertaking intelligence and analysis, statecraft and diplomacy, and strategy and military affairs. Well-trained historians could excel in the Pentagon or ministries of defense, intelligence agencies, development and aid organizations, and foreign offices and embassies. Their skills could be useful in many other fields, including the private sector, which often demands difficult and consequential choices about an unknowable and complex future. The problems of statecraft and strategy are not going away, and the need for talent will only increase.

A PhD in history, however, is not a prerequisite for acquiring a historical sensibility or to thinking historically. The insights and skills that come from thinking historically are multiple: to understand both spatial and temporal perspective, to push back against the idea of inevitability and path dependence, to think about how structure and agency interact, to challenge core assumptions and beliefs, to ask better questions, to recognize when the past is being misapplied or misused, to develop a sense of epistemological humility and prudence while recognizing important and possibly novel opportunities, among many other virtues. At least some capabilities can be developed through training short of a PhD and without producing a doctoral thesis, a process that can take the better part of a decade. Once you acquire these skills, moreover, you can improve them by repeatedly applying them to real-world examples, and examining and learning from the “after action” analysis of each effort. How does one acquire and develop the ability to think historically without becoming an academic historian? A historical sensibility demands more than one advanced history class but surely less than a full PhD program.

The curricula offered in American schools of public policy and international affairs, business, and law take anywhere from one to three years to complete. Each of these curricula requires certain core courses: in law schools, constitutional law, legal procedure, and torts; finance, accounting, micro- and macroeconomics for business;

public administration, statistics, and international relations theory for policy and international affairs. This coursework provides substantive knowledge about important issues and processes while training students' minds in a certain way of thinking and understanding the world. A historical sensibility would be an excellent complement to legal reasoning, policy development, quantitative analysis, and the other modes of thought fostered in advanced graduate and professional training. Teaching students how to think historically would provide graduates of law, business, public policy, and international affairs schools with a great advantage.

Interestingly, this kind of pedagogy is offered, but on an ad hoc and often implicit basis. The most prestigious business schools, led by the Harvard School of Business, pursue a case study method in which the histories of important events, episodes, people, and institutions are studied and mined for contemporary and future lessons. This model has been adopted by a number of schools of public policy and international affairs. In law school, legal issues from the past are studied for precedent, which involves wrestling with the past. Even medical schools have small but thriving programs in the history of medicine and science. A smattering of historians are employed at graduate schools of public policy, public administration, and international affairs.

The growing numbers of historians teaching and mentoring future public and private sector leaders outside history departments are a welcome development. The trend has been motivated by a belief at professional schools and in interdisciplinary centers that historical research matters and that history is an important part of their students' education. This salutary trend has not been driven by any particular wisdom or well-planned effort by historians. Fairly or not, historians who find themselves employed outside of history departments often feel like refugees, exiled from their home discipline. Which leads to the third question, that of supply: Who should provide the talent, ideas, resources, and pedagogy to instill and evangelize for the fundamental importance of a historical sensibility in matters of statecraft and strategy, as well as in decision-making generally?

Can this task of promoting thinking historically in statecraft and strategy be entrusted to the academic discipline of history? There are reasons for doubt. Three troubling trends within the history discipline in the United States reveal why. First, for decades, the field has actively discouraged the serious study of statecraft and strategy. If you doubt this claim, you can verify it through simple observation. Pick any year from the 1970s or 1980s and look at four things: the roster of tenured professors in the top-ranked history departments at American universities; the program for the annual meetings of the Organization of American Historians and the American Historical Association; the articles published in the *American Historical Review* and the *Journal of American History*; and the course enrollments for various history classes at any American university. Then compare your findings with the same data from any year in the past decade. The disappearance of expertise, content, and course offerings related to statecraft and strategy, or decision-making in general, in history departments is jarring

and, given the importance of global affairs in our increasingly dangerous world and the desperate need for knowledge in these areas, mind-bogglingly irresponsible.

A second reason for doubt is that while a scattered handful of diplomatic and military historians remain in history departments, they often define their research and teaching in ways that have little connection to the world of statecraft and strategy as decision-makers actually experienced it.<sup>1</sup>

Third, by almost any measure—the count of students majoring in history or taking history courses, the number of tenure-track positions available to PhD students in history, or even the prestige, influence, and respect conferred both within and outside the academy—departments of history have suffered a precipitous and seemingly irreversible decline in their standing within universities.

While the reasons for these developments within history—abandoning the serious study of statecraft and strategy, broadening the definition of diplomatic and military history in ways that confuse and confound those outside the ivory tower, and the ongoing collapse of the history discipline within the academy—are not entirely clear, it is fair to argue that they are not unrelated. In the decades since the field turned its back on statecraft and strategy, the need to understand policy—the vacuum in courses taught and majors sought, tenure-track positions created and filled, and influence wielded on decision-making and the larger world—has been filled largely by scholars in other fields, including economists and international relations theorists in political science departments. Even in the face of its own steep decline and a large and expanding external interest in applying history to big policy problems, there is little reason to think the field of history will take up the serious study of statecraft and strategy in a way that engages the world outside the narrow confines of the discipline. The answer to who will champion historical sensibility, encourage historical thinking, and teach students to apply these skills to difficult choices and complex problems will have to come from outside history departments.

If those departments won't meet the demand, who might? One idea is to reorganize our resources, talent, and incentives in higher education to create a new discipline around history, statecraft, and strategy. This new field would exploit the best insights, methods, and norms of history while moving away from some of the pathologies that have left the discipline in dire straits. Most important, it would focus on how history could be used to better understand, evaluate, and make choices in statecraft and strategy, broadly defined. Its insights could be applied more widely and become a required skill for anyone hoping to attain a position of responsibility, in the same way that decision-makers are now expected to have some understanding of statistics and data analysis. Such an effort might build upon the foundational work by historians who are currently in professional schools and interdisciplinary research centers, and it would welcome those from history departments who wish to join. This new intellectual configuration might also include scholars and experts from other fields

—anthropology, international relations, economics, political philosophy, law, political science—as well as integrate historically trained practitioners in statecraft and strategy. Such a program could be located within or across universities through a consortium, and it could offer majors, graduate degrees, and eventually the coin of the realm in American higher education: a distinct PhD followed by tenure-track academic positions.<sup>2</sup> Courses and programs could also be organized outside universities, by public- and private-sector institutions eager to imbue a historical sensibility within their organizations and train their members to think historically.

How might this be done? We often think of cognate disciplines in higher education as set in stone, permanent and unending. This certainly seems true in much of the humanities and social sciences, where fields ranging from anthropology to English literature to political science—and including history—became organized and professionalized in leading American and European research universities in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. While these disciplines have undergone enormous internal changes based on (often contested) methodological, ideological, and epistemological debates, few humanities or social science disciplines have disappeared or merged, and except for identity studies programs, few new disciplines have appeared over the past century and a half. The story is different in the natural sciences and engineering, where new fields, research programs, disciplines, and departments spring up routinely, often driven by new problems or issues of interest. In the life sciences, a wide array of distinct fields has emerged: neurosciences, structural biology, bioinformatics, and environmental sciences, to name a few. MIT's Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science offers twenty-six different research programs, from "Artificial Intelligence and Society" to "Theory of Computation."

If this effort took hold, its goal would be not to replace history as a discipline but to expand how, to whom, and for what purposes history is offered. If this new grouping of history, statecraft, and strategy succeeded, it would benefit traditional history departments; a historical sensibility would be encouraged, thinking historically would be prized, and the talents, scholarship, and pedagogy of traditional departments would be more esteemed.

The exact path to promoting a historical sensibility and revitalizing historical thought in statecraft and strategy may be different. Historians and those who care about history should vigorously debate what should be done. Any path forward is likely to be controversial. What should not be controversial, however, is the extraordinary benefits—to historians, to analysts and policymakers, and to the larger world—of highlighting the power of a historical sensibility and the benefits of thinking historically.

# Notes

## 1

### Thinking Historically

1. Errol Morris, “The Umbrella Man,” *New York Times*, Op-Docs, November 22, 2001, <http://www.nytimes.com/video/opinion/100000001183275/the-umbrella-man.html>.
2. John Pavlus, “Errol Morris’s Secret Weapon for Unsettling Interviews: The Interrotron,” *FastCodeDesign*, January 26, 2011, <http://www.fastcodesign.com/1663105/errol-morriss-secret-weapon-for-unsettling-interviews-the-interrotron>.
3. John Updike, “Comment,” *New Yorker*, December 9, 1967, 51, accessed at <http://www.newyorker.com/magazine/1967/12/09/comment-5149>.
4. “Testimony of Louie Steven Witt,” in *Investigation of the Assassination of President John F. Kennedy, Hearings Before the House Select Committee on Assassinations of the U.S. House of Representatives, Ninety-Fifth Congress, Second Session, September 22, 25, and 26, 1978*, vol. 4 (Washington, DC: US GPO, 1979), 431, 439, accessed at [http://aarclibrary.org/publib/jfk/hasca/reportvols/vol4/html/HSCA\\_Vol4\\_0217a.htm](http://aarclibrary.org/publib/jfk/hasca/reportvols/vol4/html/HSCA_Vol4_0217a.htm).
5. Morris, “The Umbrella Man.”
6. It is worth noting that in the film, Josiah Thompson slightly mischaracterizes both John Updike’s comment and the testimony of Louis Steven Witt in his comments, unwittingly proving how challenging it can be to get the most complete, accurate account of the past.
7. Sir Llewellyn Woodward, “The Place of the Historian in Modern Society,” in Association of Princeton Graduate Alumni, *Report of the Third Conference Held at the Graduate College of Princeton University, January 1–3, 1953* (Princeton, NJ: Institute for Advanced Study, n.d.), 48.
8. Gordon S. Wood, *The Purpose of the Past: Reflections on the Uses of History* (New York: Penguin, 2009), 11. “To be able to see the participants of the past in this comprehensive way, to see them in the context of their own time, to describe their blindness and folly with sympathy, to recognize the extent to which they were caught up in changing circumstances over which they had little control, and to realize the degree to which they created results they never intended—to know all this about the past and to be able to relate it without anachronistic distortion to our present is what is meant by having a historical sense.” There is a key question of whether past follies should be seen with *empathy*—my view—as opposed to sympathy.
9. Hannah Arendt quoted in Becca Rothfeld, “For Argument’s Sake: In Praise of High School Debate,” *Yale Review* 110, no. 2 (2022), accessed at <https://yalereview.org/article/becca-rothfeld-debate>.
10. For an excellent history of how the historical discipline developed in the United States, see Peter Novick, *That Noble Dream: The “Objectivity Question” and the American Historical Profession* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988).
11. Erin Blakemore, “Betsy Ross Likely Didn’t Sew the First U.S. Flag,” *National Geographic*, July 1, 2021, <https://www.nationalgeographic.com/history/article/betsy-ross-likely-didnt-sew-the-first-us-flag>. The museum itself does a fair job of wrestling with the myth: <https://historicphiladelphia.org/betsy-ross-house/>.
12. Emma Rothschild, *An Infinite History: The Story of a Family in France over Three Centuries* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2021).

13. Ernest May, *“Lessons” of the Past: The Use and Misuse of History in American Foreign Policy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1973), 179.
14. Elizabeth A. R. Brown, “Feudalism: Reflections on a Tyrannical Construct’s Fate,” *American Historical Review* 79 (1974): 1063–88, reprinted in Jackson W. Armstrong, Peter Crooks, and Andrea Ruddick, eds., *Using Concepts in Medieval History: Perspectives on Britain and Ireland, 1100–1500* (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2022), 15–49.
15. Manisha Sinha, *The Rise and Fall of the Second American Republic: Reconstruction, 1860–1920* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2024).
16. Christopher Clark, *The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914*, reprint ed. (New York: Harper Perennial, 2014), xxix.
17. Philip Zelikow, email exchange with author, December 22, 2022.
18. Clark, *Sleepwalkers*, xxvi.
19. Edward Hallett Carr, *What Is History?* (New York: Vintage, 1961), 35.
20. John Lewis Gaddis, *The Landscape of History: How Historians Map the Past* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002), 92.
21. Philip Zelikow, email exchange with author, April 7, 2019.
22. Philip Zelikow, “The Nature of History’s Lessons,” in *The Power of the Past: History and Statecraft*, ed. Hal Brands and Jeremi Suri (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press, 2016), 282–83. “Yet the first way, the way of simplification, is much easier. The reader or listener does not need much background information or special training. The simpler the points, the easier they are to explain. And many simple generalizations do have obvious value along with the value of being, well, obvious. The second way, however, offers greater and more lasting yields. In medicine, for example, there have long been many rewards from careful study of gross anatomy, examining what anyone could see. It might have seemed simpler not to bother with microscopes. Few people had microscopes or could use them. And it may have seemed as if so much could be understood without bothering about the significance of things like germs, genes, or molecules. After all, hardly anyone could see those things. They were hard to understand. So too in the examination of great human actions.”
23. For an outstanding history of the origins and perspective of the Kennedy School and its faculty, in particular Neustadt and May, see Bruce Kuklick, *Blind Oracles: Intellectuals and War from Kennan to Kissinger* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2006), 152–67.
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## 2

### History for Policy

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5. Matt Reed, “Where Should History Go?,” *Inside Higher Ed*, May 28, 2018, <https://www.insidehighered.com/blogs/confessions-community-college-dean/where-should-history-go>.
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7. Edward Hallett Carr, *What Is History?* (New York: Vintage, 1961), 77.
8. Sir Llewellyn Woodward, "The Place of the Historian in Modern Society," in Association of Princeton Graduate Alumni, *Report of the Third Conference Held at the Graduate College of Princeton University, January 1–3, 1953* (Princeton, NJ: Institute for Advanced Study, n.d.), 48.
9. Ernest May, *"Lessons" of the Past: The Use and Misuse of History in American Foreign Policy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1973), 179.
10. Margaret MacMillan, *Dangerous Games: The Uses and Abuses of History* (New York: Modern Library, 2009), 81.
11. MacMillan, *Dangerous Games*, 81.
12. James B. Steinberg, "Too Much History: American Policy and East Asia in the Shadow of the Past," *Texas National Security Review* 1, no. 1 (2017): 120–25.
13. I am grateful to Joshua Botts for this insight.
14. MacMillan, *Dangerous Games*, 144.
15. See Charles Leerhsen, "Who Was Ty Cobb? The History We Know That's Wrong," *Imprimis* 45, no. 3 (2016), <https://imprimis.hillsdale.edu/who-was-ty-cobb-the-history-we-know-thats-wrong/>; and Charles Leerhsen, *Ty Cobb: A Terrible Beauty* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 2016). For another version of how one must read even accomplished biographers very carefully, see Will Inboden, "It's Impossible to Count the Things Wrong with the Negligent, Spurious, Distorted New Biography of George W. Bush," *Foreign Policy*, August 15, 2016, <http://foreignpolicy.com/2016/08/15/its-impossible-to-count-the-things-wrong-with-the-negligent-spurious-distorted-new-biography-of-george-w-bush>.
16. Leerhsen, "Who Was Ty Cobb?"
17. Bruce Kuklick, *Blind Oracles: Intellectuals and War from Kennan to Kissinger* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2006), 159.
18. William Inboden, Review of Carter Malkasian, *The American War in Afghanistan: A History*, International Security Studies Forum, Roundtable Review 14-9, January 27, 2023, <https://issforum.org/to/jrt14-9>.
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20. Eric Foner, interviewed by Nawal Arjini, "Light Under a Bushel," *New York Review of Books*, September 17, 2022.
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22. William Doyle, *The Oxford History of the French Revolution* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), 451.
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32. A. J. P. Taylor, “Mistaken Lessons from the Past,” *Listener*, June 6, 1963.
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34. Gordon S. Wood, *The Purpose of the Past: Reflections on the Uses of History* (New York: Penguin, 2009), 15.
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38. John W. Dower quoted in Avi Zenilman, “Historian: Bush Use of Quote ‘Perverse,’ ” *Politico*, August 23, 2007, <http://www.politico.com/story/2007/08/historian-bush-use-of-quote-perverse-005499>. See also John W. Dower, “Remaking History: Bush’s Comparison of Iraq with Postwar Japan Ignores the Facts,” *Asia Pacific Journal* 1, no. 5 (2003): 1660, <http://apjif.org/-John-W.-Dower/1660/article.html>; and John W. Dower, “A Warning from History,” *Boston Review*, February 1, 2003, <https://www.bostonreview.net/world/john-w-dower-warning-history>.
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40. Woodward, “Place of the Historian,” 42.
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### 3

## Questioning the Cold War

1. Chris Buckley, “To Steer China’s Future, Xi Is Rewriting Its Past,” *New York Times*, November 15, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/11/07/world/asia/china-xi-jinping.html>; William Partlett, “Putin’s Past: The Return of Ideological History and the Strongman,” *Perspectives on History*, December 7, 2022, <https://www.historians.org/perspectives-article/putins-past-the-return-of-ideological-history-and-the-strongman-january-2022/>.
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17. Radchenko, *To Run the World*.
18. John Lewis Gaddis, "The Long Peace: Elements of Stability in the Postwar International System," *International Security* 10, no. 4 (1986): 142.
19. John J. Mearsheimer, "Why We Will Soon Miss the Cold War," *Atlantic Monthly Online*, August 1990, <https://www.theatlantic.com/past/docs/politics/foreign/mearsh.htm>.
20. Paul Thomas Chamberlain, *The Cold War's Killing Fields: Rethinking the Long Peace* (New York: HarperCollins, 2018), 1.
21. Chamberlain, *Cold War's Killing Fields*, 5.
22. Erez Manela, "A Pox on Your Narrative: Writing Disease into Cold War History," *Diplomatic History* 34, no. 2 (2010): 299–323. A key element was the Johnson administration's decision, as part of an effort to improve its global standing during the Vietnam War, to accept the Soviet Union's offer to cooperate on the World Health Organization's smallpox eradication program (SEP). Yet far more was involved than simply high policy: "But the history of the SEP is more than just a story of interstate relations, and writing it into Cold War history requires us to adopt a broader conception of international society, one that combines attention to state actors with recognition of the role played by international organizations, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), multinational corporations, and transnational 'epistemic communities' that produce, circulate, and deploy expert knowledge" (301).
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24. President John F. Kennedy, Commencement Address, American University, June 10, 1963, <https://www.jfklibrary.org/archives/other-resources/john-f-kennedy-speeches/american-university-19630610>.
25. Francis J. Gavin, *Nuclear Weapons and American Grand Strategy* (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press, 2020).
26. Benedetto Croce, *Historical Materialism and the Economics of Karl Marx* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1922), 19.
27. Tony Judt, *Postwar: A History of Europe Since 1945* (New York: Penguin, 2005), 2, 8.
28. Fritz Bartel, *The Triumph of Broken Promises: The End of the Cold War and the Rise of Neoliberalism* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2022).
29. Gary Gerstle, *The Rise and Fall of the Neoliberal Order: America and the World in the Free Market Era* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2022), 11.
30. See, e.g., Angus Burgin, *The Great Persuasion: Reinventing Free Markets Since the Great Depression* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2015); and Quinn Slobodian, *Globalists: The End of Empire and the Birth of Neoliberalism* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018).
31. Matthew Connelly, "The Cold War in the *Long Durée*: Global Migration, Public Health, and Population Control," in *The Cambridge History of the Cold War*, vol. 3: *Endings*, ed. Melvyn Leffler and Odd Arne Westad (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 466.

## 4

### Insights and Tools

1. Ernest R. May and Richard E. Neustadt, *Thinking in Time: The Uses of History for Decision Makers* (New York: Free Press, 1986), 105–6, 234–39.
2. I lay out this argument in Francis J. Gavin, *The Taming of Scarcity and the Problems of Plenty: Rethinking International Relations and American Grand Strategy in a New Era* (London: Routledge, 2024).
3. Matthew Connelly, "The Cold War in the *Long Durée*: Global Migration, Public Health, and Population Control," in *The Cambridge History of the Cold War*, vol. 3: *Endings*, ed. Melvyn Leffler and Odd Arne Westad

(Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 466.

4. Or, as Connelly shows, generates unwanted or unintended consequences when policy is applied. Matthew Connelly, *Fatal Misconception: The Struggle to Control World Population* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008).

5. Mary Sarotte, *The Collapse: The Accidental Opening of the Berlin Wall* (New York: Basic Books, 2014).

6. James B. Steinberg, “The Good Friday Agreement: Ending War and Conflict in Northern Ireland,” *Texas National Security Review* 2, no. 3 (2019): 78–102.

7. For an excellent version of this argument, see James J. Sheehan, “The Transformation of Europe and the End of the Cold War,” in *The Fall of the Berlin Wall: The Revolutionary Legacy of 1989*, ed. Jeffrey A. Engel (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012), 36–68.

8. Vladimir Putin quoted in Claire Bigg, “World: Was Soviet Collapse Last Century’s Worst Geopolitical Catastrophe?,” RadioFreeEurope, April 29, 2005, <https://www.rferl.org/a/1058688.html>.

9. Philip Zelikow, “Why Did America Cross the Pacific? Reconstructing the U.S. Decision to Take the Philippines, 1898–99,” *Texas National Security Review* 1, no. 1 (2017): 37.

10. Marc Trachtenberg, *A Constructed Peace: The Making of the European Settlement, 1945–1963* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1999), esp. 352–402.

11. James Joll, *1914: The Unspoken Assumptions: An Inaugural Lecture Delivered 25 April 1968, the London School of Economics and Political Science* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1968).

12. John Lewis Gaddis, *The Landscape of History: How Historians Map the Past* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002), 53–54.

13. This important point is discussed in Steven Weber, “Counterfactuals, Past and Future,” in *Counterfactual Thought Experiments in World Politics: Logical, Methodological, and Psychological Perspectives*, ed. Philip E. Tetlock and Aaron Belkin (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996), 268–88.

## 5

### The History Checklist

1. Atul Gawande, *The Checklist Manifesto* (London: Profile Books, 2011), 19.

2. Gawande, *Checklist Manifesto*, 24.

3. The analysis that follows is based on Francis J. Gavin, *Gold, Dollars, and Power: The Politics of International Monetary Relations, 1958–1971* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2004).

4. Walt Rostow to Lyndon B. Johnson, October 4, 1966, cover letter for Averell Harriman memo, “Negotiations,” National Security File, Lyndon B. Johnson Library, Austin, TX.

5. Rostow to Johnson.

6. James Joll, *1914: The Unspoken Assumptions: An Inaugural Lecture Delivered 25 April 1968, the London School of Economics and Political Science* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1968).

7. I am grateful to Ben Rhode for alerting me to this essay and highlighting its insight.

8. Joll, *1914*, 6.

9. Joll, *1914*, 23.

10. Fredrik Logevall, *Choosing War: The Lost Chance for Peace and the Escalation of War in Vietnam* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999).

11. Francis J. Gavin, “The World’s Biggest Crisis Is the End of Scarcity,” *Foreign Policy*, March 16, 2024, <https://foreignpolicy.com/2024/03/16/end-of-scarcity-crisis-growth-war/>.

12. For this argument, see Francis J. Gavin, *The Taming of Scarcity and the Problems of Plenty: Rethinking International Relations and American Grand Strategy in a New Era* (London: Routledge, 2024).

13. Fred I. Greenstein and Richard H. Immerman, “What Did Eisenhower Tell Kennedy About Indochina? The Politics of Misperception,” *Journal of American History* 79, no. 2 (1992): 577.

14. Greenstein and Immerman, “What Did Eisenhower Tell Kennedy?,” 577.

15. Edward Hallett Carr, *What Is History?* (New York: Vintage, 1961), 12.

16. Ernest R. May, “Lessons” of the Past: *The Use and Misuse of History in American Foreign Policy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1973), 67.

17. May, “Lessons” of the Past, 86, 69.

18. C. S. Lewis, "Learning in War-Time," sermon preached in the Church of St. Mary the Virgin, Oxford, Autumn 1939, accessed at <https://bradleyggreen.com/attachments/Lewis.Learning%20in%20War-Time.pdf>.

19. Indeed, the story reveals even more context and circumstance. Joseph Caillaux was well known for seeking détente with Germany and attempting to avoid war. The parliamentary elections of April and May 1914 saw his Radical Party receive the most votes, followed by Jean Jaurès's socialists, and a government between the two may have worked hard to avoid conflict. Jaurès himself was assassinated on the eve of the war. Jack Beatty, "The Cleopatra's Nose of 1914," *Lapham's Quarterly* 13, no. 2 (2020), accessed at <https://www.laphamsquarterly.org/scandal/cleopatras-nose-1914>.

20. See George Dangerfield's classic work *The Strange Death of Liberal England* [1935], new ed. (London: Serif, 2012).

21. Edward Thomas, "Still Friends on the Eve of War: The Kiel Naval Review of June 1914," Roads to the Great War (blog), November 27, 2020, <http://roadstothegreatwar-ww1.blogspot.com/2020/11/still-friends-on-eve-of-war-kiel-naval.html>.

22. "Transcript of Testimony of Sandy R. Berger," *Wall Street Journal*, online ed., March 24, 2004, <http://www.wsj.com/articles/SB108015599618064350>.

23. C. Vann Woodward, introduction to James M. McPherson, *Battle Cry of Freedom: The Civil War Era*, Kindle ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003). The Civil War generation "lived through an experience in which time and consciousness took on new dimensions.' These new dimensions have to be reckoned with by the historians recording the experience. If participants in that era had the experience of 'living a lifetime in a year,' historians can reasonably demand more pages and chapters to do justice to such years. That also helps to explain why far more has been written about these particular years than any others in American history. The more written, the more disclosed, and the more questions and controversies to be coped with by latter-day historians."

24. For an excellent discussion of these issues, see Andrew Erhardt, "Everyman His Own Philosopher of History: Notions of Historical Process in the Study and Practice of Foreign Policy," *Texas National Security Review* 5, no. 3 (2022): 11–32.

## Postscript: What Is to Be Done?

1. For an excellent assessment of this trend, see Hal Brands, "The Triumph and Tragedy of Diplomatic History," *Texas National Security Review* 1, no. 1 (2017): 133–43.

2. For an excellent argument on behalf of an interdisciplinary field focused on improved policymaking, see Philip Zelikow, "To Regain Policy Competence: The Software of American Problem Solving," *Texas National Security Review* 2, no. 4 (2019): 110–27.



# Index

Acheson, Dean, [152](#)  
Acton, Lord, [71](#)  
Afghanistan, [38–39](#)  
agency, [132](#), [133–37](#)  
Allison, Graham, [73](#); *Destined for War*, [134](#)  
analogies, historical, [28](#), [84–85](#), [196–97](#)  
anamnesis, historical, [160](#), [175–79](#)  
Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty, [116](#)  
antiquarianism, [53](#)  
Arab nationalism, [120](#)  
Arendt, Hannah, [13](#)  
assumptions, unspoken, [66–67](#), [160](#), [172–75](#)  
Athens, [6](#), [7](#)  
atomic bombs. *See* [nuclear weapons](#)  
Atomic Energy Commission., [89](#)  
Austria-Hungary, [163](#)  
  
Bartel, Fritz, [119](#)  
Barzun, Jacques, [44–45](#)  
Berger, Samuel R. “Sandy,” [193](#)  
Berlin blockade, [89](#)  
Bernanke, Ben, [39–40](#)  
Bessner, Daniel, [93–94](#)  
Betsy Ross House, [18](#)  
bias, [68](#), [69](#), [70](#); outcome, [26](#), [71–72](#), [161](#), [190–93](#); retrospective, [125](#)  
binary morality, [198](#)  
Black Death, [190](#)  
Bossuet, Jacques-Bénigne, [202](#)  
Bretton Woods system, [118](#), [167](#)  
Brown, Elizabeth A. R., [22](#)  
Brown, John, [183](#)  
Buchanan, Andrew, [94](#)  
Bush, George H. W., [105](#)  
Bush, George W., [38](#), [39](#), [78](#), [83](#)  
business sector, transformation of, [126–27](#)  
  
Caillaux, Henriette, [192](#)  
Caillaux, Joseph, [226 n.19](#)  
California, [128–29](#)  
Carr, Edward Hallett, [32](#), [49](#), [71](#), [151](#), [182](#)  
Carter, James Earl, [104](#), [123–24](#)  
causality, [11](#), [24](#), [49](#), [132](#), [133–37](#); Cold War, [95–102](#), [152](#); World War I, [162–66](#), [172–73](#), [191–92](#)  
Central Intelligence Agency, [166](#)



Chaing Kai-shek, [89](#)  
Chamberlain, Neville, [74](#), [84](#)  
Chamberlain, Paul Thomas, [101](#)  
checklists: anamnesis, [160](#), [175–79](#); application of, [159](#); assumptions, unspoken, [160](#), [172–75](#); chronological proportionality, [161](#), [184–87](#); historical, [159–205](#); historical purposes, [161](#), [201–4](#); horizontal history, [160](#), [167–72](#); malpractice, historical, [161](#), [194–98](#); myopia, historical, [161](#), [198–201](#); outcome bias, [161](#), [190–93](#); perspective, [160](#), [179–83](#); punctuated equilibrium, [161](#), [193–94](#); purpose of, [158–60](#); time lags, [160](#), [175–79](#); unintended consequences, [161](#), [187–90](#); unspoken assumptions, [160](#), [172–75](#); vertical history, [160](#), [161–67](#)  
China, [90](#), [93](#), [119](#), [143](#); civil war, [89](#); Communist Revolution, [115](#); Nixon visit to, [186](#), [189](#); nuclear devices in, [117](#), [171](#); Soviet Union relationship with, [188–89](#); Vietnam, involvement in, [107](#), [189](#)  
choice, [132](#), [154–55](#)  
chronological proportionality, [161](#), [184–87](#)  
chronology, [160](#), [161–67](#); Cold War, [87–95](#), [139](#)  
Churchill, Winston, [88](#)  
Clark, Christopher: *Sleepwalkers, The*, [26–27](#), [31](#), [69](#), [72](#), [163](#), [223 n.16](#)  
Cobb, Ty, [64–65](#)  
Cold War, [25–26](#), [83–130](#), [140–41](#), [168](#); Arab nationalism and, [120](#); causes of, [95–102](#), [152](#); commencement of, [87–95](#); containment, [105–9](#), [182](#); decolonization and, [115–16](#); end of, [92–95](#), [102–9](#), [139](#), [141–44](#), [152](#); European integration and, [114](#); globalization and, [118–19](#); interaction with other global forces, [109–22](#); leaders during, [133](#); nationalism and, [115–16](#), [120](#); nuclear arms and, [116–18](#); policy, importance of in, [122–30](#); political Islam and, [120](#); rights and identity revolution and, [120–22](#), [125–26](#)  
Connelly, Matthew, [121](#), [136](#)  
consequences, unintended, [161](#), [187–90](#)  
containment, [105–9](#), [141–42](#), [182](#)  
counterfactuals, [188](#), [199](#); analysis of, [149–54](#)  
critical junctures, [132](#), [137–41](#)  
Croce, Benedetto, [113](#)  
Cuban Missile Crisis, [90](#), [116](#)  
cultural norms, [126](#), [128](#)  
  
decolonization, [115–16](#)  
Deng Xiaoping, [93](#)  
détente, [91](#), [103](#), [107](#), [123](#)  
Dower, John W., [78](#)  
Doyle, William, [70](#)  
  
Eastern Europe, [89](#), [125](#)  
Eden, Sir Anthony, [82–83](#)  
Eisenhower, Dwight D., [152](#), [167](#), [168](#); “Chance for Peace” speech, [140–41](#); meeting with Kennedy (1961), [180](#)  
Engerman, David, [92](#)  
Europe: Eastern, [89](#), [125](#); integration of, [114](#). *See also specific countries*  
European Union, [114](#)  
evidence, [31–32](#), [67](#), [68–69](#), [70–71](#)  
  
Federal Republic of Germany. *See* [West Germany](#)  
Ferdinand, Archduke Franz, [151](#), [163](#), [164](#), [191](#)  
Ferguson, Niall, [73](#)  
finance capitalism, [126](#)  
First Balkan War, [163](#), [191](#)  
First World War. *See* [World War I](#)  
Fischer, Fritz: *Germany’s Aims in the First World War*, [172](#), [183](#)  
Foner, Eric, [69](#)  
Ford, Gerald, [73](#)  
*Foreign Affairs*, [106](#)

France, [89](#), [114](#), [117](#), [142](#), [163](#)  
French Revolution, [70](#)  
Gaddafi, Muammar, [120](#)  
Gaddis, John Lewis, [33](#), [49](#), [98](#), [100](#), [150](#)  
Gawande, Atul: *Checklist Manifesto, The*, [159](#), [160](#)  
Germany, [142](#), [163](#). *See also* [West Germany](#)  
Gerstle, Gary, [119](#)  
Gerwarth, Robert, [94](#)  
globalization, [118–19](#)  
Goldberg rule, [132](#)  
Gorbachev, Mikhail, [103](#), [104](#), [124](#), [133](#), [152](#)  
Gould, Stephen Jay, [193](#)  
Great Britain, [115](#), [117](#), [163](#), [185](#)  
Greece, [89](#); Athens, [6](#), [7](#)  
Greenstein, Fred I., [180](#)  
  
Harriman, Averell, [169](#)  
Harvard: John F. Kennedy School of Government, [36](#), [37](#), [132](#); School of Business, [211](#)  
Hay, John, [97](#)  
Hegel, Georg Wilhelm Friedrich, [202](#)  
Helsinki Accords (1975), [123](#)  
historians: applied, [73](#); careers for, [209–10](#); choices made by, [28–35](#); professional, [16–17](#); work of, [20–28](#)  
historical sensibility, [10–15](#), [16](#), [24–25](#), [76–77](#), [131](#); benefits of, [63–66](#), [157](#), [206–7](#), [208](#); characteristics of, [12–14](#); definition of, [10](#); developing, [19](#), [80](#), [207](#), [209](#), [210–15](#); judgment and, [13](#); nationalism and, [55–57](#); overcertainty and, [53–55](#); power of, [10](#), [37–38](#), [40–41](#), [113](#); rigidity and, [53–55](#); scientific approach and, [48–52](#); vertigo, historical, [59–62](#), [154](#); victimology and, [57–59](#)  
historicization, [49–50](#)  
history: contemporary, [66–72](#); dangers of, [63–66](#); diplomatic, [43](#); engaging with the past, [16–20](#), [52–53](#); goals of, [23–28](#); horizontal, [160](#), [167–72](#); as humanities, [44–45](#), [51–52](#); military, [43](#); misuse of, [42](#), [52–62](#); policy, use to inform, [73–81](#); as social science, [44–45](#), [51–52](#); uncertainty and, [4–5](#), [12–13](#); vertical, [160](#), [161–67](#)  
Hitler, Adolf, [96](#)  
horizontal history, [160](#), [167–72](#)  
House Select Committee on Assassinations, [2–3](#)  
humanities: history as, [44–45](#), [51–52](#)  
Humphrey, Hubert, [152](#)  
hypernationalism, [56](#)  
  
identity revolution, [120–22](#), [125–26](#)  
Immerman, Richard H., [180](#)  
Immerwahr, Daniel, [93](#)  
Inboden, Will, [67](#)  
India, [115](#), [117](#)  
individual leadership. *See* [leaders](#)  
Indonesia, [119](#)  
inevitability, historical, [149–50](#), [197](#)  
innovation, [127](#)  
*Inside Higher Ed*, [45](#)  
integration of narratives, [132](#), [145](#), [146–49](#)  
intermediate perspective, [180–81](#)  
International Atomic Energy Agency, [117](#)  
international relations (IR), [43–48](#), [50–51](#)  
international system, [133](#), [134](#), [136–37](#)  
Iran, [88](#), [93](#), [120](#), [166](#), [185–86](#)

Iraq, [38](#), [39](#), [78](#), [120](#)  
 Islam, political, [93](#), [120](#)  
 Israel, [117](#), [185](#)  
 Italy, [89](#)  
  
 Japan, [78](#), [97](#), [138](#)  
 Jervis, Robert, [98](#)  
 John F. Kennedy School of Government, [36](#), [132](#); Institute of Politics, [37](#)  
 John Paul II, [125](#)  
 Johnson, Lyndon, [39](#), [152](#), [168](#), [169](#), [174](#)  
 Joll, James: "1914: The Unspoken Assumptions," [146](#), [172](#), [173](#), [191](#), [192](#)  
 Judt, Tony, [114](#)  
 junctures, critical, [132](#), [137–41](#)  
  
 Kennan, George F.: "Long Telegram," [25](#), [88](#), [106](#)  
 Kennedy, John F., [73](#), [133](#), [167](#), [168](#); assassination of, [1](#), [4](#); meeting with Eisenhower (1961), [180](#); "A Strategy for Peace" speech, [107](#), [140–41](#)  
 Khrushchev, Nikita, [90](#), [133](#)  
 Kissinger, Henry, [73](#), [75–76](#), [81](#), [193](#)  
 Korean War, [90](#), [152–53](#), [182–83](#)  
 Kotkin, Stephen, [93](#)  
 Kuklick, Bruce, [67](#), [77](#)  
 Kurosawa, Akira: *Rashomon*, [179](#), [180](#)  
 Kuwait, [120](#)  
  
 leaders, [89](#), [107](#), [133](#), [152](#)  
 Leerhsen, Charles, [65](#)  
 Leffler, Melvyn P., [92](#)  
 Lewis, C. S., [183](#)  
 Logevall, Fredrik, [174](#)  
  
 MacMillan, Margaret, [56](#), [63](#), [77](#)  
 malpractice, historical, [161](#), [194–98](#); analogies, facile historical, [196–97](#); binary morality, [198](#); characteristics of, [196–98](#); inevitability, [197](#); monocausal explanations, [197](#)  
 Manela, Erez, [94](#); "A Pox on Your Narrative: Writing Disease into Cold War History," [101](#), [223 n.22](#)  
 Mao Zedong, [89](#), [90](#)  
 Marx, Karl, [203](#)  
 Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), [215](#)  
 May, Ernest R., [75](#), [79–80](#); "Lessons of the Past," [21–22](#), [50](#), [68](#), [73–74](#), [182–83](#); *Thinking in Time: The Uses of History for Decision Makers*, [36–37](#), [131–32](#)  
 McKinley, William, [145](#)  
 McPherson, James, [194](#)  
 Mearsheimer, John J., [101](#)  
 Middle East, [115](#), [122–23](#); U.S. policy in, [185–86](#), [190](#)  
 Milk, Harvey, [128](#)  
 Molotov, Vyacheslav, [87](#)  
 monocausal explanations, [197](#)  
 morality, binary, [198](#)  
 Morris, Errol, [1](#), [4](#)  
 Mossadegh, Mohammad, [166](#)  
 myopia, historical, [161](#), [198–201](#)  
  
 Napoleon III, [74](#)  
 narratives: integration of, [132](#), [145](#), [146–49](#); macro-, [132](#); micro-, [132](#), [144](#)  
 nationalism, [55–57](#), [115–16](#); Arab, [120](#)

neoliberalism, [119](#)  
 Neustadt, Richard E., [79–80](#); *Thinking in Time: The Uses of History for Decision Makers*, [36–37](#), [131–32](#)  
*New York Times*: “The Umbrella Man,” [1](#)  
 Nitze, Paul, [107](#)  
 Nixon, Richard, [39](#), [73](#), [152](#); China visit by, [186](#), [189](#)  
 North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), [142](#), [166](#)  
 North Korea, [90](#)  
 nostalgia, [53](#)  
 NSC-68, [107](#)  
 Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (1968), [107](#), [117](#), [171](#), [186](#)  
 nuclear weapons, [89–90](#), [147](#); deterrence, [200](#); history of, [116–18](#); Japan, dropped on, [87](#), [97](#); nonproliferation of, [101](#), [171](#), [186](#); war, thermonuclear, [199–200](#); in West Germany, [168–69](#)  
 objectivity, historical, [6–7](#), [60–61](#), [70](#)  
 outcome bias, [26](#), [71–72](#), [161](#), [190–93](#)  
 Pakistan, [117](#)  
 Palestine, [115](#)  
 “paralysis by analysis,” [132](#), [154](#)  
 Paris Peace Conference, [73](#)  
 Pärt, Arvo, [1](#)  
 perspective, [14](#), [66](#), [71](#), [132](#), [141–44](#), [146](#), [160](#), [179–83](#); immediate, [180–81](#); spatial, [180](#), [181–82](#); temporal, [180](#), [182–83](#)  
 pivot points, [137](#)  
 Poland, [88](#)  
 political science, [43–48](#); history and, [43](#); as social science, [44](#), [45](#); theories in, [45–48](#)  
 postrevisionism, [98–99](#)  
 precision, [132](#), [144–46](#)  
 Princip, Gavrilo, [151](#)  
 punctuated equilibrium, [161](#), [193–94](#)  
 purpose, historical, [161](#), [201–4](#)  
 Putin, Vladimir, [83](#), [133](#), [143](#)  
 Radchenko, Sergey, [94](#), [99–100](#)  
 Ranke, Leopold von, [203](#)  
 Reagan, Ronald, [104](#), [105](#), [124–25](#), [128](#), [133](#)  
 realists, [87](#)  
 remembering: need to be remembered, [16](#); need to celebrate the past, [16](#); reasons for, [5–9](#)  
 retrospective bias, [125](#)  
 revisionism, [24](#), [26](#), [34](#), [63–64](#), [97](#)  
 rights revolution, [120–22](#), [125–26](#)  
 Rockefeller, John D., Jr., [18](#)  
 Roosevelt, Franklin D., [87](#), [89](#), [152](#)  
 Ross, Betsy, [18](#)  
 Rostow, Walt, [169–70](#)  
 Rothschild, Emma, [21](#)  
 Rove, Karl, [83](#)  
 Rusk, Dean, [180](#)  
 Russia, [95](#), [96](#), [143](#), [163](#), [166](#). *See also* [Soviet Union](#)  
 Sarotte, Mary, [139](#)  
 Saudi Arabia, [185](#)  
 Schama, Simon: *Citizens*, [69–70](#)  
 Schlesinger, Arthur, Jr., [73](#)  
 Schwarzenegger, Arnold, [128](#)

Second Balkan War, [163](#), [191](#)  
 Second World War. *See* [World War II](#)  
 Serbia, [163](#)  
 Singapore, [119](#)  
 Sinha, Manisha: *Rise and Fall of the Second American Republic, The*, [22](#)  
 Six Day War, [185](#)  
 smallpox, [101–2](#)  
 Smith, Tony, [94](#)  
 social science: history as, [44–45](#), [51–52](#)  
 Sorel, Georges, [49](#)  
 South Africa, [117](#)  
 South Korea, [90](#), [119](#)  
 Soviet Union, [90](#), [142–43](#), [185](#); Bolshevik Revolution, [92](#), [97](#); China relationship with, [188–89](#); cooperation with U.S., [88](#), [89](#), [101–2](#), [117](#), [171](#). *See also* [Cold War](#)  
 spatial perspective, [180](#), [181–82](#)  
 Stalin, Joseph, [87](#), [88](#), [89](#), [95](#), [96–97](#), [133](#), [140](#)  
 statecraft: consequences of, [7–8](#); historical sensibility and, [14–15](#), [73–81](#); strategy and, [6](#)  
 states, [133–34](#)  
 Steinberg, James B., [56–57](#), [140](#)  
 storytelling, [24](#), [32](#)  
 Strategic Arms Limitation Treaty (1972), [116](#)  
 strategy: consequences of, [7–8](#); historical sensibility and, [14–15](#), [73–81](#); statecraft and, [6](#)  
 structural realism, [134](#), [153](#)  
 Stump, Al, [65](#)  
 Taiwan, [119](#)  
 Taylor, A. J. P., [74](#)  
 technology revolution, [126](#), [129](#)  
 temporal perspective, [180](#), [182–83](#)  
 test ban treaty, [117](#)  
 thinking historically, [10–15](#), [23](#), [40–41](#), [80–81](#); definition of, [10](#). *See also* [historical sensibility](#)  
 Third Balkan War, [191](#)  
 Thompson, Josiah “Tink,” [1](#), [2](#), [3–4](#); *Six Seconds in Dallas*, [1](#)  
 Thucydides: *History of the Peloponnesian War*, [6–7](#)  
 Thucydides’s Trap, [134](#)  
 time horizons, [132](#), [137–41](#), [146](#)  
 time lags, [160](#), [175–79](#)  
 tolerance, [65–66](#)  
 Tooze, Adam, [93](#)  
 Trachtenberg, Marc, [91](#), [145](#), [148](#)  
 trade, [126–27](#)  
 traditions, [54–55](#)  
 Truman, Harry S., [87](#), [89](#), [97](#), [105](#), [133](#), [152](#)  
 Turkish Straits, [88](#)  
 Ukraine, [166](#)  
 unipolar dominance, [122](#)  
 United States, [166](#); balance of payment deficit, [167–70](#); California, [128–29](#); cooperation with Soviet Union, [88](#), [89](#), [101–2](#), [117](#), [171](#); cultural revolutions in, [127–30](#); demobilization after World War II, [89](#). *See also* [Cold War](#)  
 unspoken assumptions, [66–67](#), [160](#), [172–75](#)  
 Updike, John, [2](#), [4](#)  
 vertical history. *See* [chronology](#)  
 vertigo, historical, [59–62](#), [154](#)

victimology, [57–59](#)  
Vietnam: China attack on, [189](#)  
Vietnam War, [39](#), [98](#), [107](#), [169–70](#), [171](#), [184–85](#), [188](#); escalation of, [152](#), [174](#); U.S. withdrawal from, [122](#)  
Voltaire, [202](#)  
  
Wallace, Henry, [152](#)  
Waltz, Kenneth N., [135](#), [148](#); *Man, the State, and War*, [133](#), [165](#)  
Warsaw Pact, [142](#)  
Wertheim, Stephen, [93](#), [94](#)  
Westad, Odd Arne, [92](#), [139](#)  
West Germany, [114](#), [168–69](#), [183](#)  
White House Council of Historical Advisers, [73](#)  
Wilhelm II, [163](#)  
Williamsburg, Colonial, [18](#)  
Wilson, Woodrow, [73](#), [97](#)  
Witt, Louie Steven, [2–3](#)  
Wood, Gordon S.: *Purpose of the Past, The*, [11](#), [75](#), [218 n.8](#)  
Woodward, C. Vann, [194](#)  
Woodward, Sir Llewellyn, [11](#), [50](#), [80](#)  
World War I: origins of, [26](#), [94](#), [151](#), [162–66](#), [172–73](#), [191–92](#)  
World War II, [94](#), [140](#)  
  
Xi Jinping, [83](#), [133](#)  
  
Yalta Conference, [87](#)  
  
Zelikow, Philip, [30](#), [34–35](#); “The Nature of History’s Lessons,” [219 n.22](#); “Why Did America Cross the Pacific?,” [144–45](#), [148](#)